THE PRICE OF MERCY

A Novel

Ken Follett

Warsaw · 1943

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PART ONE · THE NET

The Net

CHAPTER ONE

The Net

Warsaw — Thursday, 20 May 1943

The queue outside the bakery on Krucza Street began to form at half past four in the morning, and by six it was sixty people long, and Helena Wojtera was thirty-first in it, which meant that she would get bread and would not get much of it.

She had learned the arithmetic of hunger the way other people learned a language. The legal ration was two hundred grammes of bread a day, which was a joke the Germans told with a straight face. The black market wanted fifty zlotys for a kilo, which was not a joke at all, because fifty zlotys was two days of the money she earned teaching the violin to children whose mothers paid her in eggs, in lard, in glycerine soap, and once, memorably, in a jar of goose fat that had been hidden in a grave since 1939.

She stood with her hands in the pockets of her coat, because her coat had pockets and the woman behind her had a handbag, and a handbag was a thing that could be snatched by a boy on a bicycle, and the boys on bicycles worked for other boys who worked, in the end, for men who sold whatever they were given to whoever would pay. Warsaw in the third spring of the occupation was a city of very long queues and very short tempers, and the trick was to stand in the queue with your shoulders turned, so that nobody could see what you had and nobody could take it from you before you got home.

The woman in front of her was Pani Halina Rowińska, who lived on the same landing at Hoża 14 and who knew everything about everybody, and who had the news from her sister-in-law's cousin, who cleaned for a German family in Żoliborz.

"They say there's going to be an action," Pani Halina said. She said it the way she said everything, with the air of a woman handing out sweets. "A big one. Like January."

In January the Germans had closed the city for three days, and when they opened it again there were fifteen thousand fewer people in Warsaw, and the trams ran empty, and there was a silence in the courtyards for a week.

"They always say that," Helena said.

"They say this time they're taking the young ones. From the schools." Pani Halina looked sideways at her. "You should keep the child at home."

Helena said nothing. There was no arguing with Halina Rowińska, who was not a bad woman, only a woman with a mouth that ran like a tap, and in a city where a word could be worth a life, a running tap was a dangerous thing in a neighbour.

The baker, a small man with flour on his eyebrows and the look of a saint who has stopped believing, unlocked the door at six twenty and began to hand out bread through a gap the width of a hand, so that only one person at a time could reach it. When Helena's turn came she put down her money and her card and received a loaf the size of a boot, gritty and grey and slightly warm, and she put it inside her coat, against her stomach, and buttoned the coat over it, and walked away fast, because the last hundred metres from the shop door to her own gate were the most dangerous metres in Warsaw and everyone knew it.

Hoża Street was waking in the way of the occupied city: a tram grinding round the corner with three Germans sitting on the roof, a boy with a wooden box of cigarettes at the gate, an old man sweeping the gutter because the Germans had decreed that the pavements would be swept and the gutters swept and the city kept clean, and the Poles kept the city clean, and the Germans took photographs of the clean city for the newspapers in Berlin.

Number 14 had a courtyard with four acacias, a well, and an iron gate that Pani Zofia Mrożek closed at night with a key she wore on a string around her neck between her breasts, because a key on a string was harder to steal than a key in a pocket. Zofia was sixty-one and had been the caretaker's wife and then the widow of the caretaker and now she was the caretaker, with a broom and a tin badge and an air of authority that could stop a thief, a drunk or an officer of the Ordnungspolizei at ten paces.

She was at the gate when Helena came in, and she said, "You got bread."

"Two kilos."

"Then God exists." Zofia spat twice, for luck in a courtyard, and lowered her voice. "The child wanted to walk with you. I said no. She wanted to go to the market with you at noon, too. She's in the stairwell, playing again, with the window open. You'll hear her from the second landing."

Helena heard her from the gate, in fact: four bars, tenderly scraped, the same four bars over and over, with a wobble on the third that she had promised to fix and had not had the heart to fix, because the wobble was Marysia's, and Marysia was nine.

She went down the steps to the cellar first, the way she did every morning, with the loaf under her arm.

The cellar under Hoża 14 smelled of coal, damp plaster and a cat. Behind the coal bin there was a gap in the brickwork, and in the gap there was a cavity the size of a cupboard, and in the cavity, in a nest of old coats, there lived a girl of eight called Rachel Perel, who had been Renia Zielińska for three months, and who had not seen the sun since February.

Helena put her hand into the dark and the girl's fingers closed round hers, small and dry, like a bird's foot.

"Bread," Rachel whispered. It was not a question. In the cellar, everything was either bread or not-bread.

"Half. I'll come at noon if I can." Helena tore the loaf, and felt the two pieces, and gave away the larger. "There's a tin of milk behind the loose brick. If you hear them on the stairs, you go into the pipes. All the way down. You know."

"I know."

"There'll be a day," Helena said. "Not this week. But a day."

"Yes," Rachel said, in the voice of a child agreeing to a story she has heard too many times to believe and too many times to give up.

Helena went up the stairs, and on the second landing her daughter's violin stopped, and a face appeared round the door of their room: thin and brown and quick, with her father's eyes, which were grey, and her mother's mouth, which was wide and always ready to smile, and a brown plait down her back as thick as a rope because she had refused to have it cut since she was six.

"Did you bring it?"

"Look in my coat."

Marysia put in her hand and pulled out the loaf like a conjuror pulling out a rabbit. For a moment the two of them looked at it — two kilos of grey bread, a week of life — and then Marysia laughed, and Helena thought, as she thought

four or five times a day, that it was an obscenity to keep such a laugh in such a city, and an obscenity not to.

“Eat the crust,” she said. “Before Halina comes up and smells it. Then practice. Bar eleven, from the top. Slowly.”

“It’s horrible.”

“It is a very beautiful piece of music. It is not the piece’s fault that it is difficult.”

They said the same thing to each other almost every day, and it gave them both enormous comfort.

At noon, with the sun out and the day feeling like a normal day, they went to the market.

The fires across the wall of the Jewish quarter had gone out less than a week before, and the city still talked of nothing else; but on a Thursday the market at the corner of Krucza and Żurawia filled up with cabbage, sprouting potatoes, beetroot, a woman selling sunflower seeds by the glass, another woman selling shoelaces and old keys and a single boot, a man with a barrow of horse bones, and a crowd of two hundred people buying and selling and shouting the way crowds do when they are trying very hard to believe that an ordinary thing is happening.

Marysia carried the basket. She was tall for nine and liked to be trusted, and there was a fluttering in her shoulders whenever she was, like a bird deciding on a branch.

“Beetroot,” she reported. “That one wants thirty for the pair. That’s robbery.”

“It’s Tuesday.”

“It’s Thursday. She thinks because we’re from the other side of the street we don’t know the days.”

Helena had to laugh. Then she heard the whistles, two of them, near, from the direction of Bracka Street, and the sound of shutters coming down, and her stomach dropped as if she had stepped into a hole.

“Marysia,” she said. “The gateway. There. Go.”

The gateways were the only hope. There was a law of the łapanka, learned the hard way: at the first whistle you did not run. Running drew the eye. You walked like a person on an errand, and you went into a gateway, and you went through the gateway into the courtyards at the back, and if you were clever you went over a wall into the next street, and if you were lucky there was a man in the next street with a barrow and a coat you could put on.

The crowd turned into a hundred animals at once. A pregnant woman sat down in the middle of the pavement and screamed; a man with a barrow abandoned it and ran and was shot, in the leg, and fell and rolled, and the sight of it undid whatever remained of the arithmetic in the crowd and the street became water in a channel.

Helena took her daughter by the wrist and drove into a gateway, and through it, into a courtyard lined with the back walls of three buildings, where a boy was up on a wall already, holding his hand down to help, and behind them the crowd came in, and the courtyard had one exit and they were standing in front of it.

“No,” Helena said. “Not that way. Up.”

She was not strong but she was desperate, and desperate can carry a child up a coal-shoot to a low roof over a shed. They got to the shed roof as the first gendarmes came into the courtyard: green uniforms, boots, carbines held across the body, and behind them the Polish police in navy blue with their hands down and their eyes on the ground, and behind them the auxiliaries — the Ukrainians, in stained tunics, with a trident on their caps and dogs on chains — and the noise of forty people being sorted into a corner like washing.

A rope skipped across the tiles above her head and the boy on the wall said, “*Szybko, szybko* — fast — the other

roof.” He had a face like a ferret, one ear bandaged, maybe twelve years old, and he held the rope with both hands while Helena got her daughter over the ridge tiles and down onto the shed on the other side, which creaked under their weight like a ship.

Then the second whistle came, from the street in front of them, and Helena understood, with the terrible clarity of the trapped, that the Germans had not made one net, they had made two, and she had walked out of the first and into the second, and behind the shed there was only a wall and a drop of four metres, and the drop was full of gendarmes.

The boy said, “*Psia krew*,” and let go of the rope and ran along the ridge and was gone.

A German voice, very calm, said, “Kommen Sie herunter. Sofort.”

They came down. That was the thing Helena remembered afterwards, when she remembered anything at all: that her daughter came down first, because the jump was not so bad for a nine-year-old, and turned and lifted her arms to her mother, and a gendarme with a face like a boot laughed at that, and Helena, who had never in her life hit a man, wanted to kill him with her teeth.

Afterwards there were the lorries.

They were wood-burning lorries with great iron generators on the back, and the smell of them was the smell of burnt pine and hot iron, and they stood three of them nose to tail on Krucza Street, and the people taken were put into them with their hands on the shoulders of the person in front. A woman began the prayer for the dying, and another woman told her to be quiet, and ten minutes later everybody on the lorry was praying too, quietly, in the rain that had started, the first rain of the week, a fine grey drizzle that made the street look like a photograph of itself.

Marysia’s hand was in Helena’s hand, and Marysia’s mouth was closed tight, and the piece of beetroot she had bought, and the shilling change, and the basket, and the loaf of bread were all gone, and Helena’s mind was running through the empty rooms of what she had and what she could sell and who she knew, the way a hand runs along a wall in the dark.

“I’m not frightened,” Marysia said suddenly. “Are you?”

“No,” Helena said. That was the first lie.

“You’re squeezing.”

“I’m sorry.” She loosened her grip. “Listen. Say nothing. Answer nothing. If they ask, you are eleven.”

“Why eleven?”

“Because eleven is a worker and nine is a child, and children disappear.” She had heard it from Halina, from Zofia, from the woman at the pawnshop on Żelazna: the ones who were small, and fair, and orphaned-looking were sent to a room in a big building, and after the room, nobody. “Eleven,” she said again. “And your father is dead. He died before you were born. He was a Pole. Say it.”

“He was a Pole,” Marysia said. “He died before I was born.” She looked up. “What was his name?”

“Adam,” Helena said, as she had said a thousand times. “Adam Wójcik. He was a railway man. He was killed by a train, the month before you were born.” She said it in one breath, and it was not true in any particular, and she had never told the child a single false thing in her life except this one, and this one she had told so many times that it had the smoothness of the true.

The lorry crossed the river.

Helena saw the Vistula from the top of the load because she was near the tailgate and taller than the women around her: a brown river, and the pontoon bridge, and the Kierbedź bridge, and the tugs, and the far shore with its

warehouses and its chimneys, and the whole city on the left bank, dark and low, with a great bald patch in the middle of it where the ghetto had been, a place of cinders and broken wall and blackened emptiness the size of a small town. She had seen it from a rooftop, once, in April, when the distant firing went on all night and the sky over Muranów turned the colour of an apricot. She had not wept.

She wept now, and it was not about the raid.

The place they took them to was a school.

It was a real school, on Skaryszewska Street in Praga, built a few years before the war, three storeys of red brick and wide windows, and it still said on the wall over the door, in letters you could read through the paint, SZKOŁA POWSZECHNA NR 91. The Germans had turned it into a camp, and the camp had a name, the one everybody used, which sounded Polish and German at the same time: *dulag*, from the German word for going through.

They were counted in the yard. Then the men were taken to one side of the building and the women to the other, and there was a moment when Helena's hand was opened, and it was opened by a guard's stick, and she had a vision, very clear and very brief, of herself biting that stick into splinters — and then Marysia's fingers were let go, and were gone, and were in the crowd, and the child's voice called, "*Mamo!*" once, the way she had called when she was three and fell off the wall, and Helena screamed her name, and a man's hand came across her face and she stopped screaming, and the drizzle went on getting everything wet.

"How old?" a clerk asked in German, an hour later, in the line for the bath house, as women queued with their clothes in their arms and their ribs showing, and Helena answered "Eleven," and the clerk wrote it.

The bath house had tiled walls and twelve shower heads and one temperature, which was cold. After the shower the

women went through a room where their clothes hung on rails, and a man with a mask sprayed them with something that stank, and after that they were given back, damp, and Helena found her coat and her skirt and her blouse, and the loaf was gone, of course, and so was her purse, and so were her mother's earrings, which had been in the watch pocket, and she stood holding the coat, wet, in a room full of wet women, and she was, she found, more relieved than she had ever expected to be to be in the third and deepest circle of hell with her clothes on.

Then they cut their hair.

The women went into the next room with their heads held like queens and came out with their heads like the heads of hedgehogs, and the machine the Germans used buzzed and stopped, buzzzed and stopped, and the pile of hair on the floor grew to the size of a bonfire, and there was a boy with a broom whose job was to sweep it into sacks, because hair went to the Reich as well, hair went into mattresses and stockings and felt, and nothing that came through Skaryszewska went out of it unused.

Helena held herself straight for the razor and did not weep, and afterwards found that her hands were shaking so hard she had to tuck them into her armpits.

And then they brought the children.

They came in a line through the door from the yard, the small ones, and they were shorn already, all of them, boys and girls, and in a line of thirty shorn children it was, for a moment, impossible to know your own. Helena's eyes went along the line, quick, quick, quick, and did not find her, and the scream was already rising in her throat when a small hand closed round her wrist, and she looked down at a boy with a long neck and enormous grey eyes, and it was her.

Her plait was gone. Marysia held it, in her fist, folded, like a rope.

The look on the child's face was not fear and was not weeping. It was something older: the look of a person who has recently learned an important thing about the world.

"They did it with the big machine," Marysia said, quite calm. "It didn't hurt at all. The woman before me screamed and they laughed at her."

"Did they touch you?"

"They made us stand in a row with nothing on and a man walked along the row and counted us with a stick. He had a stick and he counted our heads. Then another man came and looked at our teeth."

Helena crouched and put her arms round her, and the wet, shorn head went onto her shoulder, and the child held the plait against her mother's back so that it would not be lost, and they stood like that in the middle of the room among the wet women and the rain and the smell of sabadyl, and Helena said, in Polish, quietly, into her daughter's ear, the only promise that she had left: "I am going to get you out of this."

She had no idea how. She had a violin and half a photograph and a name she had not said aloud in ten years, and none of those things was money, and money was the only language spoken in the third circle of hell.

The Wehrmacht came for the workers at four o'clock.

They came in a grey car and two lorries, and the officer who got out of the car was not old; he was about thirty, with a face that had been handsome before the war and was now merely competent, and a uniform that fitted him like a uniform should, and a leather map case, and a civilian interpreter, and the air of a man who has an appointment to keep and does not intend to miss it. The commandant of the camp came out to meet him and saluted and was not saluted back with any warmth, and there was a conference, and a list.

They were looking for hands. That was the thing that the Poles in the yard understood at once, in the way that prisoners understand everything at once: they were looking for hands, for metal-workers and fitters and carpenters and turners and seamstresses, because the Wehrmacht had workshops and the workshops had quotas, and a quota was a reason for a German officer to walk along a line of Poles in a wet school yard and look at their hands. Men held up their hands. Women held up their hands. An old man who had been a lathe operator at the PZO works was taken; a young man who had been a clerk said he was a welder and was taken, and would die for the lie or be saved by it, nobody could say; and Helena heard a woman behind her whisper, "*Ręce, ręce*" — hands, hands — and looked at her own hands, and thought about the violin, and the pads on the fingertips, and did not put them up, because the violin was a thing she had never sold.

The officer came down the line.

He walked slowly, with the clip of paper in his hand, and the interpreter beside him, and he said something to a woman about her card, and something else to a man about his trade, and his voice was a cool even voice with the north German vowels in it, and Helena, who was not looking directly at anything, heard it, and felt the whole world go quiet.

She looked up.

He was nine or ten paces away, in profile, his head bent to the clipboard, and the light was behind him so that the grey of his tunic and the grey of the sky were the same colour, and for a moment she had the illusion that she had seen him on the street a hundred times since the occupation and had simply failed to see him: the same height, the same shoulders, the same trick of standing with the weight on the left leg.

Then he turned his head, because the man beside him had said something, and she saw his face.

The world did not stop. That was the strange thing. She always thought afterwards that for a moment she had expected the world to stop, the way it does in the storybooks — the clock, the traffic, the rain in the air — and it did not: the rain went on falling, the count went on, a boy in the corner coughed with the sound of a boy who would not last the month, and Helena's heart went on beating so hard she could feel it in her wrists and her neck and her eyes.

Ten years. He had been twenty. He was thirty-one. There was grey in the temples that had not been earned by age. There was a scar, small, on the left cheek, that she had kissed once, in a garden, in Munich, in another century.

His eyes, going along the line of women the way an officer's eyes go along a line of women, stopped on her face.

Nothing happened in his face. It was, in its way, the most frightening thing she had ever seen, that nothing happened — no shock, no flush, only a stillness that went deeper than the stillness of a man at his work, and a muscle, in his jaw, once, moving.

The interpreter said something about the next woman. The officer did not move. A gendarme, seeing the pause, came forward and said something loud in German and pushed Helena back a step with the flat of his hand, and the officer said, in the voice of a man who has noticed nothing at all, "*Lassen Sie sie*" — leave her — and then, in the same flat voice, looking at her properly now, so that the interpreter wrote nothing down because there was nothing to write: "Follow me."

The room they took her to was the headmaster's office. There was a photograph of the headmaster's family on the

wall, upside down, and a cupboard full of the school's registers, and a desk with a green blotter, and a window with a view of the yard where the women stood in five rows with their shorn heads, and a Ukrainian auxiliary on the other side of the door with his rifle across his knees.

The officer stood with his back to the window, and looked at her, and said nothing for a long time.

"You have the advantage of me," she said at last, in German. Her voice came out steady, which surprised her. "I don't know how I should address you."

"You always did that," he said. He spoke German, but she heard the shape of the Polish words underneath, which he had tried to learn for her, in a cold room in Munich, with a grammar book and a hand in her hair. "You always put on the voice of a railway clerk's daughter from Żoliborz when you were frightened."

"My father was an engineer."

"He was." He looked down at the paper in his hand, and she saw, for the first time, that his fingers held it too hard. "Wojtera. Helena. Hoża 14. Music teacher. Born 1910." He read it the way a man reads a page he has read a hundred times already. "Do you have papers?"

"You took them."

"Of course." He put the paper down on the blotter, squaring its edges, an act of such ordinariness that she was suddenly, obscurely angry. "You have a child."

"I have a child."

"Nine years old, the clerk wrote. Or eleven." He looked up. "Which is it?"

The room was very quiet. Out in the yard someone was crying with the terrible monotony of a woman who has stopped being able to stop.

"Eleven," Helena said.

He looked at her for a long moment. Then he said, without any particular colour in his voice, as though he were reading the weather from the wall of a station: “In May of 1933 you were in Warsaw.”

“I was in Warsaw.”

“You wrote to me from Warsaw. Once.” He was not asking. “The letter said that your father was ill. The letter said that you would write again when you could. It came in the morning post on the twenty-eighth of May. I carried it in my tunic for a week, and then I wrote to you three times, and then my father told me what you had said to him, and what you had taken, and I—”

He stopped.

The silence went on so long that the auxiliary’s rifle butt moved on the floorboards outside and Helena flinched.

“You never wrote to me again,” she said.

“No.”

“I don’t know what your father told you.”

“I know what he told me.” He said it evenly. “I am not going to ask you who the child’s father is.”

“Then why am I here?”

“Because the clerk wrote nine,” Friedrich von Brandt said, “and in this building, nine is a leaf in a different drawer. Nine goes to the race office, and from the race office to a home in the Reich, and there is a family in Posen waiting for a girl like that, and the man who runs the race office here keeps a book with photographs in it.” He picked up the paper again. “Eleven goes to the labour list. Eleven goes, at worst, to a factory, where a clever girl can survive if she is strong and a cleverer one can survive if she is not.”

Helena put her hand on the edge of the desk. It was not dramatic; she simply could not stand without it.

“You are telling me to lie to you,” she said.

“I am telling you that the number in the register is a name that is mine to write, and that I wrote eleven, and that I am now going to sign it.” He did sign it. He took a pen from the inkstand and wrote her daughter’s name and a number, and the nib made a small sound on the paper like a fly against glass. Then he looked up, and his face was still nothing at all, a mask of administrative calm, and his eyes were the eyes of the young man in the dark in Munich, and that was the worst thing: not the cruelty of a German, which she had expected, but this, the tenderness of a man doing an ugly thing very carefully in order to be kind.

“Friedrich,” she said. She had not said the name out loud in ten years. She heard it leave her mouth and go into the room. It was like a coin thrown down a well; there is no telling, from the top, whether anything has disturbed the water.

He put the cap back on the pen.

“At the gate,” he said, “there will be a transport for the labour camp at four o’clock tomorrow morning, and your name will not be on it, and the child’s will not be, because you are a teacher, and the Reich needs teachers, and I need interpreters, and there will be a paper.” He laid his hand flat on the desk. “That is all.”

It was not all. It was not remotely all. But she saw his hand, and the hand was shaking, and on the pale inside of the fourth finger, where a wedding ring would not be, there was a mark, a thin white line, the mark of a ring worn for years and removed — and Helena, who was the only person in Warsaw who knew what that ring had looked like, because she had chosen it herself, in a shop on Sendlinger Straße in the spring of 1933, stood in the headmaster’s office with her shorn hair and her coat still damp through, and knew the worst thing of all.

He had understood her lie. He had understood it because he had been counting the years too, and the count had come out the same as hers, and he had signed the eleven on the paper and would now carry the nine, and the nine in the middle of his chest, for the rest of his life.

“At the gate,” she said. “Tomorrow. Yes.”

He turned to the window and looked out at the yard where the women stood in five rows with their heads like hedgehogs, and did not turn round when she was taken out, and Helena walked with the auxiliary back along the corridor, past the headmaster’s inverted family on the wall, past the room where the hair was swept into sacks, and she was thinking, with an accuracy that frightened her, about money, and the violin, and the tin box under the fourth floorboard, and how much time a man’s kindness could buy before it was collected with interest, and where in Warsaw in the spring of 1943 a person could go to find someone who knew how to make a child vanish and reappear alive.

CHAPTER TWO

The Man in Grey

Warsaw — Friday, 21 May 1943

They buried Leutnant Horst Peltz at eleven o’clock in the morning, in the corner of the Evangelical graveyard on Młynarska Street that the Wehrmacht had taken for its own, and it rained the whole time, a steady grey rain that made the black coats blacker and the white faces whiter and turned the soil they had dug into something the colour of coffee grounds.

Friedrich von Brandt stood in the third rank with his cap in his hand and the rain running off his hair and down the inside of his collar, and listened to the padre say what padres say.

He had known Peltz, in the way an officer knows a subaltern of his own regiment from peacetime: not well, but completely, because in the Seventh Cavalry everybody knew everything about everybody, and young Peltz had been a cheerful idiot who played the accordion badly and had once ridden into the regimental pond on a bet. He had been twenty-three. Eleven days ago a sniper had shot him through the throat as he walked along the edge of the burnt-out Jewish quarter with a clipboard in his hand, going to look at a building, of all things, and he had drowned in his own blood on the pavement of Bonifraterska Street while a sergeant tried to hold the wound shut with a field dressing.

At the graveside, Peltz’s company commander, a captain whose hands shook, tried to say something and could not,

and then read out a letter from the boy's mother, which was the closest thing to the truth that anybody in Warsaw that morning was permitted to say.

Friedrich looked at the coffin, at the tilted earth, at the brown puddles in the footmarks, and he did the arithmetic that soldiers do at funerals. Nineteen hundred and fourteen. His father a major at the Marne, thirty-one years old, with two sons already. Nineteen thirty-one, his own commissioning year. And now this, in a graveyard in a city that hated the ground he stood on, in the fourth year of a war that the family had greeted as the beginning of the family's third great chapter.

His father had said, when the Polish campaign ended: *Now, Friedrich, the map is being redrawn by men who understand that history is a matter of will. Be useful.* And Friedrich, who had wanted to be useful since he was eleven years old, had been very useful indeed: staff work, forms, quotas, requisitions, the war of paper that runs a war of iron. He had never fired his pistol at a man. He had never been shelled, except once, in the Ardennes, when the road ahead of him had been shelled and he had lain in a ditch wishing the mud were deeper. He had organized billets for eleven thousand men in France, and a rail movement of two armoured divisions in Poland, and he was, by any measure his profession used, a first-rate officer.

And what he had actually done, in the four years of this war, was to arrange for other people to be cold, hungry and afraid a little more efficiently than would otherwise have been the case.

He did not put it to himself in those words. He put it to himself in the useful phrase that his generation had taken from their fathers' mouths and polished until it shone: one did what could be done. But he had learned, since coming to Warsaw, that this phrase has a bottom to it. He learned it

first the previous summer, when the trains went east from the Umschlagplatz day after day and the city smelled of hot iron and lime, and he had said to himself, in the language of his class: *it is not my department.* Ulm had not been his department. Lidice had not been his department. The ghetto had not been his department, and the wall along Żelazna Street had not been his department, and the notices on the walls that named the men who had been shot at dawn for the crime of being Poles were not his department, and the fact that he could walk from his hotel to his office every morning through a city where a man could be shot for smuggling an egg, and feel *nothing much*, was the worst thing he had ever learned about himself, and he had learned it, as he learned everything, without ever saying it out loud.

Afterwards he went back to the office and dictated his report on the funeral, because his report on the funeral was expected, and then he dictated two letters that mattered and one that did not, and then he went to find Klara Seidler, who had the lists.

The commandant's office occupied the upper two floors of a pre-war insurance building on Nowy Świat, with a marble staircase, a brass lift cage that no longer worked, and a smell of wet wool and floor polish. Friedrich's own kingdom was the second floor, four rooms: his office, an outer office where Klara worked and where Oberzahlmeister Wollweber had a desk in the window, a map room, and a small room that was called, on the door, *Referat für Arbeitseinsatz* — the section for labour deployment — where two German clerks and one Polish typist worked under a lamp all day long on the great business of Warsaw under the occupation: the business of causing the right number of the right people to be in the right place at the right time, whether or not they wished to

be.

“Herr Major.” Klara Seidler stood up when he came in, which she always did, and which he had stopped asking her not to do, because it made her unhappy. She was twenty-eight, from Kassel, the daughter of a railway inspector, with pale eyelashes and a long neck and the flat, careful, tidy competence of a girl who had been brought up to be a secretary and had turned out to have been built by nature for something else entirely. She had been in Warsaw eleven months. She had a photograph of her parents on her desk and a photograph of nobody else, and she went twice a week to the German church on Szpitalna Street, and on the other five days she did things at her desk that Friedrich had never asked her to do and never once asked her about.

“The Skaryszewska list,” he said.

“On your desk, Herr Major. The commandant’s office wants the labour allocation confirmed by this evening. The Arbeitsamt claims we already have their quota, and Wollweber says we don’t. There is also the question of the twenty-two men from the Festungs-Pionier school, and Herr Doktor Böhm telephoned about the hospital laundry.”

“All of that can wait.”

Klara said nothing. She had learned, in eleven months, that “it can wait” was the sentence that preceded the interesting things.

Friedrich sat down at his desk, in the good chair, under the wall map of the General Government with its neat red pins, and put his cap down on the blotter and pulled the papers towards him.

It was a list. It was, by any measure, an ordinary list: the camp at Skaryszewska sent its intake register to the labour office at the end of every week, and the labour office sent a copy to the Referat für Arbeitseinsatz, because the Wehrmacht had first refusal on certain trades, and because

the Wehrmacht always needed hands, and because the hands in Warsaw belonged, by the rules of the occupation, to whoever in the German apparatus made the best claim on them first.

He read it the way he read all of them, at speed, running his pen down the columns — number, name, born, trade, disposition — and the names slid past him as they always did: Kowalski, Nowak, Wiśniewska, Zieliński, the four hundred names that Polish Warsaw endlessly produced. He stopped at forty, for a glass of tea, and went on.

241. Wojtera, Maria Anna. 3.12.1933. Warsaw. —

The pen stopped. He read the line three times, and then a fourth, and there was no change in it. The child of a Polish mother, born the third of December, nineteen hundred and thirty-three.

He put the pen down very carefully, as though it might go off, and sat quite still and did the arithmetic.

Thirty-six weeks before the third of December, 1933, is a morning in March.

He knew the morning in March. It was a Sunday, the twelfth, his twentieth birthday, and he had walked with her from the Isar along the gravel paths past the ice houses to the Englischer Garten, and she had been wearing a grey coat with a collar that buttoned up the throat, because she was always cold, and she had been laughing at him for something — he could not remember what, he could not remember what, and it made him want to pull the whole memory up out of the ground by the roots — and they had gone into the little pavilion by the lake, out of the wind, and stayed there while the light came down through the shutters in bars. He had been able to hear a band somewhere beyond the trees playing a waltz. He had unbuttoned the collar of her coat, one button at a time, and she had said his name, and after that neither of them had

said anything at all for a very long time.

The Isar. The lake. The pavilion and the band. The bars of light coming through the shutters, and the small brass ring her hair left on the pillow afterwards, and the cup of chocolate they had shared on the way home, and the way she had walked backwards away from him at the door of her uncle's flat, waving, and how she had been at the window when he turned round at the end of the street, and put her hand flat against the glass.

He had had the whole life in his head, then. He could see it now, still, if he let himself: a small house somewhere south of Munich, and a garden, and children with her hands and his eyes, and a piano, and the violin. He had been twenty years old and he had thought that a life was a thing you could choose. Nobody had told him that a life is a thing that other people choose for you, in a room you are not in.

Klara was standing in the doorway with a tray and the tea he had not asked for. He did not look up and after a moment she set the tray down on the corner of the desk and went out.

Friedrich put his hand flat on the paper, over the line, and held it there, the way one holds a hand over a wound.

The child had his eyes in the photograph. That was the thing he could not put down. He had seen the child for nine seconds across the yard of a transit camp with her head shaved, and she was thirty feet away and the rain was in the way, and he had seen his own eyes — the heavy lids, the set of the brow, his mother's eyes, the eyes of a woman who had been dead for eight years — in the face of a nine-year-old girl in a disinfected coat, and had refused to know what he knew.

He sat with that for a while. Then he did what he always did with a catastrophe: he considered the file.

There is a kind of man, and Friedrich had been one all his life, for whom the world's worst news arrives as a problem of administration. If the child is on the race office's list, then the race office's list must be altered, or the child must be removed from it, or the race office must be satisfied that the child is not what the list claims she might be. Every one of these was a thing a Major on the staff could, with care, arrange. Not one of them was a thing a Major on the staff could arrange for nothing.

He opened the drawer where he kept the Skaryszewska papers from the day before and took out the carbon of the dispositions sheet he had made on Thursday afternoon, and read it, and there in his own hand, in the neat column, was written:

Wojtera, Maria Anna, b. 3.12.33 — labour detail III (Sortierung), Skaryszewska, retained.

Which was, in Friedrich's grammar, a sentence meaning: this child will be kept in a basement in Praga sorting rags for the German army until somebody decides what to do with her.

And in the margin of the carbon, in the hand of the camp's office clerk, a pencil note, which he had not noticed yesterday because yesterday he had been looking at the mother's face:

Rassische Überprüfung beantragt? — racial examination requested?

Requested by whom? He turned the page. There was no name. There was only the small blue stamp of the camp administration, and, in the corner, a number, which was the number of a file at the office on Szucha Avenue, and the date, the twentieth of May, which was yesterday, which was the day he had stood in the yard in the rain and looked at a woman he had not seen for ten years and told himself that he was doing a hard thing well.

Somebody had been faster than he was. Somebody in Skaryszewska, or somebody in the labour office, or a clerk with a form, had seen a child of nine in a transit camp for adults and had done the thing the regulations required, which was to ask the question that the whole apparatus existed to ask, and the question had gone to the race office, and the race office would now ask its own questions, and it would ask them of the mother, and of the child, and of Friedrich von Brandt, whose signature was on the dispositions sheet, in ink, at the bottom of the page.

He put the papers down and stood up and looked out of the window at Nowy Świat, at the trams, at the people walking with their shoulders hunched, at the two boys who were standing on the corner selling newspapers whose mastheads were printed in German, and he thought, with a clarity that had been a long time coming: *there it is. That is what a wall looks like from the inside.*

He had spent ten years being careful about Helena Wojtera. He wanted to believe that he had been careful for her sake. He had, on the fifth of June, 1933, gone to his father in the study at Falkenhorst, the study with the map of the old Prussian provinces on the wall and the smell of cigars and cold ash, and told him that he intended to marry a Polish violinist from Warsaw who had no money and no family and no religion worth speaking of, and his father had listened with his hands folded and his eyes half shut, and then had explained to him, kindly, with the patience of a man explaining the multiplication tables, what that decision would cost — his commission, his name, his allowance, his mother's memory, his sister's marriage, the estate — and what it would cost the girl, who was, after all, a foreign national, and whose residence in the Reich depended on the signature of a police official who took his coffee with the Generalmajor's adjutant on Thursdays.

And Friedrich, twenty years old, who had thought a life was a thing you could choose, had said that he would manage it, and had gone back to Munich with a plan, and his father had reached the girl first.

That was the part Friedrich had never been able to make into a story he could live in. Not the ultimatum; ultimatums were a father's trade. The part was the letter.

It had come to him in Munich on the first of July: four lines, no address, in her handwriting, which he could have recognized in the dark of a cellar; it said that she had been mistaken in her feelings, that she had accepted the sum the Generalmajor had offered her for a passage home and the settlement of her uncle's debts, that what had happened between them had been an autumn and a winter of a young girl's foolishness, and that he was not to write to her again.

He had not believed it. He had gone to Warsaw. That was the thing he had never told anyone: he had got thirty-six hours' leave in September 1933 and gone to Warsaw with eighty marks in his pocket and stood in a courtyard on Hoża Street under her windows, and had not gone up. He had stood there for an hour like a man in a novel, in the rain, and then he had gone back to the station and got on the train, because — and this was the kernel and the shame of it, the thing he had been running from for ten years — because he had half believed the letter, and because his father's version of the world was the only one he had ever been taught to read, and because if the letter was true then he had been a fool, and if the letter was false then he had to choose between his father and the whole architecture of his life, and he was twenty years old, and he chose the architecture.

He had put her out of his mind the way a man puts out a lamp: by turning away from it. And in the years that followed, in the horse shows and the mess dinners, in Paris

in the spring of 1940 with the army, at a hotel in Bad Nauheim in the summer of 1937 where the families had got together and where he had met Erika von Wense, who was thirty-two and patient and good with her hands, and where the match had been settled over two dinners by three old people who had known each other all their lives — in all those years, when the thought of Warsaw came to him, it came as a small room in the dark that he did not open.

And then in September 1939 he had ridden into Poland behind the guns, at the head of a column of the Seventh, and when he saw the name of the city on a signboard outside Błonie he had actually smiled, because the whole thing had seemed, for one appalling half-hour, like a kind of homecoming.

He turned away from the window.

"Herr Major?" Klara, in the doorway.

"Have the car brought round. I'm going to Praga."

"The Arbeitsamt at two —"

"My apologies to the Arbeitsamt."

Klara's pencil stayed still over her notebook for a moment, and then she said, "Very good, Herr Major," and went out, and Friedrich heard her telephone the motor pool in the flat voice she kept for the telephone, and then heard her say, more quietly, to somebody in the outer office, "*Nein. Nichts.* Nothing."

They drove east along the avenue and over the bridge, with Kellner at the wheel, Gefreiter Bruno Kellner, forty-one years old, a Berlin grocer who had been called up in 1941 and who had made it his life's work since then to keep a fat man's amiable competence between himself and the war. He drove the Opel with the easy slowness of a man who has learned that there is no profit ever in arriving first, and he had an enormous red face and a certificate in his pocket that said he had a weak heart, and Friedrich had

never once asked him whether it was true.

"To the school, Herr Major?"

"To the school."

The Vistula went past, brown and flat under the rain, and the far bank came up with its warehouses and its chimneys and its own wet grey streets, and Kellner said, conversationally, "Praga's better off than the other side. The bread's cheaper. It's the river, you see, the smugglers use the river. It's always the same, Herr Major: wherever there's water, there's a way round the law."

"You sound as though you approve, Kellner."

"I'm a grocer, Herr Major," Kellner said, deadpan, looking at the road. "All men who approve of nothing starve."

The camp at Skaryszewska had, since Thursday, grown. There was another hundred metres of wire along the front of the school, and a second tower going up at the corner, flat brown scaffold boards and a man with a welding torch, and two lorries with their tailgates down in the yard and a work party of Poles loading them with sacks. The smell was the smell of any place in Europe in 1943 where four thousand people are kept waiting: disinfectant, unwashed cloth, urine, boiled cabbage, and the sweetish undertone of something that Friedrich's mind refused to name and which was, in fact, mostly the rain and the lime.

At the gate a Ukrainian auxiliary looked at his pass, then at him, then at the pass again, and then went for the commandant's clerk, because there was a protocol in these things, and the protocol had to be observed even at the third circle of a transit camp on a Friday in May.

The commandant was SS-Untersturmführer Oskar Bierbaum: twenty-nine years old, from Ludwigshafen, with a whippet's face and a bureaucratic sacredness, and a great appetite for paperwork, and, Friedrich noticed again,

exactly the kind of shined boots that a boy wears to the first day of a new job he intends to keep for many years.

“Herr Major. An honour. We don’t see the Wehrmacht often.” Bierbaum’s office was the chemistry laboratory of the school; there were still a few bottles in a cupboard with the labels turned to the wall, and a periodic table on the blackboard with one name rubbed out. “Coffee? I have real coffee. There’s a circumstance.”

“Thank you, no. I came about the labour allocations.”

“Of course. The allocations.” Bierbaum sat down and folded his hands on his desk like a man in a painting. “We meet our quotas, Herr Major. Forty per cent of intake to the Arbeitsamt for the Reich, thirty per cent to the General Government works, twenty per cent to your workshops and the Ostbahn and the hospital services, ten per cent retained for the camp. The Arbeitsamt sent a lawyer last month to complain that we were — they said ’over-counting’ the retained category. I invited him to count with me. He counted. He has not written again.” He smiled; his teeth were small and even, and there was a boyish cruelty in the smile that made Friedrich’s stomach turn. “We all have our battles, Herr Major. Yours is theatre, mine is ammunition. Wait, no — you’re not the theatre people. The billets. The workshops. What is it that you need?”

“I need to be sure of the camp’s retained list. My office is being asked questions by the commandant’s office about the quality of the hands we are being sent, and I would rather answer them with a signature than with a shrug.”

“You may have any signature I possess,” Bierbaum said, and rang the bell, and the whole thing took twenty minutes, and Friedrich left the office with a carbon copy of the retained list under his arm, having looked into the eyes of an SS officer for twenty minutes and said nothing at all about anything that mattered.

In the yard the work party was loading sacks. A row of women stood against the wall of the school's west wing, waiting for something — the food queue, the latrine, the bath house, Friedrich never knew, and never asked, because asking was not a thing one did, and by not asking he remained a decent man for one more day.

She was fourth in the row.

He had not expected to see her. He had come for a piece of paper; he had told himself that on the bridge and had believed it approximately. She was standing with her back against the wall and her eyes closed and her face turned up a little, and the rain was falling on it, and there was a bruise high on her cheekbone that had not been there yesterday, and her hair — the shorn hair was growing already, or had been growing for a week before the razor, and in the rain it was dark and flat against her head and made her look about sixteen. She was holding a piece of bread in one hand and there was a woman asleep against her shoulder, and the two of them were propped against the damp brick like two people on a station platform, and Friedrich stood thirty feet away in the middle of the yard with a driver behind him and a list under his arm and a great many people for whom he was responsible, and looked at her for the space of four breaths.

He did not go to her. That was the choice he made, standing in the mud of the schoolyard, and he made it in the full knowledge of what it was, which was the only courage available to him: if he walked to her there, in front of the Ukrainians and the work party and Bierbaum's window, then he was not a Major on the staff with an interest in a labour allocation; he was a German officer who had gone to a transit camp to stand beside a Polish woman, and in this city, in this year, that was a thing that men died for, and — worse, infinitely worse, and this was the thought

that turned him round like a hand on his shoulder — the child would die for it first.

So he walked to the gate. And at the gate, because he was who he was, and because a certain kind of Prussian cannot leave a scene without tidying it, he stopped and said to the auxiliary, in German, in the flat voice of a man disposing of a minor matter: “The labour detail Three. The children. They are to be kept at sorting work until further instruction. No transfer, no transport, and no examination of any kind without the written order of the commandant’s office. My office. Understood?”

The auxiliary did not understand, or did not care, and the clerk at the gate understood enough to write it in the book, and Friedrich got into the car and Kellner drove him away over the bridge through the rain, and all the way back up the avenue Friedrich stared out of the window at the wet city and thought about a card index, and about a stamp with a file number on it, and about how much of his life, from this hour, was going to consist of reaching across the desk of other men to alter papers.

At the office there was a message in Klara’s careful hand: *The race office telephoned at 15.20 regarding retained list No. 3. Obersturmführer Dörffel’s office, Szucha, requests the file on the Wojtera case. Referred to you. The Obersturmführer asks whether the Herr Major has an interest in the case.*

He read it twice, standing in the doorway in his wet coat, and then he said, “Who took the call?”

“I did, Herr Major.”

“Then you know what to write.”

Klara’s pen was still. “I am not sure I know what to write, Herr Major. That is why I gave you the message.”

Friedrich looked at her, at the pale, flat, careful face under the lamp, at the photograph of her parents on the

desk, at the little silver church pin from Szpitalna Street on the collar of her blouse. She was, he understood suddenly, one of the very few people in the General Government who had kept her hands clean, and she had just discovered that keeping her hands clean was a job like any other, with its duties and its hours.

"You write," Friedrich said, "that the Wojtera case falls under the labour jurisdiction of the commandant's office. You write that the file will be forwarded when it has been completed, in the ordinary course. And then you will make a note in the diary and you will not say another word about it to anyone, ever, including Wollweber."

"Yes, Herr Major."

"And Klara." He had never used her first name before, and they both heard it, and it changed the temperature of the room. "Noted the date and the time of the call, and who asked. That is a matter of record. I have learned, in this war, that the only thing a German officer can do for a Pole is be scrupulous with the paper."

Klara Seidler looked at him for a moment with her pale, flat, careful eyes, and then she wrote, and the nib scratched, and outside on Nowy Świat the rain went on falling on a city that had sixty thousand people under sentence of one kind or another in the drawers of its thousands of offices.

Friedrich went into his own room and shut the door and stood with his forehead against the cold of the window and looked down at the wet street, where a small boy was running with a package held against his chest, and a tram was shrieking round the corner, and a German military policeman had stopped a woman to look at her papers, and the woman was smiling, the way they all smiled, the smile that had no bottom to it, the smile the city had invented and called *the Polish face*.

And he thought about what he had told her nine years ago in a pavilion in the Englischer Garten while a band played somewhere behind the trees: that he would never be like his father. And he thought, for the first time without flinching, about the fact that a child had been born in Warsaw on the third of December, 1933, and that the sum of all his father's careful cruelty, all his own careful cowardice, and all his family's careful pride, was shut in a schoolyard in Praga with a number after her name and a stamp on her card, and that the only currency he had left in the world, the only currency anyone in Warsaw had, was paper.

CHAPTER THREE

Hoża Street

Warsaw — Saturday, 22 May 1943

At six in the morning they were counted in the yard, and at half past nine a clerk came out of the school with a clipboard and began to read names, and Helena Wojtera heard her own name read out in the flat German of a man who had read four hundred names that week and would read four hundred more, and she stepped forward, and it was over in eleven seconds: a card, a pass, a rubber stamp on the back of her hand, and a voice telling her to stand by the west gate, she was going out with the eleven o'clock.

She said, "My daughter is here. Wojtera, Maria Anna, labour detail three."

The clerk looked at his list. "Detail three remains."

"I am her mother."

"Detail three remains." He had a small scab on his lip and he picked at it while he spoke, the way a man picks at a thing that is not his business. "You will be at the hospital laundry, Wiejska Street, six to six. You will report with the card. Next."

The woman behind her in the queue was called Dorota Rybak, and she had a son of fifteen in the men's block, and she said, from the side of her mouth, without moving her lips, "Take what they give you. Don't ask twice. Asking twice is how my sister went to Ravensbrück."

They let her see the child at the west gate for the length of time it takes a man to smoke a cigarette and a half.

The west gate opened onto the yard behind the school, where the coal heap was and the sheds, and there was a wire fence along the inside, waist-high, and the children in the sorting detail were brought past it in a line on their way to the basement, and the guard with the cigarette leaned on the fence post and watched the wall of the building and did not watch the two of them, which was the only mercy anybody in the place could offer and which Helena understood to be worth more than gold.

Marysia had a smear of dirt down one cheek and her shorn head was covered with a grey rag tied in a knot at the back, which she had done herself, Helena could see at once, with exactly her father's stubbornness, to stop the other children laughing at the hedgehog heads. There was a scratch on her forearm and a bruise the size of a plum on the back of her hand. She was holding a bread crust in her fist and she had eaten half of it and had saved half.

"Give me your hand through the wire," Helena said.

"It's all right. It's only on the other side of the wire anyway." The child put her hand up, and Helena took it, and it was small and cold and gritty, and the two of them stood with the wire between them like people at a railway station in a film.

"They're sending me out this morning," Helena said. "To a laundry, on the other side. It's a pass. I can come back — I can bring things — I'll come every day if they let me."

"You can't come every day. They'll hit you."

"I've been hit before."

"Not by them." Marysia looked at her with her father's eyes. "Don't come every day. If they think we're interesting, they'll look at us. If they don't think anything, they'll forget us. That's the best thing in here, being forgotten."

Helena heard her own voice coming out of the child's mouth, and had to look away for a moment, at the coal

heap, at the shed, at the wet grey wall.

"Who told you that?"

"Pani Rybak. Her son says the ones they remember are the ones they send." Marysia's grip on her fingers was very tight, and she said, quickly, in a low voice, looking at the ground, "Mamo, I need things. Don't bring bread, they take it at the gate and sell it. Bring a pencil. Bring two pencils, one for me and one for Fela — she's three, she can't talk yet, she just holds the pencil and makes a noise, it's the only thing that stops her crying. Bring sewing thread, white, and a needle, because if you can sew you're a worker and they keep workers. And if you can, and if it isn't dangerous, bring the little case." The little case was the violin case. Marysia's violin, three-quarters size, had been left at the Szymanowski school when the Germans closed it, and had spent two years in the pawnshop on Chmielna, and had come home in 1941 because Helena had sold her mother's ring to get it. "Not for playing," the child said, urgently. "Because a girl who can play the violin is a girl who is worth something to somebody, and when they come to see who to keep, I want to be the girl who can play."

The guard threw down his cigarette and stepped on it.

"Two minutes," he said, in bad Polish.

"Two minutes," Helena said. She looked at her daughter and there was no time to say any of the things she had been composing in her head since Thursday: that she loved her, that she was going to get her out, that there was nothing in the world she would not do.

So she said: "Bar eleven. From the top. Slowly."

And Marysia laughed — a shout of a laugh, right there at the wire, in the yard of the transit camp at Skaryszewska, with the guard and the coal heap and the rain and the four thousand people — and Helena walked out of the west gate with her chin up and her hands in her pockets and her own

hair shorn and a pass to the left bank, and she did not turn round, because turning round was one of the things the child had told her not to do.

She walked across the pontoon bridge with a crowd of workers, because the tram took Germans and the tram was therefore a trap, and the bridge was long and the water under it was brown and there were gulls sitting on the pontoons like gulls in peacetime, and on the other side Warsaw came up out of the river slowly, street after street, Krakowskie Przedmieście, Nowy Świat, and the whole city was grey and neat and full of posters: *KRIEGSWEIHNACHT*, *GESUNDHEIT*, *EINE STUNDE FÜR DIE EWIGKEIT*, and over them all, pasted fresh that week so that the paste still shone, the notice that named the men shot at dawn on Tuesday in the ruins of the ghetto, fifteen names, in Polish and in German, with a line at the bottom that said that further offenses would be met with the same severity.

The same severity. Helena walked past it. In Warsaw, in 1943, you walked past the wall with the names on it and you did not stop, because stopping was a signal, and reading was a signal, and there were men who stood at the corners and watched for signals; but in another part of the head, behind the eyes, you read the names anyway, the way a person reads a gravestone in the dark, and you counted them, always, the way a woman counts stitches.

At Hoża 14, the courtyard was loud with washday. Four women at the well with their skirts tucked up and their arms red to the elbow, and one old man carrying a copper of hot water, and two boys up on the shed roof because it was Saturday. And when Helena came through the gate, one by one the arms stopped moving, and the courtyard went quiet in the way courtyards do when a person comes back from a place where people do not come back from.

Pani Halina Rowińska said, “Jesus and Mary,” and crossed herself with a wet hand, and then, at once — she could not help it, it was her nature, and her nature had been the ruin of people before — she said, “Your hair. *Mój Boże*, your hair. Where is the child?”

Helena walked across the courtyard without answering.

Zofia Mrożek came out of the caretaker’s door with a broom in her hand and stood in front of her, and looked at her, up and down, at the shorn head and the camp smell and the pass and the wet coat; and then, without a word, she opened her arms, and Helena went into them like a child, at last, there in the middle of the courtyard in front of everyone, and Zofia held her and did not ask a single question, and over Helena’s shoulder she said, to the courtyard, in the voice she used for rent and for the water supply and for closing gates at curfew: “The washing’s gone cold, ladies. Boys, if you’re on that roof when I come out with the stick you’ll come off it. Halina, make tea, and use the real tea, not the carrot, or I’ll know why.”

In the caretaker’s kitchen, with the good tea and the smell of onions, Helena told her.

When she came to the part about the child being kept, Zofia put both her hands flat on the table, the way a person braces against a door, and she did not speak for a long moment. Then she said, “So you’re out and she’s in.”

“Yes.”

“That’s not an accident, Helena.” Zofia’s eyes were old and pale and very hard. “When the Germans let one out and keep the other, they’ve made a decision. Something about that child interests somebody. Now.” She held up her hand before Helena could speak. “Don’t tell me. I don’t want to know; and if I don’t know, my face can’t say it, and there are men in this city who read faces better than they read Polish. What I know, I’ll help you with. What I don’t know, I

can’t lose. That’s how we live now. You understand?”

“I understand.”

“Good.” Zofia got up and turned to the stove so that her back was to her, which was how that generation of women granted permission for the telling of unbearable things. “Then tell me your plans, and I’ll tell you which ones are stupid.”

At noon, she went down to the cellar with a piece of the real tea and half a loaf and a small tin of milk she had got from the janitor of the Szymanowski school in exchange for nothing but a favour to be named later, and sat down on an upturned box in the dark behind the coal bin, and there was a long silence before Rachel Perel put out her hand.

“You came.”

“I came.”

“Is Marysia with you?”

Helena had rehearsed this. She had rehearsed it all the way home over the bridge, on the tram tracks, past the names on the wall: that she would say *she’s with her aunt*, that she would say *she’s gone to the country*, that a child of eight in a cellar needed a smooth lie that would carry her through the weeks, and she opened her mouth to say it, and instead, into the coal-smelling dark, she said the truth.

“They took her. On Thursday, at the market, in a round-up. She’s in a camp in Praga, and I’ve been let out, and she’s still in.”

There was silence. Helena heard the girl’s breathing, quick, and then the small sound of her moving the tin so that it stood upright in its nest of coats, and then, in a voice that was eight years old and forty years old at once:

“Aunt Zofia says you mustn’t cry in the courtyard. You can cry down here. There’s no one down here but me and the mice, and the mice don’t tell anyone.”

Helena Wojtera, who had not wept at the wire, and not on the bridge, and not in Zofia's arms, sat in a coal cellar with a loaf of bread in her lap and wept, and a Jewish child in a Polish nest put out one hand and patted her arm, in the dark, with small steady pats, three or four of them, and then took a crust of the bread, because she was hungry, and crying did not fill the belly, and there was not much bread.

That afternoon the queue at the pawnshop on Żelazna had twenty people in it, and Helena stood in it for two hours, and it was in the pawnshop that Warsaw's information market was at its thickest, because a pawnshop is one of the few places in a starving city where people have to talk about what things are worth.

She learned, in those two hours, the following:

That the Arbeitsamt at Skaryszewska was paying nothing at all and taking everything, and that a family in Ochota had been emptied of four sons in three weeks.

That the Gestapo at Szucha had opened a new department for the "Jewish question on the Aryan side" and that the price of silence had gone up twice since Easter.

That the price of a labour exemption — a real one, a stamp with a signature and a counter-signature, a *Familienausweis* — was between four and six thousand zlotys, or gold of equivalent weight, or an introduction to somebody whose name you were not to ask aloud; and that the man to see was a German official at the Arbeitsamt called Böhm, whom everyone called *Doktor* on account of nobody knew what, and who drank his coffee at the Europejski on Tuesdays and Fridays at eleven.

That a woman three places ahead of her in the queue, who had been in Skaryszewska for eleven days in March, had got her son out by proving that he was the sole support of a widowed mother with tuberculosis, and the proof had

cost her a cow that she did not own and a doctor's paper that cost three hundred zlotys, and the boy had been out for three weeks and had been taken again on Tuesday, at night, at home, on a new list.

And that the children in the camps, the small ones, the ones with no parents left alive or no parents who could claim them, were taken away in a different kind of lorry to a different place, and stayed for a while in a house on a street nobody would name, and were then sorted — the word they used, this woman said it in a whisper, because she had learned it from a German, and German words had made it real — sorted by race.

"That's not real," a man behind them said, loudly, the way men who are afraid talk. "That's not true. They don't do that."

"They do it in Poznań," said the woman. "They do it wherever they've decided to make us into Germans. There was a woman on Wolska, her boy was taken, she went to every office in Warsaw with his photograph, and they told her at Szucha that the boy had been found to be of German blood and was being brought up as a German, and when she made a scene they told her that if she made a scene again, they would consider her an enemy of the German people, and she was an enemy of the German people, because she was Polish, and so she stopped. She stopped three years ago. She still keeps his shoes."

Helena's own business in the pawnshop was small: her father's watch, a Błonie, nickel, with a chipped enamel face, worth, the man behind the counter said, two hundred and forty zlotys, or a hundred and ten if she wanted it in her hand and not on a ticket; and her mother's gold ring, which, since it was gold, was worth more than the man was prepared to say at once, which is how Helena knew that the man was lying and that the ring was worth perhaps seven

hundred; and the man in the black coat at the end of the counter, buying, not selling, who watched her hands with his chin in his collar, and whom she would remember later, when it mattered, as the man from the pawnshop.

She took the hundred and ten, and kept the ring, and as she put the ring back into the hem of her coat she felt, through the cloth, the small square hardness of the photograph, and something happened in her chest that was like a key turning in a lock in a house that had been left empty for years.

Six thousand zlotys, she thought. *And behind the money, a German who drinks coffee at the Europejski on Tuesdays and Fridays at eleven.*

She walked home the long way, because the long way went past the welfare office on Marszałkowska, and outside the welfare office there was a queue of a different kind: women with prams, women with children by the hand, women with the printed yellow cards of the RGO — the welfare council, the only Polish institution the Germans had let stand, because it was useful to them; and among those women, in a grey coat with a red cross armband, moving along the queue with a clipboard, asking a question here and there, stopping to write something down, was a heavy-faced woman of forty with her hair cut short and boots like a man's: Wanda Ostrowska.

Helena had met her twice, three years before, at the Szymanowski school, on a committee that had raised money for the families of prisoners and had dissolved itself when a member was arrested.

"Pani Wojtera," Wanda said. She had a memory like a filing cabinet and had not been given a single chance to use it. "The violin teacher. Your daughter's the little one with the plaits."

“She hasn’t got the plaits any more,” Helena said, and watched Wanda’s face go still, and then said, quickly, quietly, standing at a tram stop with her hand on the pole, “She’s in Skaryszewska. Detail three. Since Thursday. I’m out. They let me out and kept her.”

Wanda did not react. That was the first thing Helena noticed about her: that no news, however bad, changed her face; the face stayed ordinary while the mind behind it turned over, at great speed, like a machine in a factory.

“Have you been told anything?”

“Nobody has told me anything. The clerk said detail three remains, and one woman in the pawnshop told me they sort them by race, and this morning a man in the street said something about a train to Rassenpolitik —”

“Ssh.” Wanda’s hand closed on her forearm, hard. “Not here. Two hundred metres. The courtyard behind the shop with the yellow sign. Five minutes.”

The courtyard behind the shop with the yellow sign had a well, a cat, and a litter of bricks; and leaning against the wall of it, in the rain that had started again, the welfare worker talked to the violin teacher as if she were giving her a lesson: quietly, evenly, in the tone of a doctor giving a diagnosis to a patient who is going to need all her strength to hear it.

“This is what happens to children who are taken without their parents, if nothing is done,” Wanda said. “They are processed at the labour office. They are washed and fed and put to light work in a German office, because a fed child is a presentable child. Then a commission comes from the racial office in Posen, and a man looks at the child with calipers and photographs, and asks the child’s height and the shape of the skull and the colour of the eyes, and asks the mother — if there is a mother — questions about the family that go back three generations. If the child passes,

the child is a German. They give the child a German name and a German family, usually in the Warthegau, usually a family with no children, and the child is not told. Many of these children do well. That is the terrible part: many of them are happy. The Polish girls who were taken from here in 1941 are fifteen now, and they sing German songs, and they don't remember their mothers." Wanda looked at her. "If the child fails — if the mother refuses to cooperate, or the blood is wrong, or the file is inconvenient — the child goes to labour. Labour for a child of nine means a farm in the Reich, and the farms in the Reich are not all the same, and the ones they send the children to are not the good ones."

"You are telling me there is no way out."

"I am telling you that there are three ways out, and you will not like any of them. The first is money: a labour exemption from the Arbeitsamt and a paper that says the child is a skilled worker in Warsaw in a reserved trade. That takes about six thousand zlotys and an official's signature, and it works until somebody looks at the file, and then it does not work.

"The second is hiding. The child comes out — maybe, if we can buy somebody at the camp gate, maybe if the child gets sick enough that a doctor sends her to the hospital, and from the hospital they lose her. Then the child goes to a house in the country, with false papers, and you never see her again except by arrangement, and if she is ever recognized, the farmer who took her is shot, and the village that knew is burned. I have buried people who tried the second way. Some of them are alive in the countryside right now and will never come back to Warsaw.

"The third way is the one nobody takes." Wanda's eyes were steady on hers. "If the child has a German father, then the file changes. Acknowledge the father and the child

leaves the racial list; she becomes a case of *Abstammung* of a serving officer of the Wehrmacht, a scandal, a file for the Reich Security Office. It means a court-martial for the father: forbidden contact, racial defilement, in wartime, in an occupied country; at best a demotion and the Russian front, at worst a wall. It means the child is taken from you in a different way: at best made a German, at worst made nothing, and mixed-blood cases in the Reich are a file the doctors argue over for years. And it means, Pani Wojtera, that you would be signing the death warrant of the man you named, and I have never in three years of this work met a Polish woman who was willing to do that, and I have met many Polish women who were willing to do anything at all."

Helena stood in the wet courtyard behind the shop with the yellow sign and felt the world tilt, very slightly, like a table with one short leg.

"It is not a German father," she said. "It is the lodge secretary's son from Nowogrodzka and he died of typhus in 1939."

"Yes," Wanda said. She did not believe it. "Most of the time, it's not a German father. Most of the time it's a labour exemption or a hiding place. Come to me on Wednesday; the office is open on Wednesdays and I can put your name on a list for the Zamość children's fund, which gives you a right to buy milk at the depot, which is something. And Pani Wojtera —"

"Yes?"

"You are going to need an ally inside the German apparatus. Every case that has ever come out of Skaryszewska alive has come out because some German clerk needed something at the same time, and there was a trade. Not a betrayal necessarily — a trade. A signature for a signature. You have a face that men look at and a German that Rybak's wife says is better than the clerks'.

Somewhere in that building on Nowy Świat there is a man with a paper in his hand and a reason to move it, and if you find him you must not waste him, and you must not trust him, and you must never, ever write his name down."

That evening, Tomek came.

He came at the curfew hour, which was when he always came, because a tram conductor's shifts were arranged by a man who knew what Tomek did with his evenings, and he came up the back stairs and knocked on Helena's door with the pattern of a neighbour, two and one, and he came in with his cap in his hand and his coat collar up and the smell of the tram on him, oil and wet wool and the smoke from the generator.

Tomasz Mrożek was twenty-four years old and he had his mother's flat wide face and a slow way of moving that was partly a manner and partly a warning to anyone who thought that slow meant soft. He had been at the university when the university closed. He had been a boy with a cello when he was sixteen, and Helena had taught him for a year and had told his mother, privately, that he had no gift, and it had been the only unkind thing she had ever said about him, and he had found out, and had never once mentioned it, and had brought her coal in January from a place he never named.

"You're out," he said.

"I'm out. She isn't."

He stood in the middle of the little room with his cap in his hands and said nothing for a while, and then he said the thing that she had not let herself hear from anyone else that day, because he was the only person in Warsaw who could say it without it being a consolation: "Then we'll get her out."

And because he said it simply, as a statement of fact, and because he was, she knew, a person who was in the habit of

making true statements about impossible things, Helena Wojtera put her hands over her face and stood in the middle of her own room and heard the whole day come out of her at once.

Tomek did not touch her. He waited until it was over, and gave her his handkerchief, which was clean, which she noted even then, and which he would want back.

“There are three things,” he said, when she was quiet. “First: the camp. There’s a nurse at the infirmary in Skaryszewska who has helped us twice — she certifies people unfit for transport and they get moved to the hospital on Jagiellońska, and once they’re in a hospital bed they’re a different kind of problem. Second: papers. I know a printer who does baptismal certificates for children, very good ones, for two thousand zlotys, which is robbery, but he doesn’t drink and he’s never been caught. Third — and this is the one that isn’t mine to say — there’s a man in the labour office. Our people call him the Loaf, because he sold us a list once with the names of the ones he was about to take, and we got to eleven of them before the lorries came. He’s German. He’s a Hauptmann or a Major or something, in the workshops. In the Referat, on Nowy Świat.”

Helena said nothing. Her face was, she hoped, doing what Zofia’s face did: nothing at all, in the dark, in a room with the lamp turned down.

“Now,” Tomek said. “I’ve got another thing to say and then I’ll go. You know what I do, and Mama knows, and Mama doesn’t sleep because of it, and men who know what I do and are caught talk in the cellars and hang on the wall, and I don’t ask people to know what I do unless I need them to. I need you.” He looked at the floor. “There’s a girl who escaped from the country at Stutthof — no, that’s not the story, that’s another story. What I need: someone who can sit in a café and be a music teacher, with sheet music in her

bag, and pass a thing from a man to a man, and be looked at and forgotten, and speak to Germans without her hands shaking. We have nobody like that in the whole city. Everybody useful is a boy with a pistol or a woman in an office, and the boys get caught and the women get followed home." He looked up. "You'd be paid nothing and you'd be dead in three minutes if they take you with a paper in your shoe."

"My daughter is in detail three at Skaryszewska," Helena said, "and I have a hundred and ten zlotys and my father's violin."

"I know," Tomek said. "That's why I'm asking. Because a person with nothing to lose is a fool, and a person with something to lose is a soldier." He put his cap on. "Bar eleven, from the top. Mama says you've been teaching that to the child since she was five. I heard it through the window once. It's a beautiful piece."

"It is a very beautiful piece," Helena said. "It is not the piece's fault that it is difficult."

When he had gone she sat for a long while without lighting the lamp, and then, by touch, in the dark, she lifted the fourth floorboard from the wall of the alcove, where the joist and the brick made a gap the size of a shoebox, and took out the tin.

There was not much in the tin. A certificate from the conservatory in Munich with her name on it in German script. A programme from a recital in the Residenz, in which she had been the second violin, in an orchestra of sixteen, in December 1932, playing Bach for an audience of a hundred and eleven people. A dried rose, flattened, from a garden on the Nymphenburger Straße. Three letters in envelopes, addressed in a young man's careful hand to Fräulein Helena Wojtera, in Warsaw; all three returned unopened, all three with the same stamp, all three with her

father's handwriting on the back — *oddać* — give it back — because her father, who was a railway engineer and a proud man, had decided that his daughter was not going to be the kind of person who opened letters from the country that had ruined her.

She had never opened them. She had carried them home in her trunk in the autumn of 1933 with the certificate and the rose, and put them in the tin, and put the tin under the floorboard, and in ten years she had taken the tin out exactly twice: once when the Germans came in 1939 and she needed to know what to burn if the house was searched, and once, at three in the morning, in the winter of 1940, when the child had pneumonia and Helena had stood at her bed and bargained with God.

She sat on the floor with the tin in her lap and thought about the man at the pawnshop, the man with his chin in his collar who had watched her hands; and about the German official called Böhm who drank coffee at the Europejski at eleven; and about the welfare woman's unsmiling diagnosis, delivered in the rain in a courtyard behind a shop with a yellow sign, of the three ways out of a locked room.

And she thought, and this was the thought she had been holding away from herself with both hands all day, about the entry in the register at Skaryszewska in the flat German hand, and about the words *rassische Überprüfung*, and about what a man might do, if a man was a Major in a German office with a signature, and the child was his, and the mother was a liar with a half photograph sewn into the lining of her coat.

She put the tin back under the board and laid the board flat and put the rug over it and stood up and looked at her own room, at the bed that was too big, at the little violin on the shelf with its half-size bow, at the window with the

blackout paper on it, at the place on the wall where the child had grown two centimetres in a pencil line in February.

Give me until Wednesday, she said to nobody, to the room, to the window, to the city outside with its names on the walls. *Give me until Wednesday, and I swear to you I will not do it.*

Which was, and she knew it as she said it, the kind of promise a woman makes to a mirror, on the first night, before the long war of the heart begins.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Saxon Garden

Warsaw — Monday, 24 May 1943

The laundry of the Wehrmacht hospital on Wiejska Street was in a building that had been a municipal bath house, and it had three hundred and forty kilos of German linen going through it every day, and it was run by a German sergeant-major called Frau Piltz who had been a matron in a sanatorium at Bad Pyrmont before the war and who applied to the occupation of Poland the same standards of hygiene and the same low opinion of human beings that had made her a success at Bad Pyrmont.

Helena worked from six in the morning at the vats, in a steam that took the breath away in the first half-hour and after that took nothing at all; wringing, sorting, counting, marking the bundles with a wooden tally. There were twelve Polish women and one Pole who had been a notary in Lublin, and there were two German women soldiers of the Nachrichtenhelferinnen corps who fetched and carried and considered themselves superior to the vats, and there was Frau Piltz in a white coat with her sleeves rolled and a whistle on a cord that she had never once blown, because her voice was sufficient.

She had an apprentice’s eye. She walked the line twice an hour, and the second time she walked it she came back to Helena, and stood in front of her with her hands on her hips and looked at her hands.

“You have never washed anything in your life,” she said, in German.

“I have washed my own things for ten years.”

“In a basin. Look at that.” Frau Piltz took her by the wrist and turned the palm up, and Helena’s palm was unmarked: no callus at the base of the fingers, no burn, no line across the tips. “You play something. Piano? Violin?”

“Violin.”

“Hm.” Frau Piltz looked at her for a moment, and there passed over her face something that Helena would not have expected to see there and would not see again: a movement of opinion, a small rearrangement, the look of a woman of the world recognizing another woman of another world, both of them now working for an army in a bath house. “Then do not spoil your hands, because when this is over there will be music in Bad Pyrmont and there will be no laundries. Sort the bundles.” She turned away, and added, without turning back, “Here in the fourth vat, the water is hot. The third vat is hot only for the first hour. Everybody works in the third vat and I have stopped correcting them. Now you know. That is my fee. You will pay me back when you can play.”

At a quarter past one a boy in a Hitler Youth shirt came into the laundry with a slip of paper and asked loudly for *die Polin Wojtera*, and the whole line of women stopped, because in the fourth year of the occupation there were only three reasons why a boy in that shirt came for anybody: work, interrogation, or a family matter with a German stamp on it.

The paper said:

FRAU H. WOJTERA is required to attend the office of the Wehrmacht-Kommandantur Warschau, Referat für Arbeitseinsatz, Nowy Świat 71, Room 214, on Monday 24 May at 16.00 hours, concerning the registration of a minor child, labour case no. 3/Skaryszewska.

Attendance is obligatory. Bring this paper and the labour card.

For the Wehrmacht-Kommandantur Warschau — v. Brandt, Major.

At four o’clock she was in the corridor.

It was a marble corridor, and the marble was good, a warm yellowish marble with the veins in it that had been quarried somewhere in Italy and shipped up the Oder and pinned to the inside of a Polish insurance building by men who had thought, in 1928, that they were building for their grandchildren. There was a smell of floor polish and cigarette smoke and wet overcoats. There was a queue of Poles at a window further down: contractors, foremen, an engineer with a rolled drawing under his arm, a man with a wheelbarrow license. Two German soldiers walked past with a filing box. A Polish boy of sixteen in a grey smock came along the corridor with a bucket and a rag and got down on his knees and began to wipe the skirting board, and kept his eyes on the skirting board the entire time, and Helena, standing with her back against the wall and her permit and her paper in her hand, understood that she was being shown, with the economy that the occupation applied to everything, exactly where in the order of the world she stood.

At ten past four a woman came out of Room 214 with a shorthand pad and said, in German, “Pani Wojtera? Bitte.”

Klara Seidler was perhaps twenty-eight, with pale eyelashes and a long neck, and she looked at Helena for exactly one second longer than an office clerk looks at a person who is only a file, and then held the door and said, in German, “The Herr Major will see you now. You will speak German. You will stand until you are asked to sit. You will not address him unless he addresses you.”

“Of course.”

The room had a desk, a chair on each side of it, a map of the General Government with red pins in it, and a window with a view over the roofscape of Nowy Świat to the towers of the city. It had a cupboard with four hundred folders in it. It had a photograph in a leather frame on the side of the desk that Helena, sitting where she was told to sit, was very careful not to look at and then, when she was told to sit and had sat, looked at once.

It was a woman of about thirty-five with a broad unsmiling face and a hat that was not quite right, and it had been taken in a garden in about 1938, and there was no child in the picture, and there was a white space at the bottom left of the frame where a second photograph had been removed and the leather had not faded around it.

Friedrich von Brandt came in from the outer office with a folder under his arm and sat down and opened it, and said, “The child Maria Anna Wojtera. Detail three, Skaryszewska. Born 3 December 1933.”

“Yes.”

“Such a child is not a prisoner; that must be understood. She is a labour reserve. She is being kept at Skaryszewska because the labour office has not yet decided where her work can best be used.” He turned a page, and his voice was the voice of an officer at a desk, and the whole of him was an officer at a desk: the tunic buttoned to the collar, the hands, the level flatness of the vowels, the eyes on the paper. “By regulation of the Reichsarbeitsministerium of 1942, a person under fourteen may be registered for light work under the guardianship of the labour office when the mother is employed in war work. You are employed in war work. That is your paper.” He pushed a yellow slip across the desk. “It gives you the right to visit the child at Skaryszewska on Tuesdays and Saturdays between ten and eleven, in the visitors’ yard, in the presence of a guard. It

does not give you the right to bring food beyond one packet of two hundred grammes. It does not give you the right to correspond. There is no right of appeal."

"Thank you."

"Secondly." He turned the page again. "The camp administration has requested a racial examination of the child under the decree of 1941 concerning children of doubtful ancestry in the occupied eastern territories. This is a formality in most cases." The two of them looked at each other over the top of the folder with faces like two clocks. "In some cases it is not a formality. The examination is conducted by a doctor of the Institut für Rassenhygiene who comes from Posen every second Thursday. He will look at the child. He will look at you. He will ask for a family history of three generations, with dates and places. He will ask who the father was."

The corridor, on the other side of the door, had a sound to it like a distant railway.

"The father is dead," Helena said.

"So the register says. *Vater: unbekannt* — unknown." He shut the folder. "Which is a word, Pani Wojtera, and not a fact, and the difference between those two things is a matter of approximately two hours with a doctor from Posen."

Neither of them had moved. In the outer office, Klara Seidler's typewriter stopped for a moment and then went on, and the sound of it came through the door like rain on a roof.

"Thirdly," Friedrich said, and then he stopped, in the middle of a sentence, and Helena, watching him, saw his right hand come down flat on the folder and stay there, and saw the knuckle of the thumb go white, and she had a moment of such vertiginous double vision that she had to put her own hands in her lap: she was looking at a German

officer who was the most powerful man she had ever stood in a room with, and underneath him, thirty-one years old, hollow-eyed, was the boy with the violin case who had walked her home along the Ludwigstraße in the rain in 1932 holding a newspaper over both their heads because they could not afford a tram.

"There is a matter which cannot be discussed in this building," Friedrich said. "There is an interview which, under the regulations governing the employment of foreign nationals, may be conducted in a place of recreation, provided that the responsible officer certifies in writing that no office accommodation was available." He looked up. His eyes were quite steady. He was, Helena realized, terrified, in the exact, controlled, orderly way in which he did everything. "It is ten past four. There is no office accommodation available. There is a park at the end of the street."

They walked along Nowy Świat towards the Saxon Garden, two metres apart, in the four o'clock slum of noise that was the city's traffic: the horse-carts, the rickshaws with their Poles pedalling Germans, the wooden-wheeled carts, the buses with the gas bags on the roof; and in the middle of the crowd, moving at a German pace, the men in grey who owned everything, and the women in fur coats who had come from Riga and Reval and Lodz and were now the queens of the cafés on Nowy Świat, and the Italian soldiers with their feathers, and the boys selling *Nowy Kurier Warszawski* with the news that Germany's friends were winning everywhere.

At the gate of the Saxon Garden there was a sign, in German, that said *Für Zivilpersonen deutscher Volkszugehörigkeit* — for civilian persons of German nationality — and a second sign beside it that told Poles where they were permitted to walk, and a third, on the

pole, that said that the feeding of pigeons was prohibited.

They went in and walked down the lime avenue, past the fountain with the four river gods, and stopped at a bench that had, in green paint on its back, the words *Nur für Deutsche*.

Von Brandt stood in front of the bench and did not sit on it. He did not, Helena observed, sit on it for the entire hour. He took off his cap and turned it over in his hands like a man holding a bowl, and said, “There is a thing I have to ask you, and it can be asked out here, and I want you to answer it, and if you tell me to go to hell I will accept it and go on doing what I can, so you lose nothing by the answer.”

“Ask.”

“In the summer of 1933,” he said, “you wrote to me that you had been mistaken in your feelings, and that you had taken the money my father offered, and that I was not to write to you again.”

“Yes.”

“Did you write that letter?”

The fountain ran; the lime trees dripped; somewhere along the avenue a nanny with a pram was walking with a soldier’s wife from Kassel or from Posen, and the two of them were talking about rations. A long way off, past the iron railing of the garden, the trams went by on Marszałkowska.

“I wrote it,” Helena said, “with your father’s pen, at his desk, in his study, on the thirtieth of May, 1933, in German, at eleven o’clock in the morning, and he dictated it, and I signed it, and then I asked him whether I could have a cup of tea, and he sent for one, and he was very kind to me, and he told me that I was a brave girl.” She heard her own voice and it was a flat voice, and it had in it exactly what his voice had in it when he read from the folder. “Your uncle’s residence permit — my uncle, Stanisław, who had a shop in

the Türkenstraße and had come to Munich in 1924 and had nothing in the world but that shop and a wife with a bad heart — was in the hands of a police official who had coffee with your father's adjutant on Thursdays. That was the first thing he told me. The second thing was that you would be finished: that the Reichswehr would not take a man married to a Polish woman without citizenship, that his name would be struck from the lists, that his father's name was known in Berlin and would be smeared. The third thing was that he would put a hundred and fifty marks on the table for my passage and five hundred for my uncle's debts, and that I could have the second of those in the form of a draft on the Bayerische Hypothekenbank, and that if I did not take it in the form of a draft he would take it as a sign that I intended to make trouble, and that he was, he said, a patient man, but that he had seen off better people than me." She looked at the grey water in the fountain. "I took the draft. I never cashed it. It is in a tin box under my floor, and it has been there for ten years, and if you want it back you can have it, because there is a limit to what I will be paid for anything."

He stood quite still with his cap in his hands. Two Polish girls came down the avenue past them, in coats that had been turned twice, and looked at Helena with her shorn hair and then at him in his grey uniform, and away, quickly, with the expressionlessness of the city.

"I came to Warsaw in September 1933," he said.

Helena's breath stopped in her throat.

"I had thirty-six hours' leave. I came on the night train, and I had eighty marks and a photograph, and I went to Hoża Street, and I stood in your courtyard." He was looking at the fountain and not at her. "There was a man in the yard. The caretaker's husband. He asked me what I wanted and I said I had come about the piano, which was the first lie that came into my head, and he said that the young lady

was from home, and he went and stood by the gate with his arms folded until I had gone. I stood in the rain outside for an hour and a half. I looked up at your windows and I thought that if I went up and you told me it was true, the letter, I would do something stupid, and if you told me it was not true then I would have to go home and burn my father's house down, and I could not decide which of those two things I wanted, so I stood in the street, and then I went to the station." He turned the cap over, once. "There was a window with a curtain up on the second floor. It moved once. I told myself it was the wind. It was the wind, probably."

"It was not the wind," Helena said.

The silence between them went on for a long time. In the middle of it, everything that could be said about ten years was present and unsayable: that on the evening of the fourteenth of September 1933, she had been sitting at that window in an armchair with the eiderdown over her knees, knitting a bootee, three months pregnant, with a sickness in her that nobody but her father's housekeeper knew about; that she had seen a man come into the courtyard and stand in the rain among the acacias, and that she had gone down the two flights in her dressing gown and stockings in the dark, silently, sick with hope; and that by the time she reached the courtyard there had been nobody there but the wind, and that she had stood in the wet with her bare feet in her slippers and told herself that she was becoming someone who saw things.

"If you had come up," she said.

"Yes."

"No." She shook her head, once, hard. "It was better that you did not come up, because if you had come up I would have told you about the child, and you would have married me, and you would now be an officer in the

German army with a Polish wife and a half-Polish daughter in a city where the Gestapo keep lists, and all three of us would be in the ground." She looked at him and her eyes were dry and bright and terrible. "So you did the right thing by accident, and I did the right thing by accident, and between the three of us — you, me, your father — we have kept a child alive for nine years. That is the whole truth of it. Nobody in this story is a hero and nobody in it is innocent; we are just two people who were careful."

"Two people who were careful," he repeated, as though tasting it. "That's what I have told myself every morning for ten years, dressed and shaved and put on a cap, and gone to the office and been careful."

"Now," Helena said. "The child."

"Now the child." He put his cap on at last, and the change in him was immediate and complete: the officer's face came down over the young man's face like a shutter. "At the examination, a doctor from Posen will ask you three questions. One: whether there is any German ancestry in your family within three generations. Two: whether the father of the child is known to you. Three: whether you consent to the examination of the child at all. If you say yes to the third, the child is examined and photographed and measured, and a file is made, and the file goes to Posen, and in six or eight weeks there will be a decision. If you say no to the third, the file does not go, and the child is transferred, as an uncooperative case, to the administration of the Sicherheitspolizei, which means Szucha, which means I cannot reach her with any paper in the world."

"Then I say yes."

"Then between now and the examination, which will be a fortnight on Thursday, you must do the only thing that will make that examination survivable." He said it without any change of tone. "You must give them a father. A Polish

father, with a name and a parish and a date of death, and a family that can be looked up in a register, and no German ancestry at all, because a Polish file is a dead file: they do not investigate Poles. And you cannot stagger in there and invent a man: the doctor from Posen has interrogated four thousand Polish mothers, and he can smell a lie at twenty metres, and a lie at the examination means the file goes straight to Posen as a suspect case and then we are back to Szucha. It has to be a man who existed. It has to be a man who can be verified in a church register by a clerk in this city. It has to be a man who left a widowed mother who will say the same thing you say."

Helena stood in the lime avenue in the Saxon Garden in the late afternoon of the twenty-fourth of May 1943, in the year of the destruction of the ghetto, with her shorn head and her labour card and her two hundred grammes a week of visiting rights, and she thought about it: about her father, dead in 1939; about her mother, dead in 1938; about the cousin in Piaseczno who wrote once a year; about the men she had refused in ten years, and the two she had allowed to kiss her and regretted, and the notary and the doctor and the officer of the Home Army who had asked, and about the fact that not one of them, not one, was a verifiable man in a register with a widowed mother who would lie for her.

"There was a man," she said slowly. "Adam Wójcik. A railway man. He was in my father's section on the Wilno line. He died — it was said he died — in the spring of 1933, before the child was born; my father told people we were engaged. He was from Grodno, and there is nobody left of his family, they were all deported in 1940, and no clerk in Warsaw can check Grodno, because Grodno is Russian now."

Von Brandt looked at her, and it was the first time in an hour that his face had done something without his permission: a small, crooked, painful smile crossed it and was gone.

"That," he said, "is almost a perfect lie. Where did you learn to lie like that?"

"I have had nine years' practice," Helena said. "And there is one thing in it, Herr Major, and I want you to hear it: if you had come up those stairs in 1933, then the man who got the child would have been you, and I would have had a husband, and she would have had a name, and whatever else we were, we would have been an ordinary family with an ordinary sorrow." She looked at him. "As it is, she has a dead man for a father, and you have a dead man's place in a park, and when they ask me at the examination who the father is, I will say Adam Wójcik, and I will say it in front of you if you like, and I will say it every day for the rest of my life."

Friedrich von Brandt did not answer that. He stood with his hands behind his back and his face turned up towards the pale sky over the Saxon Garden, and he was silent for a long moment, and Helena, looking at him, saw his throat move and saw him, with an act of the will that was almost visible, put the thing away and become again what he had to be.

"Very well," he said at last. "Then here are the terms. You will not come to Nowy Świat again. You will not write to me, you will not send me anything, and if you see me in the street you will not know me. If you are taken by the police, you will say exactly this: that the labour office required you to give evidence about your employment, that you spoke to a clerk, and that you do not remember his name. You will not know my name. Say it."

"I will not know your name."

“There will be a paper every month for the child’s reserve status; it is renewed from my office; it buys her the right to exist as a labour resource rather than as a racial case.” He looked down at her. “Every month, understand, it will cost something, and the something will not be money, and it will not always be something you would like to give. There will be a morning when I ask you for a thing that makes you hate me. When that morning comes, I want you to remember this bench and this park and this hour, and to remember that you asked me for it.”

“I have not asked you for anything.”

“No,” he said. “You have not, and that is the worst of it.” He put his cap on straight. “Tuesday and Saturday, ten until eleven, at the wire. Bring the child a pencil. Do not bring her hope; it is not permitted at the gate.”

He walked her to the Marszałkowska gate because it was, in the logic of the occupation, the correct gate for a Pole to leave by, and he went with her along the avenue as far as the last lime tree and then stopped and said, in a voice that carried, so that anyone listening would hear a German officer dismissing a Polish employee: “That is all. You will bring the paper. You will not be late again.”

“Thank you, Herr Major.”

She did not look back. She went out of the gate into the roar of Marszałkowska Street with the crowd and the rickshaws and the boys with the newspapers, and she got twenty metres down the street before she allowed herself to turn her head, and when she did she saw him at the head of the avenue: a tall grey-backed figure with his cap on, standing perfectly still in the middle of a path down which no Pole might walk.

And she saw, too, the other thing, the thing that made her heart go small and cold in her chest like a stone dropped in water: a young lieutenant with a beautiful shine

on his boots, twenty-three years old, who had come out of the trees at the far end of the fountain with his hands behind his back as if he had been strolling for some minutes, and who was now standing at a correct distance behind his Major and waiting to be noticed, and who had — Helena was almost certain, from two hundred metres away, with her shorn head and her two hundred grammes of visiting rights and her one hour in a lime avenue — already been watching them for some time.

That night she wrote the statement on a half-sheet of paper at the kitchen table, by the light of a candle because the current was off in the whole street: *I, Helena Wojtera, music teacher, of Hoża 14, Warsaw, state that the father of my daughter Maria Anna was Adam Wójcik, a railwayman of Grodno, deceased in the spring of 1933. I have no further information as to his family. I have never applied to any German authority for anything concerning my daughter, and I ask nothing for myself.*

. . .

Warsaw — Tuesday, 25 May 1943

The visitors' yard at Skaryszewska was a triangle of gravel between the west wing of the school and the coal heap, with the wire running down the middle of it, and it was open on Tuesdays and Saturdays between ten and eleven, and it was, Helena understood in the first five minutes, not a place where people visited their children. It was a place where the camp conducted a lottery and charged nothing for the tickets.

There were thirty women at the wire on the Tuesday, and eleven of them were mothers of children in detail three, and the rest were mothers of men and women and grandmothers of everybody, and the whole crowd of them stood with both hands through the wire like people

standing in a river, and talked at the same time, in the way people talk when every sentence is priced by the minute.

The guard was a man of about fifty in a black Ukrainian uniform who walked his twelve-metre beat with his hands behind him, and who was, Helena learned in the first hour, one of the three things in the whole camp that money could reach.

“You have twenty-five minutes and four seconds,” he said to her, in Polish, as she took her place at the wire. “There is a Jew in the next yard and a Pole in the office, and I am a Ukrainian, and I do not care about any of you, and if you put your arm through the wire above the second line I will hit you, not for the rules, but because the second line is where the sergeant looks.”

Marysia came out of the west door at ten past ten with eleven other children, in a line, in the grey shirts, with their hair grown out into dark caps.

The first thing Helena noticed was that the child had learned to walk in a line the way the children in the camp walked in lines: not shuffling, not slow, a good, quick, level, invisible walk, the walk of a person who has understood that any movement noticed by a man in a green uniform is a movement that costs.

The second thing was that the child was carrying something: a little bundle of rags, tied with thread.

“You,” Marysia said, at the wire, in the flat voice of a person keeping count of a debt.

“Me.”

“Three minutes to set up and then the guard comes back this way,” the child said, and knelt down at the wire so fast that Helena’s heart jumped, and put her hands to the rags, which were three-quarters of a hand high, and made of grey army cloth cut into a shape, and had a neck and two arms and a head, and were stitched, Helena saw at once,

with real stitches, in rows, in white thread, the rows of a person who has learned to stitch on a corpse of rags under a German lamp.

"This is Fela," Marysia said, in Polish, very low, keeping her head down over her work. "Three years old. She doesn't talk. She came from the road at Zamość with her sister and her sister was taken out of the bath house on the fourteenth and Fela has not talked since, and they put her next to me at the sorting because I can count, and last week she started to shake at night and sing a thing with no words, and the guard came in with a torch and I put my hand on her mouth and now she has got the shakes all the time." The needle went in and out. "So I am making her a doll and it has to be finished before Saturday, because when a child has a thing of her own she stops shaking, that is the truth, Pani Rybak's boy told me, he said that they gave the children at the orphanage a piece of wood each and they stopped crying, and so I am stitching, and I need white thread and a needle and three more pieces of cloth, and I need them before Saturday, Mamo, because the doctor is coming here on Thursday."

"What doctor?"

"An officer doctor in a car with a chauffeur. He came last week and he sat in the office with Bierbaum and he has got a book with photographs in it, and there is a girl called Elschen in the next dormitory and she says he asks her name in German and she has forgotten her Polish name, she has been here since she was four, and they are going to send her to a German family and give her a doll with a china face, she says, and she was singing about it last night, it is the only thing she sings." The child's head came up, and the grey eyes held hers through the wire, and the eyes were steady and absolutely without self-pity, which was the most frightening thing Helena had ever been

looked at with. “If he asks me about my father, what do I say?”

“You say his name and you say he died before you were born and you do not say anything else. Not about the violin, not about Munich, not about a single German word, unless the doctor asks for the counts in German and then you say them in a voice like you’re saying the multiplication tables, like something learned by rote, without looking at anybody.”

“Counts?”

“When you sort the buttons. You said you could count them in German.”

“*Eins, zwei, drei, vier, fünf, sechs*,” Marysia said, all in one breath, fast, singsong, dull, in the voice of a child repeating what the guards shout, and then looked at her mother with one eyebrow up in a way that was so exactly her father’s that Helena had to put her hand flat on the wire to hold on to herself.

“Exactly like that,” she said. “Now listen to me. Twenty minutes. They will ask the doctor’s questions here in the office or in the little room with the shutters, and there will be a nurse and a clerk, and the door will be open, and if anything at all in the room frightens you, you say, in Polish, in your ordinary voice, that you need the toilet, and they will take you out, and that is a rescue five seconds long, and you can find five seconds three times in an hour. That is all you have to remember. Five seconds, three times, and the truth about Adam Wójcik, which is not a lie, because I never told you one, and don’t ever decide you know better than me about this. Give me your hand.”

The hand came through the wire, small and quick, and it had a fresh scratch along the palm and the calluses of a person who has been lifting wet cloth for three weeks, and Helena turned it over and looked at it, and this, more than

the shorn head, more than the grey shirt, more than the wire, was the thing that told her what had happened to her daughter in eight days.

"Sunday is for the piano," Helena said. "And in September, if God is awake the whole night, you will play the Szymanowski for the entire block, and they will all cry, and the guard will cry too, and you will be so vain about it that I shall have to slap you."

"Sunday is for the piano," the child said, as if reciting the second half of a lesson. "Mamo. There was a woman. In the bath house line, the first morning. She had a little girl of five and she was holding her by the hand and a guard came and said the child must go with the children's line and the woman wouldn't let go of the hand, she wouldn't let go, and they hit her hands with a stick, both hands, so that they swelled up like bread, and then they took the child, and the woman stood there with her hands out not doing anything, just shaking them, like this, in the air—" Marysia stopped. Then she said, in a very small voice, the smallest voice that Helena had ever heard her use: "I don't like the nights here. Please don't make me say I like it here. Everybody's aunt says it's not so bad and I want to scream."

"Then scream into your bedroll, and not into the air," Helena said. "Scream with your mouth in the cloth, and then be quiet, and go to sleep, and count the buttons in the morning. That is what my mother told me at Verdun, and I never told you that my mother told me that, did I?"

"No."

"Well, now you know."

"Twenty-five minutes," the guard said, walking past.

At the gate, going out, there was the ritual that the women had organized among themselves in three weeks: the packet, passed through the fence at the corner where

the wire met the fence post, out of sight of the office window, two hundred grammes of bread and one hundred of lard, counted by the guard with the eyes of a man who had learned long ago that he could either be a gendarme or a man with a cook, and had chosen. And past the guard, along the row of women, went the thing that Warsaw measured in, the only gold that had not been taken out of the country: the small talk of the wire, in whispers, at speed, while the guard counted.

They were all there, the mothers of detail three: the mother of the twins, from Wola, who could not sing and did not care; the mother of the girl with the swollen glands; Pani Rybak, who had the boy of fifteen in the men's block, and who told Helena, with her chin up and her eyes on the guard, the thing she had not told her in the first week: "They are doing them now. The racial ones. Elschen went to Elschen's family in Posen, she is already gone, and there are two more in the office this week, and the office woman told me it is because the labour office in the city is playing another game, the Wehrmacht wants the children for their workshops, and the SS wants them for the families, and the two of them are fighting over the same name on the same list. Put the bread inside your coat, the woman behind you has been watching your pocket."

And the three of them — Rybak, and Helena, and the mother of the twins — stood at the gate of the camp at Skaryszewska on the twenty-fifth of May, 1943, and watched the office window, where a clerk was writing; and Helena understood that the sentence she had heard in the visitors' yard, out of the mouth of a woman who had heard it from a clerk who had heard it from an office woman, was the most important thing that anyone would tell her for a year; and that the fighting over her child's name was not a personal matter between herself and the Major and the

doctor. It was the war: the war moving along the corridors of every office in the General Government, the war between the men who wanted the girl’s hands for a factory and the men who wanted her name for a nation, and she and her daughter were not even the battlefield of that war. They were its supplies.“

She copied it twice in a fair hand for the file, and then she sat for a while with the pen in her hand and looked at the tin box on the table in front of her, closed, and at the three unopened letters, and at the photograph inside the lining of her coat, and then she put everything away under the floorboard, and blew out the candle, and lay down in the dark on the side of the bed she had made for herself ten years before, on the side nearest the door, listening, as every mother in Warsaw did, listening, all night, to the street.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Card Index

Warsaw — Friday, 28 May 1943

The month-end was always the worst three days of the Referat's month, and this one was the worst of the war, because the Arbeitsamt had raised the Warsaw quota by a third and because the news from the south had gone through the army like a boot through a window.

Tunisia had fallen on the thirteenth. A quarter of a million men, the Italian First Army and the Afrika Korps and everything that fed them, had gone into the bag at Cape Bon, and every mess in Warsaw had been quiet for a week; the officers who had been in Africa were quiet because their friends were in it, and the officers who had not been in Africa were quiet because they had heard the things that the men who had been there said about the way it had ended. In Friedrich's office, where the maps on the wall were of Poland and White Russia, they did not talk about it at all, in the way of a family that has had bad news and organizes the day around the fact that no one is to mention it.

The quota was 1,150 hands for June, which was a number, and the number was not the problem; the problem was that 1,150 hands did not exist in Warsaw any more. They had all been counted before. The metal workers were at the Ostbahn works; the tailors were in the workshops at the Gęsiówka and the Flak barracks; the tradesmen's names were on Böhm's ledger at the Arbeitsamt, where they had been bought and sold four times, and the men

themselves had been sent to the Reich the week after they had paid for their exemption, so that the same man could be sold twice, which was, when Friedrich looked at it coolly, the most Polish thing about the whole occupation: a system in which everyone, the occupied and the occupiers, sold the same person over and over until the person disappeared and the last buyer was left holding an empty paper.

At nine o'clock Generalmajor Wolfram Ritter sent for him.

The Kommandant's office was on the first floor at the front, with two windows onto Nowy Świat, a portrait of the Führer on the wall behind the desk and a photograph of Ritter's own two sons in front of the window with the light full on them, and the light fell on the photograph in a way that showed you, before you knew anything else, that the elder son had been killed at Smolensk in 1941 and that his father had never moved the frame.

"Sit down, Friedrich. Coffee?" Ritter poured without waiting for an answer. He was fifty-six, bald across the top, with the heavy eyes of a man who had been sleeping badly since 1939. "The quota."

"I'm aware of it, Herr General."

"Everybody is aware of it. The Arbeitsamt is aware of it, which is why their man in the corridor this morning — what is his name, the one who wears the hat —"

"Böhm."

"Böhm, yes, told my adjutant that the General Government's labour reserves in Distrikt Warschau are 'exhausted' pending 'a further cleansing action.'" Ritter put the coffee down. "You know what a cleansing action is, Friedrich."

"I know what they call it."

“They call it that, and it means that they will cordon the streets and take whoever is in them, and then the Arbeitsamt will give us a share of what they have taken, and we will be able to say that our workshops are full and our quotas are met, and everybody will be very satisfied, and in August we will be running lathes with fourteen-year-old boys who have never seen a lathe and the accident rate at the shops will double and I will have to write a report about it.” Ritter sat back. “I have been in the army for thirty-eight years. I’ve commanded a regiment, I’ve commanded a garrison, and I have never once been asked to write a report explaining why the generals have lost me a battle in an office. This city is going to make me an expert.”

Friedrich did not smile. He had learned, in the eleven months of working for Ritter, that the old man’s bitterness was real and that it cost him nothing and that it meant nothing: Ritter was a decent man who had grown old making the machine run and had discovered that decency is a private opinion and not a policy.

“There is a second thing,” Ritter said. “The Warsaw district office has asked for a list of all cases in which this command has intervened in the labour disposition of persons who are the subject of a racial examination. That is the language they use. It came in writing.”

Something moved in the room, very quietly, like a cat.

“I have no cases of that kind,” Friedrich said.

Ritter looked at him for a long moment. Then he looked down at his desk and moved one paper to the other side of it, and when he spoke again his voice was the voice of a man giving a piece of fatherly advice over a garden wall.

“Friedrich, I knew your father at the Academy. He was a great man with maps and a difficult man with people. I say that with respect, because he did what he said he would do

and he was never loved for it, and when I am asked what kind of officer he was I say that his division was where it was supposed to be, every day of the war. So you will understand me when I say that I know the look of the von Brandt family when it has decided that it is right and everybody else is complicated." He raised his eyes. "There are two kinds of officers in this army. There are officers who are useful, and officers who are correct. The useful ones are watched. The correct ones get promoted. Do not be useful, Friedrich. Be correct, and be correct in writing."

"And if a thing is both wrong and correct?"

"Then do it very slowly and hope the war ends." Ritter picked up his pen and began to sign the day's letters, and did not look up. "The file that came from Szucha on the twenty-first — the Obersturmführer's inquiry — went back out of this building two days ago. I saw the carbon on the adjutant's desk. You answered it."

"Klara Seidler answered it."

"Klara Seidler answers everything. I have read her since she came here; she is the best clerk in the General Government and she has no more idea than a cat what she is signing." Ritter waved his pen at the door. "Send her my compliments and tell her that everything written in this building about persons under racial examination is to come to me as well as to you. As of now. Before it goes anywhere."

"Yes, Herr General."

At the back of the outer office, past Klara's desk and past the typist with the lame hand, past the two clerks who played chess at lunchtime with a set they had made out of buttons, was the room that held the card index.

It was a room the size of a pantry, with a window the size of a packet of cigarettes, and it held four steel cabinets with eight drawers each and a row of box files on top, and it

was, in its way, the most powerful room in Warsaw: because in Warsaw under the occupation a person was not a body, a person was a card, and a card could be moved from drawer to drawer by anyone with the key to the room.

Klara Seidler had the key.

She was standing at the open drawer C–Z when Friedrich came in, with a card in her hand and the drawer pulled out to her waist, and if he had not known her as he did he would have said that she was reading the card because she was filing.

"The Wojtera card," he said.

"Yes, Herr Major." She did not pretend. She never pretended; it was the most disconcerting thing about her. "I saw the name on the summons last Monday. The child's card is here because we hold the reserve list, and the woman's card is here because she is war-employed at the hospital laundry, and I looked at both of them because it is my job to know what is in the drawers, and I have never in eleven months seen a reserve case from Skaryszewska that was not a widow with five children."

"You have a reason for telling me this."

"I have a question." Klara closed the drawer with her knee and looked at him, with the pale, flat, unhurried eyes, and Friedrich understood that he had underrated her for eleven months. "The card of the child is marked *Reserve III/Skaryszewska* and it is renewed weekly by us. It costs the Wehrmacht nothing: the child is fed by the camp, worked by the camp, housed by the camp. The only thing our card does is take her out of every other list in this city, including the transport lists, and there is a regulation that says a person who is in a reserve cannot be transferred out of the district without the signature of the referring office." She said it precisely, the way a person reads a railway timetable. "That is what the card does. It holds a gate

shut.”

“Yes.”

“Then the question I want to ask, Herr Major, is whether a card in a drawer can be renewed in a month’s time. Because the Arbeitsamt renews the camp’s reserve list only if the camp’s retained quota is met, and the camp’s retained quota is met by the commandant’s discretion, and the commandant’s discretion is — I am sorry, I do not know a polite word for this in any language — for sale.” Klara folded her hands. “Herr Wollweber sells it. He has been selling it since February. The price is a hundred and fifty zlotys a head for a labourer, four hundred for a skilled man, and the money goes to a fund for the widows of the Feldgendarmerie, or into his boot, whichever is closer. There is no proof in this building that would interest a court martial, because the proof is a Form 22 in triplicate and the triplicates are in his coat.”

Friedrich looked at the steel cabinets and at the little window and at the girl with her hands folded and the silver church pin on her collar.

“How do you know the price?”

“Because I take the money in an envelope and put it on his desk,” Klara Seidler said. “He thinks it reassures me to be included.” She looked down at her hands and then up again. “Herr Major, my father is a railway inspector in Kassel and my mother has a bad hip and my brother has been missing at Stalingrad since January. I have been in Warsaw eleven months and I have filed four thousand cards. I am not telling you this because I am a good person. I am telling you because the arithmetic is that on the present rota, the camp’s retained sector will be closed and re-opened at the end of June, and the child in question will be on the list that closes, and there is nothing on any card that will stop it, and I would like to know whether there is a

form for that.”

There was a long silence in the pantry-sized room. Somewhere along the corridor a telephone rang and a man laughed at something and the laugh came down the passage and went away.

“There is no form,” Friedrich said. “There is a price.”

“Then I would like to know the price, Herr Major.”

“Not today.” He took the card out of her hand; the card of Maria Anna Wojtera, b. 3.12.33, with its small blue stamps and its weekly pencil marks. “In the drawer behind this card, is there a list of the camp’s retained detail three?”

“Yes. Sixty-one children under fourteen.”

“Take it out. Not to remove it; to read it.” He handed the card back. “I want to know how many of the sixty-one can be entered on the reserve list as war-employed before the end of June, and what it would cost in Wollweber’s envelopes. Then type it as a schedule, with a cover sheet that says it is an armaments-labour utilization plan for the workshops, and bring it to me, and the first item on the schedule is to be the child Wojtera.” He turned to go, and then stopped, with his hand on the doorframe. “Klara. When you type the cover sheet, type it so that a stranger can read it and find nothing but an office doing its work. Do you understand? Not a word in it that a man could use.”

“I understand, Herr Major.”

“Then that is all.”

“Herr Major.” She had picked up a buff envelope from the shelf. “This came from Szucha at four o’clock.”

He opened it in the corridor, because he did not want her to see his face.

It was one page, typed, with the letterhead of the Kommandeur der Sicherheitspolizei, and it was addressed to the Wehrmacht-Kommandantur Warschau, Referat für

Arbeitseinsatz, for the attention of Major von Brandt, and it was signed by an Obersturmführer of Department IV whose name Friedrich had heard three times in eleven months and each time in a context he had not wanted to know about.

It said: *In the matter of the detained minor Wojtera, Maria Anna (case 4/1411/43), the undersigned would be grateful for a report from the referring office as to the grounds for the reserve entry of 20 May, together with the personal particulars of the applicant mother, and would consider it a courtesy if the Herr Major would call at Aleja Szucha 25 at his convenience, where the matter may be disposed of orally and without formalities.*

Without formalities. Friedrich stood in the marble corridor of the commandant's building on Nowy Świat with the letter in his hand, and he knew, as plainly as he knew his own name, two things: that the word *courtesy* in that letter meant an ambush, and that if he went to Szucha and sat down in a chair in that building and answered questions about Helena Wojtera, he would be signing the register of his own death, and hers, and the child's, in that order, and that he was going to have to go, because a refusal was also an answer.

At one o'clock he sent Kellner for the car and went to Praga.

He told himself that the reason was the quota: sixty-one children in the sorting detail were sixty-one wasted hands, and it was his duty to see what the camp was doing with the labour reserve. He even believed it for the length of the bridge, and then the school came up on the left with its red brick and its wide windows and its wire, and he stopped believing anything at all.

The sorting room was in the basement, in what had been the school's gymnasium: a long low hall with a vaulted brick ceiling and windows high up at ground level, so that

the light came in grey and flat and full of dust. There were long tables down the length of it, and on the tables were mountains of rags: German army rags; hospital rags; uniforms of men killed in Russia, cut and sorted for paper and for wiping and for the fibre mills. There was a smell of dust and rot and carbolic. There were, Friedrich counted, twenty-nine children at the tables: from about six years old to about fourteen, in grey shirts or in their own clothes, and they worked with their hands moving, and they did not look up when he came in with Bierbaum and the female guard, because work was the thing that made you invisible and every child in the room had learned that in the first hour.

Maria Anna Wojtera was at the third table on the left, and she looked up, which was the first thing. She was sorting buttons out of a heap with a small wooden scoop and putting the good ones into a can, and there was a pencil behind her ear, worn down to a stub, and a rag tied over her head with a knot at the back; and when the door opened she looked up the way a bird looks up, and then, seeing officers, she went back to work like the others, and then — and Friedrich saw it happen, and it was the first thing in Warsaw that had ever put tears in his eyes without his consent — then, having looked down and gone on working for the space of ten seconds, she looked up again, not at him but at the wall beyond him, and her lips moved, silently, twice: *bar eleven. Bar eleven.*

She was practising. In the rags and the dust and the buttons, with a pencil behind her ear, she was playing bar eleven of the Szymanowski, from memory, on a violin that was not there.

Bierbaum was talking about the quota, and about the fuel for the bath house, and about the price of the Ukrainian guard company’s rations, and Friedrich heard it all and answered it all, and while he was answering it he

watched the child's hands move, quick and sure, and thought of the photograph in his pay book and of a room in Munich with a band playing beyond the trees.

"Number nine," he said, when there was a pause. "The girl at the third table. What is her disposition?"

Bierbaum looked. "Detail three, labour reserve. She's a case from the racial office; we hold her. There is talk of an examination on the tenth."

"Her hands are worth more than that." Friedrich said it in the voice he used for the war, the flat, unarguable, staff-officer voice. "Look at the speed of her. I have lathes in the workshops at Wolska; the Ostbahn is short of hands for fine sorting and they have German overseers who cannot count. I want her on my reserve as war-employed, with a trade entry: *Sortiererin* — sorter, light metalwork." He was writing it down as he said it, on his own pad, in his own hand, because a thing said is nothing and a thing written is a fact. "And the whole of detail three. The children of detail three are a labour reserve of this command as of today. Every one of them under trade entry, and every card to my office, and no transfer without my signature."

Bierbaum's face did something small and knowing. "The Major is building an empire of small hands."

"The Major is meeting a quota," Friedrich said, "which is a thing the Major is asked about every day and which the Unterstrumführer is not. There is a fee, of course."

"There is a fee," Bierbaum agreed, and named it: it was a modest fee and it was, Friedrich understood, exactly the price of the girl's life, expressed in the currency in which such lives were sold in the General Government in the spring of 1943: five kilos of coffee and two thousand zlotys, to be paid at the camp office, weekly, for the maintenance of the camp's cultural fund, by which Bierbaum meant his

own pocket, and Friedrich agreed to it without blinking, because in that moment he would have agreed to anything.

And then, because he was who he was, and because the thing had gone on too long and had begun to burn a hole in him, he walked down the length of the sorting room to the third table on the left, and stood at the end of it, and looked at the child, and said, in Polish, in a voice pitched for a schoolroom: “You there. What is your name?”

The hands stayed on the buttons. She said, in Polish, with her eyes down, in the singsong of a child reciting: “Maria Anna Wojtera.”

“And your father?”

“Adam Wójcik. He was a railwayman. He died before I was born.”

The room had gone very quiet at the two tables nearest them. A small girl at the next table — three years old, Friedrich saw, three years old and sorting rags, with a face like a fist — began to make a low keening sound and stopped herself, and put her hand over her own mouth, and went on sorting.

“Where did you learn to count in German?”

“From the guards.” She said it to the table. “I can count the buttons in German and in Polish. *Eins, zwei, drei…*”

“Good.” Friedrich said. He looked at the pencil behind her ear. It was a stub no longer than a joint of a finger, and it was sharpened with a knife at both ends, and he knew, without knowing how he knew, that the mother had brought it through the gate in a packet of two hundred grammes, past the guard, in the visitors’ yard, on Saturday morning. “What else do you know?”

“Nothing, Herr Officer.”

“Nothing?”

“Only music, Herr Officer,” the child said, and looked up at the ceiling, at the high windows with the dust coming

down through them, and closed her eyes, and moved her left hand a little, four fingers, on the edge of the table, in the air, as if on the neck of a violin. “Only bar eleven. From the top. Slowly.”

Friedrich von Brandt stood in a school gymnasium in Praga, in the presence of twenty-nine children and an SS-Untersturmführer and his own driver, and put both his hands behind his back so that no one could see them, and held on, and said, in German, in a voice of complete administrative calm: “The girl is transferred to the reserve of the Referat für Arbeitseinsatz as of today. The whole of detail three. Prepare the schedule for my signature.”

Then he walked out into the yard, past the coal heap and the shed and the wire where, nine days before, a mother and a shorn child had held hands through the fence, and there, standing by the car with his cap in his hand and something unhappy in his fat face, was Kellner.

“There’s a thing, Herr Major,” Kellner said. “I didn’t want to say in there. The young gentleman — Leutnant Adler — he telephoned the office while we were on the bridge. He said Szucha had been enquiring at the motor pool about the Major’s movements, and about the Major’s journeys across the river, and he said —” Kellner turned his cap over, the way a man turns over a coin he does not like the look of — “he said it kindly, Herr Major. He said it as if he was warning you. But he said it into the telephone in the office, where two clerks could hear him.”

Friedrich got into the car and sat looking out at the wire.

He did not stay in the car. He went back into the school, past the queue at the bath house and the Ukrainian at the door, and up the stairs to Bierbaum’s laboratory office, and shut the door behind him, and stood in front of the desk, and said, without preamble, the thing he had been composing all the way across the yard: “The fee for the

reversal of a disposition. How is it paid?”

Bierbaum looked at him for a moment with the small, flat, professional interest of a man who recognizes a first-time customer. Then he opened the lower drawer of his desk, and took out a form — a real one, printed, with the eagle on it — and put it on the blotter between them, and turned it round so that Friedrich could read it, and it was a printed receipt for a donation to the *Kameradschaftskasse der Schutzpolizei*, with spaces for the amount, the date, and the donor’s unit.

“You will pay nothing to me, Herr Major, and I will not take anything from you, and there will be no conversation of the kind we are having now, ever again,” Bierbaum said, in the voice of a clerk instructing a newcomer in the office’s procedures. “There is a fund of the camp, for the welfare of the men of the guard company: their Yule, their tobacco, their cinema, their letters home to Ludwigshafen. Contributions to the fund are voluntary and are acknowledged by this receipt. The receipt is made out to a name that I write myself and file in my own safe, and there is a second copy, which I give to the donor, and if the donor loses the copy, the donor has lost nothing, because the copy is in the safe and the copy is my funeral.” He put the form back in the drawer. “To your question: six thousand zlotys and five kilogrammes of coffee, paid in two parts, half on the first of the month and half on the fifteenth; coffee in the tin, roasted, not ground, because ground coffee is weighed with sand by every Pole in this city, and the men of the guard company are not Poles, they are Ukrainians, and they prefer tea, so the coffee goes to my mother’s cousin in Lemberg, which is not your business or the fund’s. Now: the case of the girl.”

“Detail three. The whole of it.”

“The whole —!” For the first time, Bierbaum’s face did something unprofessional. “Herr Major, there are sixty-one children in detail three. At the fund’s rates —”

“I am aware of the arithmetic. The Wehrmacht requires hands; this command’s workshops at Wolska and the Ostbahn’s sorting depot at Praga are short of fine-assembly workers; an armaments labour plan for sixty-one persons, drawn as a schedule, signed by me, with the trade entries and the reserve numbers, is a document that the Arbeitsamt will countersign and the *Rüstungsinspektion* will approve, because it makes the Warsaw district’s labour forecast look better in Kraków.” Friedrich heard his own voice, level, fluent, completely shameless. “There is no payment at all for the plan. The payment is for the commandant’s *discretion* in reassigning the persons on the plan to the reserve group, and that is a fee, and I will pay it, and I will pay it in coffee, in tins, in the second half of every month, and for that fee the commandant will keep his boot out of the reserve group’s files, and no card in the reserve group will be altered, and no name in the reserve group will be exchanged, and no person in the reserve group will be transferred anywhere on any list, at any time, for any reason, without my signature; and if the commandant wants to say no, he may say no, and I will take the plan down the corridor to the Oberfeldkommandantur and the plan will be signed by another signature, and the *Kameradschaftskasse* will never see a tin of coffee again.”

There was a silence. Out in the yard the counting went on, and the whistle of the bath house, and the sound of a work party’s boots on the gravel.

“You have been doing this a long time, Herr Major,” Bierbaum said at last, with what sounded, horribly, like admiration.

“Six weeks.”

"Hm." Bierbaum wrote something in his notebook, short, and underlined it twice, and then looked up, and his face had gone back to being a whippet's face, and he said, conversationally: "Then, since we are both professionals, you should know the following, as a courtesy of the house. The room over the gate is not part of the camp. It is under the direct control of Aleja Szucha; the files of the persons kept in it are kept not here but there; and the persons who go into it are, in the language of the SS, *Befragungshäftlinge* — not prisoners, but a file. And this morning I received a telephone instruction from Szucha to hold the room in readiness for a case of theirs." He looked down at his notebook. "I mention it because when a Major of the Wehrmacht makes a labor-utilisation plan for sixty-one children, it is the kind of plan that goes on a desk in a different building, and one finds, in this city, that plans make echoes."

"Thank you," Friedrich said. "You will prepare the schedule."

He did not ask whose case it was. He had understood, from the first three words of the sentence, that asking was a way of hearing the answer out loud, and that once he had heard it, he would be a man who knew the answer, and knowing the answer out loud was a thing that could be written on a form; so he bowed slightly, the way Prussians bow in offices to other men's junior officers, and went down the stairs and out to the car, having paid for it with coffee and with the part of himself that could still be said to have clean hands.

At the end of the day, in the office, the schedule came back from Klara's typewriter, with its cover sheet in the bland language of an office doing its work: *Armaments Labour Utilisation Plan No. 61/A: transfer of reserve group III (light sorting) from camp Skaryszewska to the*

establishment of the Wehrmacht-Kommandantur Warschau, effective 1 June 1943. Cases: 61. He signed it at the bottom and initialled the annexe, and then he sat with the pen in his hand and read the covering sheet from the labour office that had come in with the afternoon post, the routine monthly return of "transfers effected under plan 22" — the plan of the previous month, his own plan, his own signature at the foot of it.

Three hundred and forty persons. He had signed it on the second of May and had not looked at the annexe for more than thirty seconds, because on the second of May he had been in a hurry.

And there, at line 118, in the alphabetic list of trades, was a name he had heard that morning in a basement in Praga: the boy of twelve at the end table with the mouse in his pocket, who could whistle the whole of a march and had a mother in the camp, whose name Friedrich had heard because the female guard had shouted it at him across the room for dropping a button. And the trade entry against the boy's name was *Hilfsarbeiter* — helper — and against the destination was written, in the neat hand of a clerk of the Arbeitsamt, the words *Reichseinsatz, Braunschweig*.

He put the paper down on the desk, and sat looking at it for a long time, while the building emptied around him and the trams went past on Nowy Świat and the light went out of the sky over the city in the way it does in June in Warsaw, slowly, and he thought:

My signature put a child on a train.

And then he thought:

My signature is the only thing that can keep one off.

. . .

Powiśle — the same evening

The room Klara Seidler rented was in a house on the Browarna, below the escarpment, with a stove she fed with coke she bought on the black market and a bed, a table, a chair, a wardrobe, a crucifix, and on the table two photographs: her parents in front of their house in Kassel, and her brother in a labour-service uniform in 1940, before the army took him, standing with a spade over his shoulder and his cap over one eye, grinning, nineteen years old.

Since January he had been *vermisst*: missing. The letter from the company had said, at Stalingrad, in the industrial sector, in the fighting for a factory, of which nothing further was known; and her mother's letters asked the same question every week in careful German sentences — *is there anything new, have you written again to the Wehrmacht information office, they say that when the spring comes they will finish the lists, and the priest in Veckerhagen says that a missing man is not a dead man* — and Klara answered every letter with facts, because facts were what she had: the case number, the date of the inquiry, the address of the office, the sentence in the reply, the date of the next reply. She had written the facts down in a notebook. That was her way with pain: it went into a notebook, with the dates in the margin.

She was twenty-eight years old and she had been in Warsaw eleven months, and she had learned, in eleven months, the things that the clerks of the General Government learn: that a stamp is a weapon, that a drawer is a country, that a schedule can be signed with a pencil or with a pen and that the difference between those two signatures is the difference between a person who is going somewhere and a person who is going nowhere; and she had learned it not from anybody's teaching but from the daily observation of a sheet of paper, and the paper, on this Monday, had a name on it that had frightened her in a way

that no paper in eleven months had frightened her, because in eleven months she had filed four thousand cards and she had never once seen a Major of the Wehrmacht write his own name in the margin of a card about a girl of nine.

She sat at the table in the light of a single lamp with the blackout paper up, and ate the bread and the sausage from the parcel her mother had sent with the field post and that had arrived that afternoon, stale, with a smell in it of the house at home; and then she took out her writing case and wrote to her mother the ordinary letter, the letter of the facts: the weather, the work, the new winter coat she had had made from an old blanket and the sergeant of the motor pool's sister, the price of eggs; and under all of it, in the same hand, between the lines of the ordinary, in the place where she always wrote the thing her mother would not read until the letter was twice folded — "Dear Mama, I am well, and I am being useful, and there is a Major here in the office who is a proper officer; his name is von Brandt, and he is from a family near Küstrin, and he has given me a good reference to the commandant; he is the only man in this building who says good morning to the Polish cleaner" — because her mother, in Kassel, in 1943, collected such sentences the way other women collected stamps, and because a proper officer, in Kassel in 1943, was a thing to be believed in, like the spring and the lists.

Then she put the letter in her bag, and sat for a long while, and did something she had not done before.

She took out of the drawer, from under her underclothes, a small notebook, black cardboard, ruled, the sort a shopkeeper uses for his accounts; and she wrote, in her careful upright hand, with the date in the margin, the thing that had happened that day, completely, with the names and the numbers and the times, and the words *detail three* and the words *war-employment schedule, see File*

61/A, and, at the foot, like a clerk's summary of a case:

The Herr Major is doing a thing which, if it is found out, will end him. He did it in front of me and in front of Kellner and in front of the camp commandant, and he did it in such a way that I have signed the schedule as typist and the schedule bears my initials. I am therefore inside the thing whether I wish it or not, and I have decided that I wish it, and that the reason I wish it is not the girl and not the Major but the fact that in three years there has been one paper in this office that I could look at in the evening without wanting to wash my hands; and the further fact that if my brother is in a factory in the east, then somewhere there is a clerk who writes schedules, and I would like the clerk who writes Henri's schedule to be a person who once wrote a schedule for a child.

She read it over, and then she did the thing that a careful person does with such a page, which is to keep it, because the alternative — to burn it — is a decision that no clerk in the General Government should ever make about the only record that a thing was done; and she put it under the underclothes, in the drawer under the drawer, and went to bed at half past nine, and lay in the dark listening to the trams on the river side, and did not sleep.

And then he picked up the telephone and asked Klara Seidler to come back and bring the whole of the reserve file, and to bring the light, because the work of the night was to find out how many other names had gone on to trains under the cover of the papers he had written to save one girl.

CHAPTER SIX

The Courthouse

Warsaw — Monday, 7 June 1943

The welfare office on Marszałkowska opened at eight, and by half past seven the queue along the wall was two hundred people long, and Wanda Ostrowska had learned, in three years of standing on the other side of such queues, that the most dangerous thing in the world is hope with a number on it.

She came in through the courtyard, past the coal shed and the women already waiting there with their papers tied up in string, and up the back stairs, because the front stairs had the queue on them and the queue on the front stairs would have asked her questions; and in her office, which had a desk, two chairs, a stove, a filing cabinet with four hundred lives in it and a window with a view of a wall, she took off her coat and put on the grey cardigan she always wore at the desk, and became, for the day, a woman with an armband and a ledger, which was the best disguise in Warsaw, because nobody in the history of the world has ever looked twice at a woman with a ledger.

At half past eight Pani Jadwiga brought in the first ten cases, and she brought them in the way she had been taught to bring them in: by number, not by name, because a name said loudly in a waiting room is a name that somebody remembers.

Case 411: a woman of sixty with two grandchildren, the parents deported in January, no money, no ration cards because the cards had been issued to the parents' address

and the address had been sealed. Wanda wrote her the yellow card, the child-feeding card, the milk ticket, and put her on the Thursday list for the shoe distribution, and told her, when she got up to go, quietly, without looking up from the ledger: “There is a woman at the paper shop on Wilcza who keeps sacks. Tell her that the swallows are back.”

Case 412: a woman of thirty-five with a boy of thirteen who had a withered arm. She wanted a work certificate for the boy, because the boy had been called up by the Arbeitsamt for registration and she had heard that a registration meant a transport. Wanda looked at the boy’s arm; and looked at the woman; and said, “This certificate will say that the boy assists in the house and is not fit for employment. It will be true. It will also be worthless, because the labour office does not care whether a boy is fit; the labour office cares whether a boy is on a list. Bring him back on Thursday and I will put him on the register of the children’s home on Tarczyńska, which will make his address a home address, and a home address is looked at by a different desk than a private address, and a different desk is nine days of the boy’s life. Nine days is not much. Nine days is what I have to give.”

Case 413 was a woman Wanda had known before the war, from the committee at the Szymanowski school, and she had brought a letter from a priest in Żoliborz and asked for the second kind of help, the kind that does not go in the ledger. Wanda took her into the corridor, because the corridor was safer than the office for the second kind of help, and read the letter, and said, “Not this week. There’s a boy coming out of the ruins this week and I can only make one hole in the wire at a time. Tell the priest to keep the family quiet and indoors and to tell the neighbours nothing, nothing at all, and to burn the letter.”

“As God is my witness we have told nobody.”

“Then tell the mirror,” Wanda said, and gave the letter back, and looked at the woman with an expression that had nothing in it at all, and went back into the office, and shut the door, and stood for a moment with her hands flat on the desk.

That was the part nobody understood: that the work was not made of brave decisions. It was made of ledgers, and of arithmetic, and of saying no to a woman you had known since before the war because the hole in the wire had been booked for a different child; and if you wept about it, you wept at night, alone, in your own kitchen, and never, ever at the office, because a welfare worker who weeps in her office is a welfare worker who is watched, and a welfare worker who is watched is a welfare worker who gets other people killed.

The second kind of help that week was a bunker under Wilcza Street.

Since the sixteenth of May, when the fights in the ghetto had ended and the great synagogue on Tłomackie had been blown up with a German engineer’s careful satisfaction, the city east of the courthouse had been a dead country: sixty-odd hectares of broken wall and standing chimney and cellar hole, three or four storeys of nothing, drawn with a ruler as you looked at it from the roof of the pralines factory on Żelazna — which Wanda had done, once, in the last week of May, with a man from the underground who wanted to know what could be seen from there, and the two of them had stood on the roof among the dish racks and looked east across the desert of the ghetto and had said nothing at all for a quarter of an hour.

But the dead country was not empty. That was the thing the Germans, with their rulers and their labour battalions, had never quite learned. Men and women were still down there: in the bunkers that had been dug before the fighting

and not found; in the sewers, whose maps the Poles had and the Germans did not; in the cellars of the houses on the Aryan side whose back walls were in the ruin. There were, by the best count the underground had in June, between two and five hundred people living in the ruin and under it, in the dark, on rainwater and on what came over the wall at night, and every one of them was a person for whom the whole apparatus of the richest state in Europe had a single question, which was: *how did you get out, and who helped you?*

Wanda's job, that Monday night, was a boy of eleven called Edek.

He was the son of a woman who had been a bootmaker in the small ghetto, and he had been in a bunker under the ruins of Nowolipki since the eighth of May, when the group of fighters he had been hiding with had come up out of the sewers and gone to ground, and the fighter in charge, a young man named Marek who had lost the hearing in one ear, had sent a message out through the sewer to the only contact he had left, which was a woman who worked in the welfare office on Marszałkowska Street. The message had three words: *the child and the case was closed and Edek was the last of the group that had been in the cellar at Miła.*

They met in the yard of the Church of the Holy Cross at nine o'clock, when the curfew was an hour gone and the city had gone indoors: Wanda, and a man from the waterworks called Broda, who was fifty and drove a municipal truck and knew the length, depth, slope and smell of every drain in the central district, and two boys of fifteen who were the sewer boys, Wojtek and Ludwik, who went in and out of the ruin six times a month for the underground and the welfare office and the Jewish committee, and who had been paid, in the way of all sewer boys, in cigarettes and in being alive.

The entrance was a manhole in the courtyard of the empty factory on Gęsia: four hundred metres from the German guard post in the cordon, in a courtyard where a bone works had been until the Germans took it, and the cover had been kept moveable by the simple method of putting a shed over it and calling the shed a store.

The two women went down second: Broda first, in rubber waders, then the boy Wojtek, then Wanda, then the boy Ludwik, with the torches, and the rope.

The first ten metres were the worst because of the smell, and after ten metres the smell was the house you lived in and it stopped being a thing at all. The pipe was a metre and a half of brick egg, with the flow at the bottom, and the flow in June 1943 was the colour of black tea with a skin on it and it came to her mid-calf and it moved at a walking pace and it took every ash of the ghetto eastward to the river, and the two sewer boys went along it as easily as people walk along a passage at home, one hand on the wall, one hand for the torch, and the two torches made two small red circles on wet brick and made everything else look like the inside of a mouth.

They walked for twenty minutes and then they turned left into a side pipe and then right into a chamber, and then Broda stopped and said, “Now the short one,” and they went into a pipe that was a metre and thirty and had not been maintained since 1937 and was full of things Wanda decided, at the start of it, that she was not going to look at, and then the pipe went downhill for fifty metres, and Wanda, whose head was down and whose eyes were on the boot of the man in front, heard, quite clearly, a violin.

Two notes, then a third, then a stroke of four, in the dark, in a sewer under Warsaw, played very softly and very well, a phrase in E minor that she recognized without being able to name, stopping and starting; and after it, a man’s

voice, low and patient, saying something that went down the pipe to her in a rhythm without words.

“That’s Marek,” the boy Wojtek said quietly. “He plays in the dark. He says it keeps the rats down. He’s got a violin he brought down with him on the eighth of May and no strings for the E, so he can’t play anything with an E in it, and he says that every piece he loves has an E in it, and when a person comes out who can get him a string he is going to sit down and cry.”

They came up into the bunker through a hole where a wall had been knocked, and Wanda stood in the middle of a cellar ten metres by six, lit by three candles and a fat lamp made out of a tin of grease, in which there were eleven people: a man of seventy with his wife; three women of middle age; a boy; a girl of four; and the young man with the violin, who was twenty-four, who was so thin that his cheekbones had turned his face into something carved, and whose left ear was scarred with a burn.

They had: straw, four blankets, two buckets, a sack of potatoes, the violin, and a hole in the floor where the water came in from the pipe.

Marek said, when they had finished, quietly: “Take him and go. The girl goes nowhere; she’s got the fever, she’s had it since Friday. If you take a fevered child through the pipes she dies in the pipes, and the pipes are two hours long, and if she cries down there we all die, and I will not do that to you.” He looked at Wanda with the flat, apologetic, savage calm of a man who has been living in a hole for a month. “Nobody else comes. The old ones cannot walk it. We have the water; we have what Ludwik brings. In September they’ll have forgotten us. In September I will write a letter to a man in London and tell him what we did here, and if he answers, I will buy a new string for my E.”

“He’ll answer,” Wanda said. “The violinist isn’t finished.”

The boy Edek was eleven years old and had been in the dark for four weeks and came up out of the hole like an animal coming up out of a burrow, with his fists and his shoulders up, blinking, shaking, silent; and he had a sack with a pair of shoes and a photograph in it; and he would not let go of Wanda's hand for the first hundred metres and then, in the middle of the long pipe, with the water at their knees and the torches making their two red mouths down the tunnel, he let go and walked by himself for ten metres and then took her hand again, and that, Wanda thought, was the boy's whole history, walked out in the dark in front of her: he had been afraid alone for four weeks, and now he was afraid next to somebody, and he was testing which one he could bear.

They came up out of the sewer at a manhole in the courtyard of the ruin of the Grodzki courthouse.

That was Broda's whole art, and she had never asked him how he knew it, and she never would: that on that side of the building, the wall of the courthouse yard was a wall of the ghetto, and on this side it was not, and the manhole was in the strip of the courtyard that had belonged to neither, and it was, in June 1943, twenty-five metres from the German cordon post and invisible from it, because the soldier there was a young man with a rifle and a bicycle who watched the empty street, and the courtyard behind him was a place where a person with a torch could stand in the open air and look up at the sky.

They stood in the ruin for the four minutes it takes for a boy to breathe.

The courthouse had been shot at in April and shelled in May, and one wall of the yard was down and two were standing with their window frames hanging out of them like the ribs of a whale, and the middle wall, the one with the gates, the one that had let four hundred children out of the

ghetto one at a time in 1942 through the doors that opened on Leszno and closed on Ogrodowa, was still standing, blackened, with its arch and its tiles and the little carved stone face over the arch that had a mustache and looked down on the courtyard with an expression of complete indifference, which is, in the end, the only expression that architecture can have.

Above the wall, to the east, was the dead country, and a smell of dust and lime and something under the dust that was not dust, and, here and there, far off, in the grey of the night, a lamp: a work party of Poles under German guard, clearing the rubble at the corner of Nalewki by lamplight, because the Germans cleared the rubble all summer, for the brick and the iron and the salvage, and because in the rubble there were things worth selling, and among the things worth selling there were things that men had hidden under the floors in the winter of 1942.

And there was, Wanda knew, because Broda had told her, one other thing in the dead country that the Germans had found and were using: since the middle of May the ruins had been a place of execution, and twice a week the vans came from Pawiak prison, four hundred metres up the street, and the men from the Gestapo shot the prisoners into the cellars of the burnt houses, and the Poles of Żelazna and Leszno and Ogrodowa had learned to count the shots, the way people in the country count the strokes of a church bell.

“Under the wall,” Broda said. “Now.”

They went along the inside of the wall, and out through the gate on Leszno, and Edek walked with his sack of shoes like a boy going to his aunt’s, and the four of them crossed Leszno Street, in June 1943, at ten minutes past eleven at night, in the darkness under the blackout paper and the shuttered lamps, and went up Karmelicka into the ordinary

living streets of the Aryan city, where the walls had wallpaper on them and behind the wallpaper a woman coughed and behind the cough a wireless played the German news.

They put the boy in a flat on Żelazna, in a room where there was a bed, a chair, a table, a window with the paper on it, and a crucifix on the wall with a shirt hanging on it. The woman of the flat was called Pani Bronisława, she was fifty-one, she had a face like a nut and hands like a stonemason's, and she had, by Wanda's count, kept fourteen people alive in three years, four of them in that room, and she made the sign of the cross over the boy's forehead and said, "Antek. You're Antek Wiśniewski, from Krasnystaw, your mother is dead, your father is in the Reich, you came from your aunt's on Tuesday, and if anybody asks you anything, you cry. Cry like a real boy; real boys of eleven cry about once a day. Now eat."

The boy looked at the bowl of soup and then he said, in the local Yiddish vowel that he had been born with and that would be the death of him if he ever used it again, "*Nu*," and then, in Polish, with the accent of Nowolipki: "What's my name?"

"Antek."

"Antek," he said. "And after that?"

"After that," Pani Bronisława said, "every morning somebody tells you your name again. That's what 'after that' means for you now, so eat."

Wanda wrote the boy in the ledger on the table by the window: not his name, but a number, and against the number the words *Antek Wiśniewski, 11 years, from Krasnystaw*, and against that a date, and against that the name of the flat, and then she closed the ledger and put it in the tin under the third floorboard of the room, and drank the tea they gave her, and walked home at two in the

morning along the middle of the street in the dark, keeping to the tram tracks because the tram tracks were the only place in Warsaw where a person could not be stopped by the police without a reason.

At four in the afternoon of Tuesday, she went to Hoża Street.

She went in, as always, through the gate past the caretaker, and Zofia Mrożek looked at her red cross armband and her boots and her heavy face, and said, without moving her lips, “Third landing. Wash on the line on the second landing, mind your head.”

The cellar was dark, as always, and Rachel Perel was behind the coal bin, in her nest of coats, and she was not alone: the two of them were doing something with thread, in the dark, by touch, and when Wanda’s foot came down off the last step, a piece of a song stopped in the air, and then a girl’s voice — Marysia’s — said, “*Mamo?*”

“It’s me,” Wanda said. “Pani Wanda.”

The two children in the dark: one who lived in the cellar and one who had been let out of the camp for four hours and came down here, Wanda understood in one turn of the stomach, every Wednesday and Saturday, in the two hours between the tram and the curfew, because her mother had gone to work and she had to exist somewhere, and had found, in the dark under the coal, the only friend in Warsaw who could be trusted not to be able to tell.

“They let me out at two,” Marysia said, out of the dark. “They let me out because I can sew, and the sewing is all done, so I came here. Nobody saw me. I came through the courtyard with the wash basket like Pani Zofia said.”

“Marysia.” Wanda’s voice, she was glad to hear, was entirely calm. “Where is your mother?”

“At the laundry until six. She said she’d come here at seven.”

“Good.” Wanda sat down on the box by the door and looked at the two girls in the last of the daylight from the coal chute: one eight years old and hidden for her blood, and one nine years old and hidden for her father, and the two of them together in the dark, sewing, two children in a cellar in the fifth year of the war, doing the same thing in the same way, which was to make themselves unfindable.

She had known, of course, that Helena Wojtera’s child was not on the transport lists; you heard things in the welfare office; the women in the courtyard talked. She had not known that the child was out of the camp on a regular basis and playing, on Wednesdays and Saturdays, in the same cellar as Rachel Perel, and the knowledge hit her in the middle of the chest the way the knowledge always did, with the picture that came with it: a cordon, a search, a dog, and two girls in a nest of coats, their two lives hanging on the same nail.

At seven o’clock Helena came, with the smell of the laundry on her and a paper parcel under her coat, and after the two children had eaten the bread and the sugar, and after Marysia had been sent up, through the courtyard, to her own room, with the basket, and the door had shut on the last of the daylight, Wanda said what she had come to say, and she said it without anything in front of it.

“The girl in the cellar must go.”

Helena sat down on the box, slowly, and looked at the dark.

“She’s been here since February,” she said. “Nobody has come. I feed her out of my own ration and she never goes into the courtyard, she never goes to the window. She is the safest thing in this house.”

“She is the least safe thing in this house, and you know it, and I will tell you why, and then there is something I am going to ask you, and it is a thing that will make you hate

me.” Wanda leaned forward. “In February there were two hundred people in this district looking for Jewish children, and they were looking with their ears, in the courtyards, at the gates. In June there are six hundred, because the ghetto has been destroyed and there is nothing left in the ruins for them to catch, so they are all here now, on this side, in the courtyards, at the gates. Do you understand what has changed? In February there were people who cared about nothing, and the ones who cared were a special kind of man, and their price was known. Now the szmalcowniks are ordinary men: a concierge, a taxi driver, a caretaker, a boy from a bakery. In February a child in a cellar was a secret. In June a child in a cellar is a rumour, and the whole profession of this city has one ear on the courtyard and one ear on the stairs, and a child in a cellar makes a noise, Pani Wojtera: the bedding, the coughing, the coal moved at four in the morning when your neighbours are awake and their windows are open because it is June.”

Helena was silent. The coal shifted in the bin with a small dry sound.

“On Friday night,” Wanda said, “I can move her. I have a place in the country, beyond Grodzisk, a farm, the man is a cousin of the man who fixes my roof. He has kept two children and a woman since 1941 and the village thinks they are his wife’s sister’s children. A child of eight on a farm: a labour unit, another pair of hands, the sort of child every Polish farm has. She will sleep in a bed. She will go out of doors. In two years she will be a village girl who can milk a cow.” She looked at the shape of Helena in the dark. “And if the man is denounced, they will shoot him and his wife and burn the farm, and the children will be taken, and it will be because I sent them.”

“Then why are you telling me?”

“Because the place is one place and there are four children on my list for it, and I am going to take the one who is in the most danger, so I have to decide which of the four that is, and I have been deciding it for a week, and I have decided it tonight, in your cellar.” Wanda’s voice was quite level. “Not because your girl is dearer to God. Because the arithmetic is the arithmetic. Rachel is eight, she is Jewish, she has no papers at all, and if she is found, they take her to Szucha and they find out in four hours through the caretaker’s son that there was a flat above the coal bin. Your daughter has a labour card with a German signature on it, and a camp number, and a mother with papers, and if she is found in your cellar she can say — and she will say, because you will have taught her — that she was playing in the yard and came down out of the rain, and she will be believed, because she is a Polish girl with a Polish record, and the most that will happen is that you will lose your labour card, and the worst that will happen is that you will be taken to Szucha and interrogated for three days and released with your teeth gone. That is not the same risk as Rachel’s. You know that it is not. You have known it for months. You have simply refused to say it out loud, and I have come here to say it out loud for you.”

Helena put her hand over her mouth.

“The transport leaves the East Station on Friday at six in the afternoon; the man who takes the child will be at the number 8 tram stop at Zawiszy at four with a cart and a barrel of salt fish, and she will go in the barrel, and I will come here at half past three to fetch her.” Wanda stood up. “It costs eleven hundred zlotys.”

“Eleven hundred zlotys.”

“For the transport, the papers, and the first three months of the farm, and then two hundred a month, in envelopes, from you, by the hand of the priest at St

Barbara's, and if the money stops, I will bring her back to you, because the man's family eats the same as everyone else and I will not lie to him about that either." Wanda pulled on her gloves. "You have a hundred and ten zlotys from your father's watch. I know, because the man at the pawnshop on Żelazna buys for us sometimes and he mentioned your name, which is a thing I will come to in a moment. Where is the rest?"

Helena said, in a voice that did not sound like her own: "The violin."

"A Hopf? You could get six or seven thousand from the right buyer, and a thousand from the wrong one, and a thousand is what I need."

"Not the violin. I'll find it another way."

"There is no other way, and I have to know by Friday morning, and I have to know tonight, so that I can tell the man with the salt fish." Wanda looked down at her, and her heavy face was, for one moment, nothing but tired. "I have taken four hundred and six children out of this city in three years and I have buried sixty of them. I am telling you this not to impress you but to make you understand that I am not your friend and not your enemy. I am a woman with a list, and your child's name is on it — not on this list, on the other list, the one that thinks it is saving her with papers from the Wehrmacht — and I have known for two weeks that somebody on the other side is holding a door open for your daughter, because a labour reserve that survives a racial examination in Skaryszewska in the spring of 1943 does not happen; it is done."

Helena's hands were cold. "How do you know about the examination?"

"Because a clerk in the labour office talks to a woman in my office, because that is how everything in this city comes out in the end, like water coming through a wall." Wanda

put her gloves on. “And I will say this one thing to you, Pani Wojtera, and then I will go, and then we will do business on Friday like two strangers discussing a barrel of salt fish. Whoever he is, whatever he is, that German who is keeping your child off the race list — he is not doing it because he is a good man. Good men in that building sign papers that send other people’s children to Braunschweig, and I have the lists to prove it. He is doing it because your daughter is his business, and a man’s business is the thing he dies for, and in this war, when a German dies, he does not die alone. He takes his house with him. He takes his name, his family, his photographs, and the Poles who touched his hand.”

She was at the foot of the steps when Helena said: “I don’t know the rest. The money.”

“You have a violin,” Wanda said. “And in the ledger of the things I have asked people to give up, there is a wedding ring, a piano, a silver samovar, six teeth, and a son. The violin is a violin.”

She came up out of the cellar into the courtyard at half past seven. The acacias were in leaf and the light was golden and ordinary, and there were boys on the shed roof, and two women at the well, and Pani Halina Rowińska at her window with her elbows on the sill, and a tram going by in Hoża Street with a German soldier riding on the back platform; and on the bench under the second acacia, sitting with his legs out and his hat on his knee, was a small neat man of about fifty with a chin that went back into his collar like a man who has spent his life being careful with his face.

He had a notebook open on his knee. He was writing in it with a pencil, slowly, in a way that Wanda Ostrowska, who had spent three years learning to recognize the shape of a man writing down a person’s face, recognized at a distance of thirty metres the way a doctor recognizes a fever across

a room.

She walked past him without turning her head, out through the gate, into Hoża Street. She did not hurry. She had a red cross armband on her left arm and a welfare card in her bag and a face like a stone; and behind her, in the courtyard, the man with the notebook looked up from his writing and watched her go, and then looked back at the thing he had written, which was this:

W. Ostrowska, welfare, Marszałkowska 72, boots like a man. Wk. 411 ledger.

and under it, on a new line, in the neat small hand of a man who sells names in a city where a name is worth more than a man:

Wojtera, H., Hoża 14. Music teacher. Out of Skaryszewska 22/v. Child in camp = interest. Ask at the laundry.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Photograph

Warsaw — Thursday, 10 June 1943

The invitation to the racial examination came on Tuesday in a grey official envelope with no stamp on it, delivered by a Polish postman who had learned, in three years, to hold such envelopes delicately, as if they might go off in his hands.

It said that the examination of the minor Maria Anna Wojtera would take place at the Institute for Racial Hygiene, Aleja Szucha 25A, second floor, room 4, on Thursday 10 June at 10.00 hours; that the mother should attend with the child, if the child were at liberty, or without the child, if not, in which case the child would be examined at the place of detention; that the mother should bring all documents relating to the family history of the child, in particular any documents concerning the father; that statements would be taken under oath; and that non-attendance would be noted and would be considered a refusal to cooperate in the establishment of the racial status of the child, with consequences.

The words *consequences* and *refusal to cooperate* had been printed in the same weight of type as the words *Aleja Szucha* and *10.00 hours*, and Helena had read the whole of it standing in the courtyard at Hoża 14 in the middle of the day, with the loaf in her other hand, and had then gone up to her room and put the envelope on the table and sat down in front of it and looked at it the way a person looks at a train ticket to a country they have heard about.

On Thursday morning she put on her best blouse, and the good grey skirt that she had kept for the conservatory, and her mother's small cameo, which was not valuable and had no gold in it and was therefore still in the family, and she did her hair, which had grown out into a short dark cap with a fringe, and she looked at herself in the little mirror in the corner of the room for a long minute, and she thought, as she had thought every morning for ten years when she had looked into a mirror: *bar eleven, from the top, slowly.*

Then she walked across the city to Aleja Szucha.

The children were examined at ten and the adults at eleven, and so the waiting room on the second floor of the building at Aleja Szucha 25A was, when Helena came into it at a quarter to ten, full of Polish women with children: eleven women and fourteen children, in a room with a bench along the wall, a table with a lamp, a portrait of the Führer with his mouth slightly open, and a smell of new paint over an older smell of mould and cigarettes.

In the middle of the room, on two chairs that had been pushed together, sat three German women in the grey of the Rasse-und-Siedlungswesen service: a typist with a card index on her knee, a nurse, and, standing with her back to the window and her hands folded, a woman of about thirty in a well-cut green suit, with a white blouse and a little bunch of lilac pinned to the lapel and fair hair rolled at the back of her neck, who was looking at the children with a very particular expression.

It was the expression, Helena thought afterwards, of a woman looking at goods in a shop window. Not greed. Not cruelty. Something worse and simpler: the look of a person who had decided what she was going to buy, who had come with the money, and who was now examining the wares with the practised eye of someone who has been told that

her money is good for one purchase only.

“Maria Anna Wojtera?” the typist said, reading from her index.

“Here.”

“And the child?”

“The child is at Skaryszewska. The labour office has her in the sorting detail.”

The nurse and the typist exchanged a look; the woman in green wrote something on a small pad with a gold pencil. And then the typist said, “Both files are here. Take a seat on the bench, and wait.” And the woman in the green suit turned round and looked at her, Helena Wojtera of Hoża 14, in her best blouse and her mother’s cameo; and a small movement crossed her face, sharper than anything else that would happen to either of them that day, and was gone.

The examination was at eleven, and it took an hour and twenty minutes; and when Helena came out of room 4 into the corridor, with her back cold and her hands shaking and her ears ringing, she walked to the end of the corridor where the window was, because she could not be seen at the window and could not see anybody either, and stood there and put her forehead against the glass, and made herself be breathless two or three times, and then stood straight again and looked at the courtyard below, where two young men in shirtsleeves were unloading a lorry of cardboard files.

The room had been small and hot, with the window shut, because the doctor from Posen did not like draughts; and the doctor from Posen had been a man of about forty-five, a doctor of medicine and philosophy called Alfred Teichmann, with a soft, patient, absent face, and hands like a woman’s, and an air of gentle exactness that was the most terrifying thing Helena had ever been examined by. He had had a

notebook and a pair of calipers and an eye for skulls; and on the wall behind his desk there had been a chart of the SS race classifications, and on the desk beside the inkstand a small brass instrument for measuring the angle of the nose; and he had said, in the quiet voice, the first sentence, which was: “Pani Wojtera, this examination is not a punishment. It is a service to the child. We are here to establish whether the child’s race allows her to be saved from the fate of her mother’s people. Please be seated.”

He had asked her about her mother and her father, about her grandparents, about their names and dates and places: her father Stanisław Wojtera, born Żoliborz 1878, an engineer on the Wilno line, died 1939; her mother Zofia née Kwiatkowska, born Piaseczno 1882, died 1938; her grandparents, four of them, with their four villages; and about the child’s father, about whom she gave him Adam Wójcik, born Grodno 1904, a railwayman, killed by a shunting engine in the spring of 1933, the month before the child was conceived.

“Killed by an engine,” Teichmann said, and wrote it down. “In Grodno.”

“In the yards at Grodno.”

“And the parish register of Grodno would show the burial.”

“He was a Calvinist,” Helena said. “There was no burial in a Catholic register, and the Calvinist books were taken away by the Russians in 1940. There is nothing. That is the truth of it.”

“That is very convenient,” the doctor said, gently; and looked at her for a long moment with his soft patient eyes and tapped the brass instrument on the blotter, one small tap, and said: “Now, Pani Wojtera, we will do the part that you were not told about in the letter. Please stand.”

The child, of course, was not there. So they had used the mother; and the mother they had put in the middle of the floor and taken to the window, where the light was best, and measured: the height of her, the span of her arms, the length of her skull and the breadth of it, the circumference of the head before and behind, the nasal angle, the shape of the jaw, the colour of the eyes and the colour of the hair and the height of the shin; and they had asked her to put out her hands, palms up, one then the other, and had measured the length of each finger against each other finger; and they had asked her, in the middle of it, to unbutton her blouse for the examination of the chest, which she did, in front of the nurse, and then to turn round, to the light, to the light, and down to the straps, which she refused in Polish, and Teichmann, after a moment, had said, "It is of no consequence. We shall have the child's photograph; the mother's measurements are corroborative only."

Then the photographs: front and both profiles, with her hair held back by the nurse with two fingers. And then he had put the sheet in front of her, the *Familienbogen*, and read out to her the three questions, slowly, in the quiet voice, and had written her answers in his neat German hand.

German ancestry within three generations: none, to my knowledge.

Father of the child: Adam Wójcik, railwayman, of Grodno, deceased.

Consent of the mother to examination and to the entry of the child in the register of persons of doubtful race: given.

And then he had done the last thing, the thing she had not been prepared for, and it was the reason she was standing with her forehead against the window of the corridor of Aleja Szucha 25A with her back cold and her

ears ringing: he had taken from the file, and put down flat on the desk between them, side by side, like two cards in a game of patience, both halves of her life.

Two photographs and one card index entry.

The first photograph was of Marysia: taken, she could see at once, in the basement of the labour office at Skaryszewska in the last week of May, three views, front and two profiles, in the striped rag-sorting shirt with the collar open, the shaven head grown out into a dark fuzz, the eyes grey and steady and enormous in the thin face. The second photograph was of Helena herself: one of the three the nurse had taken twenty minutes earlier in front of the window, in which she looked, she thought, like a woman being arrested.

And the card, in the typed German of the labor office, said:

Wojtera, Maria Anna. b. 3.12.1933, Warsaw. Mother: Wojtera, Helena, b. 1910, Warsaw, violinist, war-employed. Father: allegedly Wójcik, Adam, deceased Grodno 1933. Physical findings: dark hair with a slight wave; grey-blue eyes; oval face; high forehead; stature for age above mean; musical aptitude noted in mother. Photogrammetric comparison of mother and child: the ear form does not correspond. Reference: Rasse-und-Siedlungsamt Posen, petition 2188/43.

And under that, in Teichmann's own hand, at the bottom of the card, the sentence that Helena had read upside down on the desk before the doctor turned it round with two fingers, the way a man turns round a card he is about to play:

Übereinstimmung geprüft — kein. Fall vorläufig offen.

Correspondence checked — none. Case provisionally open.

He had let her read it. That was the thing: he had turned the card to her for one second, deliberately, gently, like a nurse showing a patient the wound; and then he had said, in the quiet, patient voice, “You may dress. The child will be examined at the place of detention on the twenty-fourth. You will be informed of the finding. Do you have anything to say to me?”

And Helena had stood in the middle of the room with her blouse in her hands and her back to the chart of the race classifications on the wall, and had said: “Only that the child’s father was a Polish railwayman of Grodno, and that if you write anything else in that register, you will be writing a lie in a book that will outlive both of us.” Which was, she understood at once from the flicker of surprise in his soft eyes, the single most dangerous sentence she had ever said to a German, and the only sentence in the whole hour and twenty minutes that had been entirely true.

Now the woman in the green suit came along the corridor and stopped in front of the window, and stood looking out at the courtyard, and the two of them were side by side with a metre of polished floor between them.

“You are the mother,” the woman said, in German.

“I am.”

“Then we shall not pretend. It is always better not to pretend; I discovered that in Posen.” She had a small gold pencil in her fingers, and she turned it over and over, and her hands were white and cared-for and shaking, very finely, the way a person’s hands shake after a long wait. “The petition in the file at the bottom of your daughter’s card is mine. Petition 2188. I made it a year ago, after the armistice in the east was announced and we had a Te Deum in Posen, and my husband was killed in Russia, and my brother-in-law’s little boy died that same winter, and there has been no child in the family since; and I said to the office

that if a suitable child of German blood were found in the General Government, I would want to be considered. That was a year ago. I did not know your name. Nobody knows the names in the file; the file has numbers in it, and the numbers have photographs when they are old enough, and I have had the photograph of the girl in the striped shirt on my table for eleven days."

The corridor was empty. At the far end, behind the closed door of room 4, a woman was crying with the flat, unending monotony of a person whose crying has become a place she lives in.

"What do you want?" Helena said.

"I want to say two things to you, and then I shall go and we shall never speak again, and it will be as if I had never spoken." The woman's hands went on turning the pencil. "The first thing is: the file says *correspondence checked — none*. That means the doctor found that the girl's ear does not match your ear, and he has written it down, and a doctor's note of a physical discrepancy in a doubtful case goes to Posen, and the men who sit in Posen with the papers have a waiting list of one hundred and eleven families. The girl's photograph is on that list now, and so is mine; mine is at the top, because I have been waiting a year, and the others know it, and they are angry about it, and last week somebody wrote to Berlin about me." She turned the pencil over. "The second thing is a question, and if you answer it truthfully, you may save the child's life; and if you lie to me I will know, because I have spent four hours in a room with your daughter's photograph. Is the father of that girl a German?"

Helena looked at the courtyard below, at the two young men unloading the files, at the lorry with the blackout lamps, at the small patch of pale June sky over Warsaw.

"No," she said.

"No." The woman nodded, slowly, as though she had been given a piece of paper with a sum on it and had checked the sum and found it correct. "Then I shall tell you the thing you are going to need, and you will remember, if you live, that it was given to you by a woman you do not know, in bad faith, out of decency, and that those three things can be true at the same time." She put the gold pencil into her bag. "There is a charitable organization in the General Government: the Zentrale für Kinderfürsorge, a woman named Frau Doktor Fischer runs its office in Kraków. Every child on the Posen list who passes the examination and is found German comes to the Zentrale before it goes to a family, and every child whose case remains open — like your daughter's — is transferred to the Zentrale's custody when the labour office closes the case with the note *kein* on it. The Zentrale's custody is a building on Krakowskie Przedmieście, a very clean building, with a very good kitchen, where the children are held for four to twelve weeks, and it is the only institution in the whole apparatus where a child's file can be made to go quietly to sleep, because the Zentrale is run by a woman who counts nothing. If you want your daughter to live, she must get to that building; and the way through that building is not a mother's tears, it is a man's signature; and you look to me like a woman who has found herself a man's signature."

And she turned and walked back down the corridor in her well-cut green suit, with the lilac on her lapel, and went down the stairs and out; and Helena stood at the window for two minutes more, and then she went down the stairs and out of the building herself, past the great door and the sentry box and the dark green trees of Aleja Szucha, into the ordinary June morning, and walked west towards the centre of the city; and it was at the corner of Marszałkowska that she noticed the black car.

She noticed it the way a person notices a thing they have already been waiting for: a black pre-war Adler saloon standing at the curb with its engine running and the driver at the wheel and the windows down, in a street where a car standing at the curb was an event. It had been behind her, she thought, at the corner of Bagatela: she had heard it, and had not turned her head. It had passed her at Plac Zbawiciela and then slowed, and now it was standing.

She walked on. She crossed Marszałkowska at the tram stop, and went up towards Krucza with her head down, and the car came alongside and kept pace with her, and the rear window came down, and a man's voice said, in German: "Pani Wojtera."

She did not break step. She looked round because a person to whom a black car speaks must look round; and inside the car was a man of about thirty-six in a grey civilian overcoat and a brown hat, with a long pale face and a small mustache and a folder of buff folders on the seat beside him, and he was eating a piece of chocolate, and he broke off another piece and offered it to her through the window in its silver paper.

"Obersturmführer Dörffel," he said. "Security Police, Department Four. You need not take the chocolate; most people do not, and I do not mind; I am told I am sinister with chocolate." He broke the piece off, small and tidy. "I have been reading about you this morning. The Institute sent us a note, which is a very proper thing for the Institute to do, because a signature from the Wehrmacht came into the Wojtera file in the last week of May, and when a signature from the Wehrmacht comes into a file in this city, my department is required to consider whether it was a mistake. Almost always it is a mistake. A clerk in the Wehrmacht office is told by a friend, and he puts his signature on a paper, and the paper goes into a drawer, and

no one ever looks at it, and the whole thing is a mistake, and it dies quietly." He looked at her with pale eyes that were neither friendly nor unfriendly, and his voice was the voice of a man who has once been a lawyer and has never forgotten how to sound reasonable. "But this paper was not a mistake, Pani Wojtera, and I am looking at you, and you are not a mistake either. So may I ask you, unofficially, in the street, on a Thursday: what business does an unmarried Polish music teacher who was released from a transit camp on the twenty-second of May have with a Major of the Wehrmacht commandant's office in this city?"

The tram went past, full, with a German sitting on the back platform with his legs dangling; and two boys went by on bicycles, and a woman with a pram, and a man selling cigarettes out of a box slung round his neck, and the city went on its way around them in the June sun.

Helena looked into the car at the man in the brown hat, and felt, all at once, not fear but a curious cold steadiness, the feeling of a person who has been working all her life for a thing and now hears the key turn in the lock.

"He was an old friend of my father's," she said.

"An old friend of your father's," Dörffel repeated. He did not smile; he wrote, or seemed to write, nothing; he ate the last of the chocolate in two bites, folded the silver paper into a square and put it into his pocket, like a man tidying his desk. "Very well. I am going to do something now that I should not do, and you may take it however you like, and if you mention it to anyone I shall deny it." He leaned forward so that his shoulder was against the window frame, and for a moment, with the sun on it, his long pale face looked almost kind. "The Wehrmacht office on Nowy Świat is going to receive a letter from me asking for the Wojtera file. I already know what the file says; I have the copy. What I want to see is what the Major does with the letter. You may

think about that however you please; there is no answer to it. What matters to you — and this is the only thing I have said today that I mean — is that a Polish woman who becomes the reason for anything in this city becomes a file, and a file is read by everybody, and in this city a file that has been read by everybody is a wall with names on it." He tapped the window frame twice with two fingers, the way one knocks on wood. "Good day to you, Pani Wojtera. Give my compliments to your daughter's teacher of music."

The window went up. The car pulled out into the traffic of Marszałkowska and turned right towards the river, and Helena stood at the edge of the pavement, in the middle of the flowing current of people that goes up and down that street all day, and heard her own heart, and looked at her own two hands, which were perfectly steady.

Then she thought, with a clarity that felt like a hand closing round her throat:

He said: give my compliments to your daughter's teacher of music.

Marysia has no teacher of music.

Unless it is the one who comes to the wire on Tuesdays and Saturdays, and stands in the visitors' yard with the guard five metres away, and says nothing for a whole hour except the number of a bar.

. . .

Warsaw — Saturday, 12 June 1943

The man from the pawnshop called at the laundry on the Saturday, which took a certain kind of nerve, and he did it in the right way, which Helena noted: he came at the change of the shift, in the crowd, and he stood at the gate with a newspaper, and when she came out he fell in beside her and walked with her as though he were her cousin from the country, and said, before she had even decided to look

at him:

“Don’t stop walking and don’t put your hand in your bag. I’m not going to rob you; I’m going to make you an offer, and you are going to want to hear it, because I already know one thing about you that you would pay to keep quiet, and I have not sold it, and I have not sold it because I am a businessman and not a butcher, and the difference between a businessman and a butcher is that the businessman wants you alive next year.”

“You know nothing about me,” Helena said.

“I know that your child is at Skaryszewska in the sorting detail, which half of Hoża Street knows; and I know from a clerk at the labour office — I buy him cigarettes, he tells me nothing, it’s the other way round: he tells me everything and I buy him cigarettes — that a Wehrmacht Major in the Referat has written your daughter into a labour plan, and no Wehrmacht Major writes a child of nine into a labour plan. So what I know,” said Wacek Górski, “is that there is a German officer in this city who has a reason to do something about your family, and in this city a reason is a thing that people pay to hear about, and there are two prices at which I could sell it. The cheap price is to the men who buy names for Szucha: eight hundred zlotys and a receipt, and they would have your daughter out of the camp in a week and you would never see her again, or you would see her once, at an address in Aleja Szucha, and then never. The expensive price is to you: I keep my mouth shut about the Major, and about the child, and about the woman from the welfare office with the boots, and I do it for a modest standing arrangement.”

They walked past the tram stop and past the church. Helena looked straight ahead, at the grey street, at two Polish policemen on the corner with their hands behind their backs, at the queue outside the butcher’s shop, at the

wet paper in the gutter.

"How much?"

"Two thousand, now; four hundred a month after; and I will tell you what you are buying: silence, and, more useful to you, information. I am a bad man, Pani Wojtera, and a bad man in this city hears things, and the things I hear are for sale to my clients before they are for sale to Szucha, because Szucha pays in favours and clients pay in gold. Also I will buy the violin."

"What violin?"

"The Hopf. Your father's. You pawned the watch on the twenty-second of May at Kostecki's and you kept the violin, and the man at Kostecki's mentioned it because men who pawn watches at Kostecki's always have a violin somewhere, and I looked it up in the register of the Szymanowski school: the instrument was entered by your late father, Stanisław Wojtera, engineer, Wilno line, first violin, and the school's register notes it as a Hopf of about 1790 with a repaired wing. I'll give you eighteen hundred for it and you can keep it in the flat and play it on Sundays, because what I want is the paper, not the wood; I sell the paper to a man in Kraków who sells it back to the estate of the family it was stolen from in 1939. Everything in this city is stolen twice. That is the whole of my philosophy."

"Eighteen hundred zlotys for a violin worth six thousand."

"Eighteen hundred for a violin worth six thousand, and I pay it in a week, and you keep the violin, and the money is real, and it is the only offer of real money you will get this year that does not come with a German in it." He stopped walking. They were at the corner of Krucza and Hoża, and the man from the pawnshop took off his hat and looked at her with a small, honest, entirely conscienceless face. "Think about it until Thursday. But think about the first

price too, Pani Wojtera, because the first price is the price of a thing I already know, and I am going to go on being a businessman on Thursday whether you have made a decision or not."

She walked home. She went up to her room and opened the case, and took out her father's violin, which she could only play at night with the window shut and a cloth in the f-holes, and held it in her two hands, and looked at the wing, which had been repaired in 1921 by a man in Wilno with a piece of wood from a church door, and thought about how many things in a person's life can be sold before the person herself is sold, and made a small, exact, practical list:

The violin: she would not sell it. That was the only thing on the list that was not negotiable, and not for sentiment: because the child needed to know, whatever else was taken from her, that her mother had kept something; and because a violin in the house was a future, and there was no other object in Warsaw in 1943 that could be called that.

The rest of the list was: the room, the furniture, the coat, the ring, herself.

She did not have a plan yet. But she had, from that afternoon, the beginning of the only kind of plan that anyone in Warsaw had in the summer of 1943, which was a ledger: a page on which she wrote what she still had, and what each thing was worth, and what each thing could buy, and in what order, and from whom, and the leaving of a space at the bottom of the page for the price that had no name yet, the price that she would pay to the man in the brown hat or to the man with the notebook or to the Major in the grey tunic, when the day came that the child's name was the only object she owned that anybody in the Reich was willing to buy.

. . .

Skaryszewska — Thursday, 24 June 1943

They came for her at the breakfast hour, and it was, Marysia thought, the best time of the day, because at breakfast the bread was warm and you could sit next to Fela and put the crusts in her pocket for her, so of course that was when they came.

The room over the gate was three and a half metres by two, with a barred window and a table and two chairs and a plaster saint's head in a niche, from which a school child had long ago scratched out both eyes, and Marysia had seen it from below in the yard and had thought it was the prison, and now here she was in it, sitting on the chair with her feet not touching the floor, and there was nobody else in the room except a German nurse with a card of printed numbers and a man in a grey uniform with a long thin nose and soft white hands who was called Herr Doktor and who had brought a bag with instruments in it.

The nurse measured her. The doctor sat in the other chair and watched, and asked questions in a low voice, and wrote the answers in a notebook, and the things he measured went into a printed card with squares, and the squares were for the length of her skull and the width of her skull and the length of her middle finger and the height of her forehead and the angle of her nose, and when the measuring instrument was put on her nose the metal was cold, and Marysia thought about the buttons: *eins, zwei, drei, vier*, and did not move, and did not laugh, and did not cry.

"Now the eyes," the nurse said.

"*Bitte*," the doctor said. "The child is quick; let her answer in German; it is a good sign for the file. Your name?"

"Maria Anna Wojtera."

"A Polish name. And the German for what you are doing in the camp?" He said it gently, spreading his long hands. "The work?"

"*Sortieren*. *Knöpfe*." Marysia said it flat and dull, the voice of a girl repeating the shouted orders of guards: "*Eins, zwei, drei, vier, fünf, sechs, sieben, acht, neun, zehn.* I can do it fast if you want it fast."

The doctor's pen stopped. He looked at her, and for the first time he looked at her as a person, which was worse than all the instruments, because when he looked at her as a person he had a face, and the face was patient and kindly, and it said, without any words at all: *I am going to open you up now.*

"Who taught you to count like that?"

"Nobody. I learn from the guards."

"And who taught you the words in German?"

"Nobody."

"Child, you spoke German in the yard last week. I have the note. You said a whole sentence to the girl with the fever: *du musst Wasser trinken*. Somebody taught you that."

"Nobody. The doctor is mistaken. Fela doesn't speak, and I don't speak, and the sentence was Polish."

"The sentence was in German, and there is a note, and it is in the file; and in the file there are also your measurements, and the photograph of your mother, and the note of the Institute in the case of your mother, and the note says that the ear in the photograph of the mother does not correspond to the ear of the child; and there is a card of my colleague's, in Posen, which says that a child of this age with this brow and these hands sings on pitch." He put down the pen and folded his hands, and his voice was quiet and entirely reasonable. "Maria Anna, I am not a

policeman. I am a doctor. Nobody in this building is going to hurt you, and whatever you tell me here will not be used against your mother. Now: who was your father?"

"Adam Wójcik," she said. "He was a railwayman. He died before I was born."

The doctor looked at her for a long time, and then he smiled, and it was the smile of a man who has finally confirmed an arithmetic. "Yes," he said, and picked up the pen, and wrote, and the nib went over the paper in long clean strokes. "Every child in Warsaw says that sentence with exactly your face. It is the best-taught sentence in the General Government."

He gave her a chocolate — a real one, in silver paper — and she did not eat it, and did not throw it away. She carried it in the pocket of the grey shirt for four days, and in the end she gave it to Fela, who did not eat it either, and who put it, with the other things she had been given in her life — a pencil, a button, a piece of blue glass, a doll stitched out of army cloth — in the nest she had made under the corner of her mattress; so that the chocolate of the Institut für Rassenhygiene went, in the end, into the archive of a three-year-old child.

Going down the stairs, past the door of the camp office, Marysia looked into the outer room through the open door, and there were three German women sitting on the bench with their gloves on their laps, and one of them was a woman in a green suit with a small bunch of lilac pinned to her collar, who had been in the office corridor when they brought Marysia in, and who looked at her now as she went past with an expression that Marysia did not understand and would remember for the rest of her life: the expression of a person looking at a window in a house they cannot afford, in a street they will walk down every day for years.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Dead City

Warsaw — Wednesday, 14 July 1943

The order came on a Monday: the Kommandantur was to provide a survey of quartering possibilities in the "former Jewish residential district" for a work detachment of eight hundred men, in connection with a clearance and salvage programme in the ruins. Leutnant Adler brought the file in and put it on Friedrich's desk, and Friedrich looked at the order for a long time, at the letterhead of the Bauleitung of the Waffen-SS and the Hauptamt für Raumordnung, and then looked out of the window, and said, "Very well. Wednesday. The car."

"Why not Oberzahlmeister Wollweber?" Adler said. "He has the quartering lists."

"Because Wollweber has not gone east of the cordon since 1941 and would come back and tell me that the district is full of valuable salvage and I should requisition it for the shops," Friedrich said. "And because I want to see it myself. Bring the sketch map from 1939, and the key to the Gęsiówka gate, and Kellner."

"Shall I come, Herr Major?"

Friedrich looked at the young man for a moment. Klaus Adler had a nice face, brown and open, and he had been in Warsaw seven weeks; before that he had been a company officer in white Russia, where, in the winter of 1942, he had been in a village on the Beresina with a rifle company and had, according to the letter his own colonel had written him, conducted himself well; and before that he had been in

a Labour Service camp and in the Hitler Youth and in a family in Pforzheim that had a shop and four sons in the Wehrmacht. He was eager and clean and punctual and had never once, in seven weeks, said a false thing about the General Government in Friedrich's hearing.

"No," Friedrich said. "You will stay and dispose of the morning's mail. Write to the commandant's office that the survey will be delivered on Friday, with a covering note explaining that the district contains no quartering of any military value."

"Officer quarters?"

"None of any military value," Friedrich said, "is what you will write."

He said it mildly, and Adler looked at him for a moment with the small, closed, watchful expression that came over his face whenever Friedrich made the flat statements that officers were not supposed to make, and then said, "Yes, Herr Major," and gathered the files and went out; and Friedrich sat for a moment looking after him, and was aware, as he had been aware since the day in the Saxon Garden, of the young man's eyes.

. . .

Tuesday, 13 July 1943

Ritter sent for him at noon and did it with coffee, which was a bad sign.

"Sit down. Help yourself. It is real; my wife sends it from Silesia in the field post and I am reduced to hiding it from my adjutant." The General waited until Friedrich had the cup in his hand, and then took off his spectacles and rubbed the bridge of his nose, and said, in the tone of a man discussing garden drainage: "Now. Szucha."

"Herr General."

“Obersturmführer Dörffel has written to me — not to you; to me, in my own name, which is the courtesy of a man who wants an answer that has been given some thought — and he has asked me, in eleven lines of perfect German, whether the Wehrmacht-Kommandantur Warschau has employed its staff officers to intervene in the racial and labour classification of Polish civilians not in its service; and whether the pattern of correspondence in the Referat für Arbeitseinsatz is the pattern of an office doing its work or of a man doing his.” Ritter put the spectacles back on. “I have known Dörffel’s type since 1913. He was a lawyer before the war, in Kiel, and he took a bullet in the leg at the Somme, and he wears no decorations, and in the five years since this business began he has never once been in a hurry. A man who is not in a hurry is a man who intends to still be in the room when everybody else has left. He is not going to arrest you, Friedrich. He is going to watch you until the day he can arrest you, and on that day he will have everything, because he will have had a year to collect it, and the reason he will have had a year is that he enjoys the collecting.”

“What do you advise, Herr General?”

“I advise the truth, but not to him.” Ritter pushed a sheet of paper across the desk: the carbon of Klara’s answer to the first Szucha letter, the one in May. “This is a good document. It gives the facts, it gives the regulation, it gives nothing else, and it was typed by a girl who cannot be broken because she does not know anything. There are four more like it on my file now, and the file makes a shape I do not like, and I am going to say a thing to you that I have said once before in my life, in 1917, to a captain on my own staff, and it was true then and it is true now.” He leaned forward. “You are a Prussian officer and you are behaving like a missionary. Missionaries die, and they take their

sergeants with them. If you cannot stop — and I look at you and I see that you cannot stop; it is your father's face, he had it too, he had it at Verdun and it is the reason he was not a general — then for God's sake be better at it. Buy nothing in cash. Write nothing in your own hand that you would not read out at a court martial. Never go twice to the same door. And never, ever let anybody see you care about one particular Pole, because the moment a man in that building sees that you care, that Pole is not a person any more, that Pole is a lever."

"Yes, Herr General."

"Now get out, and take the coffee cup with you, and tell my adjutant that I want the Polish-language newspaper files for the last fortnight. I am going to be reading about the cinema." Ritter began to sign letters, and then, as Friedrich reached the door: "The Führer's birthday is in April, Friedrich, and the staff's ceremonial duties for next year will be worked out in the autumn. If the war is still going on then, I intend to be a general with a clean record and a very dull file." Sign. "I mention it in connection with nothing at all."

. . .

Aleja Szucha 25A — Tuesday afternoon

The Institute for Racial Hygiene occupied the fourth floor of the building next to the Security Police, with its own staircase from the courtyard, so that persons visiting the Institute did not have to walk past the cells of the Security Police, which was, Friedrich thought as he went up, a piece of architectural thoughtfulness that told you everything about what the German state thought of science.

A clerk took his card and left him in an anteroom for twenty minutes with a copy of the *Deutsche Allgemeine*

Zeitung and a poster on the wall that showed a family of clean-limbed children standing in a field of rye, under the words *Haltet rein Euer Blut* — keep your blood pure — and Friedrich read the newspaper's financial page, and turned it, and turned it again, and did not look at the poster.

The file on Maria Anna Wojtera was a folder two centimetres thick, and he was given it on the written authority of the Referat, and he sat at a small table in the anteroom and read it from the beginning, and it took an hour and a quarter, and at the end of it he had one name, one number, and a coldness in his stomach that he recognized from the dead city.

The contents were in order, and that was the horror of them. A four-page Familienbogen, with the mother's statements under oath. Three photographs of the child, front and two profiles, taken in the basement at Skaryszewska on the twenty-seventh of May, and three of the mother, taken on the tenth of June. A sheet of measurements. A note of the mother's family history, with the villages of four grandparents. A note, in Teichmann's hand, on the discrepancy of the ear, and the sentence *Fall vorläufig offen* — case provisionally open. A note on the child's musical aptitude, with a doctor's arrow and the single word *verwertbar?* — exploitable? And on the last page, a form with a stamp in the top left corner, an identification number typed at the top, and, in the space marked *Anträge und Vorbehalte* — applications and caveats:

Petition 2188/43 (Rasse- und Siedlungsamt Posen): claim of suitability for Germanization of a female child of German blood, applicant: Brandt, Ilse, widow, Posen, Karlstrasse 9. Registered 2 June 1943, priority by date of application 21 June 1942. Recommended for consideration on completion of the racial finding. Cross-reference: list 4 of 9 September

1941 (childless women, Reichsgau Wartheland); the applicant's original entry, superseded by this claim. Priority by date of application: 21 June 1942.

Friedrich read that last paragraph four times in the anteroom with the poster of the rye field on the wall, and it was not the identity of the applicant that struck him first, though that came in the second breath, with the force of a blow in the chest: his own sister-in-law, Konrad's widow, Ilse, at the family's table at Falkenhorst at Christmas, asking him across the soup whether he had thought any more about the estate, and whether he and Erika might ever consider a child from the Lebensborn, and whether the East was really as bad as people said.

No: what struck him first was the date.

The twenty-first of June, 1942. A petition registered a year ago in Posen, in the fourth week of June 1942, by a widow of the family von Brandt, on a form, in the ordinary course, at the routine request of an office that was collecting names of childless women for the allocation of orphans from the eastern territories — a thing she could not have known anything about; a thing she had done, no doubt, the way she did everything, quietly, decently, with a woollen dress, a kind word for the maid, and a completed form.

A petition registered twenty-one June 1942. And the child's name had gone into the racial file in the last week of May 1943 — a distance of eleven months — and the petition's file number was 2188, and it lay in the folder with a priority by date, and the priority was at the top of the list, and the woman in the green suit who had put the child's photograph on her table had been waiting a year for the list to produce a girl, and the list had produced one, and the girl was her brother-in-law's daughter.

Friedrich closed the folder and sat with his hands on it, and heard the clerk's typewriter in the adjoining office, and looked at the poster of the rye field, and thought, with the last clear thought he had that day: *this is how it happens. Not with a knock on the door, not with a policeman, not with anybody intending anything. It happens with a form, in a year, and a date, and a stamp, and nobody in this whole apparatus is doing anything except his job.*

He gave the folder back to the clerk and walked down the four flights of stairs into the courtyard, and stood in the afternoon light for a moment, and then took out his notebook and wrote, because his hand was steadier than his mind: *Go to Posen (Karlstrasse 9) first opportunity. Do not write. Cannot write.* And under it, crossing out the first letters, he wrote: *Nothing can be done through the family. The family is the instrument.*

. . .

They drove east in the Opel at eight in the morning, over the Kierbedź bridge, along the streets of Praga to Ząbkowska, across the Pelcowizna road, and turned in at the cordon gate on Bonifraterska Street at half past nine.

The gate was two barriers of planks and wire and a sign in two languages; and the guard was a Landesschütze of the 386th, a man of about fifty-five with a broom of a mustache, who looked at Friedrich's pass, and then at Friedrich, and then at the pass again, and said, in the voice of a school caretaker, "Do you want to go *in*, Herr Major?"

"I do."

"Then I will tell you the thing everybody tells everybody, and you can do as you like with it." The old man leaned on the barrier. "Breathe through your mouth for the first hundred metres, and do not, whatever happens, do not go into the courtyards. The courtyards are where the cellars

are, and the cellars are where they flood, and there is a gas in the air down there from the burning that collects in the low places at night, and in the mornings you can see the flies. If the flies rise, get out. Also there is the stink and the stink is not the danger, the stink is only the stink." He raised the barrier. "Three o'clock is the relief. Do not be here at four; we shoot at movement in the ruins at four."

They went in.

Friedrich had been a soldier for eleven years and had been in three countries and had seen a village burned by a punitive expedition in Poland in 1939 and a church full of people burned in white Russia in 1941, from three hundred metres, with the field glasses passing from hand to hand along the line, and he had believed, until he walked into the dead ghetto on the fourteenth of July 1943, that he knew what destruction looked like.

It does not look like destruction. That was the first thing, and he understood it in the hundred metres of Bonifraterska Street, and the rest of the day only confirmed it: the dead ghetto did not look like destruction, it looked like a *plan*. The Germans had knocked the buildings down with a method — with burning, with explosive, with the labour detachments, from a map, street by street — and the result was not chaos. The result was a city read at a level of the horizon: at the level, Friedrich thought, of a city seen from an aeroplane, except that you were walking in it. The streets were still streets. The junctions were still junctions. You could stand at the corner of Muranowska and Zamenhofa and see, on the ground, the four corners of an intersection; you could read the plan of the district in the stump-fields of brick; and the scale of it, the vastness of the emptiness contained between standing street lines, was worse than the collapse would have been, because the emptiness had a ruler to it, and the ruler said: *this was*

done by people who took their time.

They walked north up Zamenhofa. There was brick dust on everything, fine and grey and slightly warm, and it got into the nose and the throat and the shoes; and there were places where the ground was hot; and there were places where the ground gave, and Kellner, who had grown up in Berlin and had been at the front in France, walked where Friedrich walked and said nothing at all.

At the corner of Miła, near where the bunker had been under the house at number eighteen — Friedrich knew that street name from the reports, and from the newspapers, and from conversations in the mess at which the men who had been in the operation said the things they said — the salvage detachment was at work: a hundred and forty men in two groups, guarded by Ukrainian auxiliaries, pulling down a chimney stack with a system of wires and winches, carting the bricks into neat iron frames and stacking the frames, sorting the iron and the tin and the lead into separate heaps, dredging the cellars with a long pole fixed across a cart; and it was all so orderly that it might have been a municipal improvement scheme, and at the corner there was a small tin hut with a telephone, and a sign on the wall of the hut that said, in German: *Sammelstelle — sorting depot — 8b. Buchhaltung — accounting — second door.* And among the ruined walls stood a wooden notice board painted black with white letters, put up by the German administration for the benefit of polite visitors, and on it were the words:

Der jüdische Wohnbezirk ist nicht mehr vorhanden. Dieser Bereich wird von der Stadt Warschau zur Neuanlage von Wohnflächen für deutsche Siedler überplant.

The Jewish residential district no longer exists. The area is being re-planned by the city of Warsaw for residential development for German settlers.

Friedrich stood in front of that board for a long moment, and Kellner waited behind him with his cap in his hands, and the work detachment went on pulling down a chimney three hundred metres away, and the man who had put up that board had used a spirit level; the letters were straight.

They went on. On Smocza they passed, under a piece of orphaned standing wall, a chalk mark in a child's hand — the street game of hopscotch, drawn a hundred years before — and Friedrich looked at it because the chalk was so bright against the burnt brick, and then he saw that it was not old at all: it had been drawn within the last few days, by a child, on a patch of clean paving that the wind had swept. Which meant that a child had been standing there within the week. Which meant there were people in the ruins still, in the heat and the flies and the dust, and the man in the tin hut at the corner was supposed to be looking for them with his dredging pole, and either he was not looking or there were more of them than the whole apparatus could count.

He did not write that in his notebook. He wrote: *Street line intact at Smocza/Żelazna; no quartering; water table high in the cellars; no rebuilding before 1945.*

At noon, in the shade of a railway arch on Stawki, they ate the sandwiches Kellner had brought; and across the main road, beyond the wire of the cordon, in the strip of waste ground that had been the big pre-war goods station, they could see the Umschlagplatz — the loading place — a platform and a rail siding and a great loop of track, entirely empty, entirely ordinary, with grass already up between the sleepers, and at the far end of the platform, bolted to two posts, a long inclined plank, at the exact angle of a cart ramp. Friedrich looked at the ramp for a long time, because a ramp is a thing a man cannot look away from once he has understood it: a freight wagon's floor stands a metre above

the platform, and a plank, and children of nine and old women of eighty walked up it, and it was, in the German language, *die Rampe*, and everything had been arranged, with German thoroughness, so that a person could be shifted from a cattle truck to a labour camp to a shed to a gate to a wall without any German ever having to raise his voice.

“By the ramp,” Kellner said, “that’s where the boy Peltz got his wound. The Leutnant. Eleven days before he died. He was standing there on the platform, looking at the wagons after the last one left, and somebody up in the goods shed, in the dark, put a bullet through his neck. He was a nice lad, Herr Major. He kept a tally in a book and he never once raised his hand to anyone. The sniper shot him because he was wearing grey, and because the man in the goods shed wanted to shoot somebody wearing grey before he was caught.” Kellner packed up the paper from the sandwiches into his pocket, because he never left litter in a place where litter was noticed. “They caught the man. Jewish, from a bunker. They shot him in the ruins at four o’clock on the same day, and it was Leutnant Peltz’s own company that did it, and the sergeant-major cried while he gave the order, and that is the whole story of the Polish war.”

“Get the car,” Friedrich said.

They were on the way back, following the sketch map towards the cordon gate on Bonifraterska, when he saw the wall.

It was the wall of the Gęsiówka: the old military prison on Gęsia Street, which had been inside the ghetto, and which had stood at the edge of it, and which the SS had taken over in 1943 as a labour camp for Jewish prisoners from the eastern districts, who were still being brought there in hundreds in the summer of 1943 — everybody in

Warsaw knew that by then, in the way that a city knows a thing — and the walls of the Gęsiówka were three metres high with the wire above and the gate with its ironwork, and beside the corner of the wall, in the yard of a house that had been knocked down for salvage, there stood the house's last surviving wall, alone, its three neighbours gone, with the plaster still on the inside and the ghost of a staircase going up it into the open air; and in the shadow of that orphan wall, on the ground, there was a man.

Friedrich saw him at thirty metres through the dust: an old man, curled on his side in the shade, with his coat over his head, quite still. He might have been asleep, or ill, or dead; and the whole apparatus said that a person in the ruins was a fugitive, and a fugitive was a matter for the Sicherheitspolizei, and an officer of the Wehrmacht who saw a fugitive and did not report him was a man who had chosen a side.

Kellner had seen him too. Kellner's hands on the wheel were quite steady, and he drove at the same slow speed, and he said, in the voice of a man passing a church: "Herr Major, the gate's four hundred metres."

Friedrich looked at the old man in the shade with his coat over his head.

"Stop the car," he said.

He got out. Kellner stayed at the wheel with the engine running, and Friedrich walked back fifty metres along the street in the hot grey dust, and the whole time he walked he was thinking, with the cold clarity of a man walking into a fire, that this was the single stupidest thing he had ever done in his life: that there was a Ukrainian guard post two hundred metres away, that he had no food on him, that he had no water, that he could not carry the man anywhere, that if the man was a Jew and was seen with him, then the file would have a Wehrmacht Major in it, and the file with a

Wehrmacht Major in it would go to Szucha, and a Major from a Prussian family in a Szucha file was a scandal that would destroy his name and his father's name and his sister's marriage and put him on the Russian front or against a wall; and he knew that he had to do it anyway, and that he had known it in the first three seconds, and that the last fifty metres of walking had been nothing but the price of pretending otherwise.

The man was alive. He was, Friedrich saw as he came up, not old: perhaps sixty, perhaps fifty-five worn to sixty, with a grey beard and a shirt that had been white in 1939, and the coat over his head was not on his head for sleep but against the sun and the flies, and when Friedrich's shadow fell on him he said, in Polish, without moving, in a voice that was dry and calm: "I am not here. There is nobody here. Go away, and God bless you, and do not come back."

Friedrich stood over him in the ruin of the courtyard of a house on Gęsia Street in July 1943 and did not know a single word of Polish that was of any use to him in that moment. What he had was a piece of sandwich and half a bottle of water and, in his tunic pocket, a bar of German army chocolate; and he put all three down on the ground, the chocolate on top, at the man's head, and said, in German, in the voice of a man reading a sentence from the files, because whatever else he was, he was a man who had learned that in this country a kindness spoken loudly gets two people killed: "There is a manhole in the courtyard of the corner house on Miła. It is open; the water below is low; it runs south to the Leszno sewer. Tell them in the bunkers that the surveying party at Narutowicza comes at six, and the guard posts are relieved at three. Do you understand German?"

There was a long silence. Then the coat moved, and a face came out of the shadows: narrow, grey-bearded, with

the dirt of twenty months in a cellar in it, and two eyes that were still entirely clear, and entirely unafraid, and which looked at Friedrich for the length of perhaps four breaths, and then the man said, in German with a Galician accent:

"I understand German. I understand you too. You are not a good man and you are not a German; a German would have reported me. Go away now." And then, quietly, as Friedrich turned: "*Herr Offizier.* The chocolate. You have put it down with the paper on. Without the paper it will melt into my beard, and there is nothing worse than chocolate in a beard."

And Friedrich walked away without turning round, and did not hear the man's sentence, in dry Polish, into the dust after him: that they had buried the last of the fighters under the wall eight days before, and that God, in His infinite humour, had sent a Prussian.

Half a kilometre up Gęsia Street, in the courtyard of the Gęsiówka, behind the wire, a work party of the camp's prisoners was being counted for the evening roll call: three hundred and eleven men in striped jackets, with their shirts off in the heat, standing in five rows with their hands at their sides; and behind them the camp's Jews, who had dug and carried and sorted and been killed in the ghetto clearance since May, and in front of them an SS Unterscharführer on a box with a list and a stick; and Friedrich, walking to the car with his cap in his hand, did not look at them, because it was the middle of the afternoon, and the guard's duty was to look outwards, and an officer of the Wehrmacht standing and looking into a camp of Jewish labourers in July 1943 was exactly the kind of small ordinary thing that brought men to Szucha; and he got into the car and said "Bonifraterska," and Kellner drove, and neither of them said anything at all for four kilometres, until they were back on Bonifraterska Street

with the gate in sight, and then Kellner said, without looking at him, in a voice of complete ordinariness:

“Herr Major. In the box behind the seat there is the bottle of schnapps that the quartermaster’s office gave me for the men at Christmas. I mention it because I do not drink and because you have to go back into an office, and because this afternoon in this car is the only place in Warsaw where a man can be alone, and if you would rather I stopped the car here and went for a walk, I will go for a walk.”

“Drive on,” Friedrich said.

They came back over the bridge at four o’clock with the sun on the river behind them and the whole of the left bank in front of them, spires and chimneys and the one great bald place in the middle of it, and the city looked, from the river, exactly as it had looked a hundred years before: a city of roofs, with a line of smoke over the far edge and the crosses of the churches up over the town like the masts of ships.

Friedrich sat with the sketch map on his knee, and looked at Warsaw, and did not think about the old man, and did not think about the ramp, and did not think about the board with the straight letters and the street plan drawn for German settlers; and found after ten minutes that he was thinking, without mercy, and with the whole force of a mind that had been trained to solve problems and forbidden to feel them, about a small ledger of cases in a steel cabinet in a room on Nowy Świat where a girl of nine had a card whose renewal came round every month.

Klara Seidler was waiting in the corridor with three telephone messages on a slip in her careful, upright, clerical hand; and she gave him the slip without saying anything, and stood with her hands folded while he read it, which she had never done before.

1. Obersturmführer Dörffel's office telephoned 11.40, asking whether the Major has been across the river. Answered: no reply.

2. Oberzahlmeister Wollweber requests the quarterly statement of the reserve renewals, for the fund.

3. Skaryszewska camp office telephoned 15.00. The camp commandant requests the Major's instructions: the children of detail three have been catalogued as Sortierung (Rüstung)*, and the case of the minor Wojtera, Maria Anna, has been placed by the Sicherheitspolizei under the custody of the camp pending a decision of the Reichssicherheitshauptamt; the child is therefore transferred from the reserve group to the custody of the camp at the order of the Obersturmführer, and the mother has been informed by post today. The commandant asks whether the Major wishes to lodge an objection.*

Friedrich read it twice, standing in the corridor in his dusty boots, and then he looked at Klara Seidler.

"When was the child moved?"

"This afternoon, Herr Major. The order came by telephone to the camp at two o'clock and the child was moved at three. Her mother is on the afternoon shift at the laundry until six. The letter is waiting for her at the camp gate for when she comes to visit on Thursday." Klara's hands stayed folded. "They have put her in the prison block, Herr Major. In the room with the shutters, over the gate. The room they keep for the ones who are going to be examined by Szucha."

PART TWO · THE SHORTENING ROPE

The Shortening Rope

CHAPTER NINE

The Notices

Warsaw — Saturday, 16 October 1943

The first notice went up on the walls at seven in the morning, and by nine every wall in the centre of the city had one, and by ten there was a man in a long coat reading one of them aloud outside the church on Marszałkowska, because half the city could not read the German and the other half could not bear to read the Polish.

They were printed at the top with the eagle, and at the bottom with the signature of the commander of the Security Police in the Warsaw district, and they said that the persons named below had been sentenced to death by a summary court for acts of sabotage and armed resistance, and had been executed on the sixteenth of October 1943 by hanging, in the streets named; and the names were printed in two columns with their ages, and there were fifteen of them, and at the bottom there was a paragraph that said that in future, similarly, every act of resistance would be met with the same severity, and that the population would do well to remember that the mercy of the German Reich was not without limits, and that the Reich reserved the right to take reprisals against families.

Helena Wojtera stood in the crowd on Marszałkowska at ten past ten in the morning, in her grey coat with the good collar, with her violin under her arm in its case, on her way to a lesson, and read the two columns twice, and found, in the second column, sixth name down, the name she had come to dread finding there since the first week of

September:

Henryk Zaremba, 17, of Warsaw, student.

They had called him Kuba. He had been her first partner in the whole business of the war: a boy of seventeen with a bad haircut and a bicycle, who had taught her, in three afternoons in a courtyard on Wilcza Street, how to carry a package, how to walk a route, how to feel the eyes of the man behind her and put him off with a window, how to take a tram three stops from the end of the line to see whether the line was being watched, and how, at the moment of danger, to drop the parcel into the nearest doorway and turn into the nearest shop and be a music teacher asking the price of sheet music. He had taught her with terrible care, the way a boy teaches his mother to ride a bicycle: with jokes, and with his hands ready, and with a whistle at the corner of his mouth. He had been arrested on the twenty-eighth of September on the bridge, with leaflets in the lining of his coat; and he had been interrogated at Szucha for eleven days, and he had not given up the girl who had been his pupil, and nobody knows how it was, whether he had nothing to give or whether he had held on to what little he had, but he had been hanged in the street at dawn on the sixteenth, at the age of seventeen, with the leaflets still in his file; and on the same morning, at half past five, Irena Załuska, of the Women's Underground, had been hanged in the same way at the corner of Wolność Street, and she was nineteen; and the two of them hung on the same gallows in the middle of the city, and men in uniform took photographs for the newspaper, and the newspaper sold out by eleven.

Helena read the notice for the third time and then she walked on to her lesson, because it was ten past ten in the morning, and the lesson was at a flat in Mokotów, and part of the lesson — the folded envelope of the *Biuletyn*

Informacyjny, four pages, hidden between the sheet music of the second violin part of the Brahms sextet — was in her case under her arm, and the second part of the lesson was due at the flat of a woman on Wspólna Street at half past twelve, and if she stood under the notice crying on Marszałkowska Street, she would be picked up before the clock struck eleven and everything that Kuba had given up his fingernails for would have been given up for nothing.

So she walked, and by the time she reached the corner of Wilcza she had the face on again, the smooth, shut, ordinary Polish face, the one she had learned from Zofia, the one that a city of two million people had learned to wear — the face that says to a policeman: *nothing here, nothing at all, only a woman with a violin.*

She had been in it for six weeks.

It had begun with Tomek on the first of September, in the little room at Hoża 14, with the lamp down and the blackout paper up, and three sentences he had been walking around for a month before he could say them.

“There is a thing that is worse than the leaflets,” he had said, “and it is what we do with the people who carry them. Forty couriers in this city. Twenty-two of them are boys between sixteen and twenty, because boys run fast and boys are cheap. Eight of them are dead since July; two have gone over to the Ukrainian police; one is being watched and he doesn’t know it yet. I have one woman in the whole district who can carry a parcel through a German check and look like a woman taking her mother’s bread home, and she is fifty and she has cancer. Now I am going to ask you a question, and I want you to say no if the answer is no, because a courier who does not want to be a courier is a courier who gets other people killed.”

“And the question?”

“Would you carry things for us?”

She had sat there with her hands in her lap and looked at him for a long time: at his flat wide face and his slow way of sitting, and at the line of his jaw, which had thickened in the summer.

And she had thought about all the reasons to say no, and she had found out, in the way that a person finds out the shape of a thing by walking round it in the dark, that the reasons to say no had been removed one at a time, over the summer, by the Germans.

Because in June they had let her bring the child to the wall on Tuesdays and Saturdays, and then, on the fourteenth of July, they had put the child in the room over the gate, and for five weeks she had not been allowed to see her at all. And on the twentieth of August she had stood at the gate of the camp for four hours in the rain with a parcel of bread and an old woman's asthma medicine, because the office had told her at eight in the morning that the child was there, and at eleven they had said she was not there, and at five in the afternoon a Polish clerk had come out to the gate and told her, kindly, that the child had been taken to the hospital on Jagiellońska Street with a boil on her neck the size of a hen's egg and that she had better go home, and she had walked to Jagiellońska and stood across the street from the hospital wall for two hours, because there was a window on the second floor and a nurse who came to it twice, and the nurse had put her hand up — just her hand, palm out, one second — and Helena had gone home and slept; and on the twenty-eighth of August there had been a paper at the gate from the Referat, with a stamp on it, renewing the reserve status, and a line at the bottom, in Klara Seidler's hand, in Polish: *the child is better; the boil was opened on the 26th; she asks for pencils; she is being kept in the labour reserve.*

She had known then, with the certainty of a woman who has spent a summer being moved around a board by other people's hands, that the thing that had kept her daughter alive when the notices arrived in the yard at Skaryszewska with the words *Reichssicherheitshauptamt* at the top was the paper, and that the paper was the Major's, and that the Major's paper was now the only thread holding the child in the world of the living, and that the thread ran through a man she had not spoken to since the twenty-fourth of May.

So in September, when the notices came and the shootings came and the city began to eat itself, she had gone to Tomek and said yes; and Tomek had taught her the last things, in a courtyard on Wilcza Street, with great care, in the way a young man teaches a thing he does not want to teach.

And on the twenty-second of September, in a courtyard on Wilcza Street, at a quarter to nine in the evening, she met, for the first and last time, the boy who had taught her everything.

He was on the wall of the courtyard, up where the roof of the shed met the wall of the house; he had a bicycle clip still on his right trouser leg, and hair that would not lie down, and he looked, in the light of the courtyard lamp with the blackout hood on it, about fifteen.

"You're the violinist," he said. "I know. You don't have to tell me your name and I don't want it. I'm Kuba; that's not my name and you'll forget it. Three rules, and then we'll walk once and I'll watch you and then we're finished with each other forever. One: never carry anything that is worth more than a lesson. A parcel of leaflets is eighteen hours of a man's life; a parcel of letters is forty; a parcel of medicine is a family. Two: never take the same route two days running, and never be early, because a man who is early is a man who is waiting, and a man who is waiting is a man

who is looking. Three: if they stop you, be stupid. Not brave. Stupid. Cry. Be a music teacher who has lost her papers. Show them the violin. Nobody in the history of occupation has ever suspected a woman with a violin of anything except being a nuisance, and the ones who look at the violin case are looking at the wrong thing." He had come down off the wall in one movement, landed, dusted his hands, and grinned at her with the confidence of a boy of seventeen who has already decided that he is going to die and would rather not mention it. "Now walk behind me for two streets and tell me who is following us."

There was nobody following them. That was the lesson too.

At the end of September she had carried her first medicine: a packet of insulin and four ampoules of morphine, from a doctor's flat on Hoża to a cellar on Zielna, for the wife of a man who had been taken at Szucha, and she had done it in a box of piano strings, in her violin case, through a check at the corner of Marszałkowska where a Polish policeman looked at her card upside down for four seconds and a German gendarme looked at her legs for two, and had felt nothing at all except a strange, clear, cold happiness that was, she understood later, the thing that all of them felt, the boys and the girls and the men and the women who carried paper through the streets of occupied Europe: not courage, and not patriotism, but the physical happiness of being a person who was doing something instead of being a person to whom things were done.

In October, the sixteenth of October, she read Kuba's name on the wall on Marszałkowska Street, and walked to her lesson with the leaflets in her music case, eleven pages of Brahms between them, and taught a girl of eleven the second violin part of the sextet for fifty minutes, and went home and lay on her bed in the dark without eating, and did

not say anything to anybody.

And that night Tomek came, very late, long after the curfew, with his cap in his hand and a cut on his lip, and stood in the middle of the room and said, “Kuba,” and she said, “I know,” and the two of them stood there with the lamp not lit, and then Tomek said the thing he had come to say, and he said it fast, as a man says a thing he has decided on and is afraid will be talked out of him:

“The night before he was taken, he gave me the name of the German.”

“What German?”

“The Loaf,” Tomek said. “The one who sold us the list in March. He gave me the name, because he said the contact was going to have to be a woman, and a woman can’t go into a building without a name. The man’s name is von Brandt. He is a Major in the labour section of the Wehrmacht commandant’s office on Nowy Świat, and the department he works in deals with labour allocation for the workshops and the railways, and he is the man who put four hundred Poles on a train to the Reich in the first week of May and then took eleven of them back off it by telephone, in the middle of the night, on the third of May, and those eleven are alive because of it, and I know that because my own cousin is one of the eleven.”

Helena stood in the darkness of the little room with her hands at her sides.

“Say it again,” she said.

“Von Brandt.”

“There are two of them in that building?”

“No. There is one. There is a Major von Brandt in the Referat für Arbeitseinsatz, and there is no other von Brandt in the General Government except a widow in Posen and a Generalmajor in the old-age reserve in Brandenburg, and before you ask me how I know that, the answer is that I

have spent four weeks finding out, because a man who does a thing in March and a thing in June is not a fool, and a man who is not a fool must be looked at twice." Tomek was quiet for a moment. "I didn't know, Helka. I didn't know when I brought you in, and I didn't tell you when I found out, and I should have told you, and I didn't, and the reason I didn't is that I did not know which of the two facts was the important one: that your daughter's protector is a German Major, or that the man who has been selling us paper for seven months is the same man."

"What does the command want?"

"The command doesn't know," Tomek said. "I've kept it out of the reports. That's what I came here to tell you. Because the moment I put it in a report, it becomes a thing with a file, and a thing with a file in the underground moves, and the first movement will be that they will ask you to arrange a meeting, and the second will be that they will want to use him, and the third will be that they will want to know why he cares about your daughter, and that is a question I am never going to answer for them, and you are never going to answer for them, and so I have kept it out." He put his cap on. "There. Now that's out of me. Say something."

Helena said, after a while: "He has kept her alive."

"He has kept her alive."

"He has kept her alive four months, and he has not asked me for anything, and there will be a morning when he asks, and it will be a thing that makes me hate him, and I will do it anyway, because that is the trade." She heard her own voice in the dark and it was flat and without any weight at all. "And you're right. You should have told me. And you were right not to. Now go home, Tomek, because it's past one, and if you're stopped on the way I will never speak to you again in this world or the next."

At the end of October, on a Friday, the thing that the book has been circling came to her through a door on Świętokrzyska Street, in a flat with an upright piano and a cactus in the window, where a woman with grey hair and a black dress gave her tea and looked at the folded envelope and said, “Thank you, Pani Wojtera. There is one thing more, if you will. Do you know the smell of gangrene?”

“I know it. I was at the front in 1939 and I have been a hospital washer since May.”

“Better than that. There is a boy in the back room who is nineteen years old and was born in Gelsenkirchen, and he is a soldier of the Wehrmacht, and on Tuesday night he walked out of the barracks at the Flak school at Wola with a rifle and sixty rounds and a pair of boots, and he came to us on his own legs, which takes a boy with a conscience and no sense, and on the way he was shot twice by his own side: once through the left forearm, which is not the problem, and once in the side, above the hip, which is. He has been here since two o’clock in the morning. The doctor was here at six and again at noon. He says the same thing both times, which is that the boy has twelve hours, maybe twenty-four, and that the wound is the kind that a German hospital cleans and a Polish cellar kills.”

“And what am I for?”

“Because at half past six tonight there is a cordon on the block, the whole block, two streets, and the rickshaws are already stopped at the corner, and we have the boy and the rifle and the sixty rounds and a German uniform under the floor, and if they search this flat they will shoot the three of us, and the boy will be hanged in the yard, and one of us —” the woman stopped, and put down her cup without a sound, and said, “One of us will have to stay with him, and the other two have to walk out through the cordon with nothing at all, and there is a thing you can carry through a cordon

tonight that nobody can take off you."

"What is that?"

"Blood," said the woman with grey hair. "You put the coat on him, and you lift his shoulder, and you hold him while the doctor works, and then you walk out of this building at half past six without washing. A woman with wet blood on her coat at a cordon in this city is four hundred zlotys of fine and a night in the station and, if the gendarme is honest, a beating; a parcel in her lining is a wall. That's not the reason I'm asking. I'm asking because you are the one with the papers and the face, and because the doctor needs four hands tonight and I have only got two, and because you said yes to a box of piano strings in September, and this is the same thing, only I'm not going to lie to you about which."

The cordon came at half past six, exactly as she had said: two green lorries at each end of the street, the men out and the lamps in the archways, and the whole street shut with the rickshaws standing in a line. In the back room with the boards up and the lamp turned to the wall, the doctor — Antoni Kwiatkowski, who had been a surgeon at the Praga hospital in another life, and who had hands like a pianist and the eyes of a man who has not slept since 1939 — operated on a boy of nineteen for two hours without anaesthetic except a rag soaked in schnapps between his teeth; and the boy had bitten the rag in two and had then, in the passing-out that comes before the body gives up, called for his mother, and then, in German, in a sobbing whisper, one sentence over and over, which Helena translated for the doctor with her hands in the wound cloths and her arms to the elbow in the boy's blood: *Ich hab nicht geschossen. Ich hab nicht geschossen. Ich hab sie gesehen und ich hab nicht geschossen.* — I did not shoot. I saw them, and I did not shoot.

At nine o’clock, when the search had come up the stairwell to the second floor and gone past the door of the flat with the piano (the woman with grey hair had put the sheet music on the piano and played, out of tune, at the third landing, an hour of Chopin with the pedal down, because the acoustics of a stairwell had been studied by the underground the way roads are studied by an army), the boy’s side was closed, and his breathing had changed; and at half past nine they lifted him, the doctor and Helena, and carried him down the back stairs to the coal cellar, and laid him on a mattress in a recess behind the boiler which would, the woman explained, be invisible to a search unless they went into the recess, and if they went into the recess it was over for all of them; and it took the two of them fourteen minutes to carry him down one flight and across a yard, and by the end of it Helena’s coat, which had been clean that morning, was black to the elbows, and there were two round marks on the front, exactly where a person’s hands go when they are holding a shoulder, and a smear across the sleeve where the boy’s head had fallen against her.

At ten o’clock she walked out of the courtyard, and the sentry at the archway of the Świętokrzyska cordon, a gendarme of about forty with the face of a man who wanted his dinner, put his torch on her and said, in Polish, “Stop. Papers.”

She stopped, and gave him the labour card and the residence card and the pass to the Wehrmacht hospital laundry, and stood with her hands at her sides in the light of the torch, and the torch went down her and stopped at the front of her coat, at the two round marks and the smear, and stayed there.

“What is this?”

“From the laundry,” Helena said. “It is the German linen. We are supposed to sort the linen of the surgical ward before the wash, and I am on the surgical linen this week, and if the gendarme wishes he may telephone Frau Piltz at the laundry on Wiejska Street and she will be delighted to tell him what her people look like at the end of a Friday.”

The gendarme looked at the blood, and at her, and at the card, on which the stamp of the Wehrmacht hospital laundry was very large and very clean; and then he did what every official in Warsaw did when the possibility of a telephone call to another German official opened in front of him, which was to hand back the papers and step out of the way, and Helena walked out of the cordon on Świętokrzyska Street into the dark October city with a German soldier’s blood drying on her coat in two round handprints and a smear.

She walked home through the tramless dark. And then, because it was after curfew and the streets were hers, she did what no careful person does: she did not go home at once; she sat for twenty minutes on the steps of the church on Świętokrzyska Street with her arms round her knees, and smelled the blood in the cold, and thought about a boy of nineteen from Gelsenkirchen calling for his mother in a coal cellar, and about a boy of seventeen from Warsaw hanging at dawn in Marszałkowska Street, and about what a person was supposed to feel in the autumn of 1943, and discovered, with a kind of horror at herself, that she felt nothing at all except the determination to be there again on Monday.

She did not wash the coat for a week.

Not from sentiment: from a reason that she wrote in the notebook she had begun to keep, in a hand so small and so flat that it could not be read across a room, in the ledger of what a woman in Warsaw could still have: *I have the coat*

cleaned on Sunday. If it is cleaned, on Monday I could not have walked through the cordon and the boy would be in the yard and the woman with grey hair would be at Szucha. Therefore the coat is not a coat; the coat is a tool; and a tool must be kept dirty, and I must learn not to hate the sight of it.

And on Sunday, when she did wash the coat, in the copper in the courtyard with the soap she had been saving, she found that the blood had gone through the lining on the left breast, where her hand always went, and that the envelope sewn into the lining had a thin brown line across its lower corner, where the blood had come through the cloth, exactly across the lower right corner of the photograph, so that the two young people in it stood in an autumn garden with a red-brown stain spreading up from the edge of the frame towards their feet.

She sat with it in her hands for a long time in the empty courtyard, and then she stitched it up again with the same white thread, and sewed the seam shut along the old line, so that from the outside the coat looked exactly as it had looked before, which is the whole art of Warsaw in the fifth year of the war: not to hide the blood, which is impossible, but to sew the seam along the same line, so that the coat can be worn again on Monday.

CHAPTER TEN

The House of Wolves

Falkenhorst, near Küstrin — Wednesday, 22 December 1943

The estate lay on the low ground by the Oder, where the river branched and the water stood in the meadows all winter and the frost came up out of the ground in long white feathers, and the house was a low, long, solid Prussian house of 1812 with a pillared porch and a hundred and ninety years of additions at the back, and it had been in the family for four generations, and it was, Ilse von Brandt thought, standing at her window on the morning of the twenty-second with a shawl round her shoulders, exactly as beautiful as it had been when she had first come there as a bride in the spring of 1935, and exactly as cold.

In the yard the Polish labourers were bringing in the last of the firewood for the holiday: the Scharwerk men from the village, in their coats and their wooden shoes, with the sledges, and the foreman, Kaczmarek, who had been the estate's foreman since 1911 and who had a son in the Polish army in England and a daughter who cleaned in the house and was, everybody assumed, the reason the silver had not been stolen; and there was snow on the roofs and smoke on the air and, from the kitchen wing, the smell of the goose that had been hanging since Sunday and the good hot smell of the bread.

Ilse stood at the window for a long time.

She was thirty-eight years old. She had been born Ilse von Woyrsch, of a family with more name than acres, in Stettin, in a house with a good piano and a set of Heine that

her father kept in the back of the bookcase; she had married Konrad von Brandt, the eldest, the one with the laugh, in 1935, and they had had the ground floor at Falkenhorst and a flat in Berlin and no children, and in the autumn of 1939 Konrad had gone to the war in Poland with his regiment and had come home on leave at Christmas and had been unable to sleep; and in June 1941 his regiment had gone east, and in July there had been a letter in his handwriting from a place with no name that Ilse had looked up in an atlas and not found; and on the fourteenth of September 1941, at a supper party in Posen, an officer of the Ordnungspolizei who had had too much wine had said, in front of nine people, "The Kamerad of the cavalry — Konrad von Brandt — my condolences, Frau Brandt," before anybody had told her; and she had gone home, and telephoned, and on the twentieth of September the telegram had come, and it had said KILLED IN ACTION IN THE EAST, and there had never been a grave.

That was two years and three months ago. She had learned to live with a hole in the middle of her life, the way you learn to live in a house with a tree through the roof: you moved round it, you stopped seeing it, and then three or four times a year something fell out of it. She had learned the German widow's ritual: the black, the year of the black, the deliberate cheerfulness of the fourth year, the photographs, the letters, the field post, and the silence; and she had learned, in those two years, the thing she had never told a living soul, which was that grief is not the worst of it. The worst of it was the emptiness of the days, which had no shape left at all: nothing to be got up for, nothing to be counted on, no child at the table, no reason to be careful with the household money, no reason to keep up with anybody, no reason, she thought sometimes, to eat.

She had wanted a child since 1936, and had spent four years in the indifferent hands of a professor in Berlin who had explained the mechanics of her body to her with a brass instrument, and had spent 1940 and 1941 at Bad Nauheim taking the waters and the injections, and had taken, in the end, the advice of the wife of a party official, which was that a woman of her family and background, whose husband had fallen for the Reich, need not necessarily adopt a child from an institution of the sort one associates with the cities. There were children, the official's wife said, of good blood, whose parents had been lost in the East; there were lists.

Ilse had put her name on a list in September 1941. She had done it in the way she did everything: quietly, with a form, and a letter of support from her father-in-law, and an attestation of her own ancestry as far back as 1750, which had taken a lawyer in Stettin six weeks. And then she had waited, and mended the linen, and organized the Christmas parcels for the men from the estate who were in the army, and read the letters that came and the lists of the dead in the newspaper, and been, on the surface, a decent, careful, useful woman in a house full of people, with nothing to hold on to at all.

And then, in the last week of May 1943, a clerk at the Rasse- und Siedlungsamt in Posen had written to her to say that a case had become available, in the Warsaw district, which might in his view correspond to the particulars of her application; that the case was a female child of nine years of age, of suspected German descent on the paternal side, and that her name was not to be given to the applicant, as the finding was not complete; and that a photograph could be seen, under the rules, on one of the days when the office received applicants, in Posen, on the second floor.

Ilse had gone to Posen on the eighth of June and had stood in a corridor with three other women, all older than herself, all of them in black, and had been given, for eleven minutes, in a room where a typist was in the corner and a lamp was on a table, one photograph of a girl of nine in a striped shirt with a shaven head and grey eyes.

She had gone home on the train with her hands folded in her lap, and had not been able to eat in the dining car, and had looked out at the Warthegau going by — the great confiscated farms, the neat German settlements with the names changed on the signposts, the Polish labourers coming back from the fields in the last light — and she had understood, in that hour, something about herself that she had not known before, which was that she was going to want that child more than she had ever wanted anything, and that a woman in her position who wants something that much should be watched, because a woman in her position had the paper and the office and the Reich behind her, and paper works.

She had, that autumn, in fact, done one more thing. She had gone to Warsaw.

It had taken her three days there in October, and she had not told the family, and she had told Erika that she was visiting a cousin in Dresden; and she had stayed in the Hotel Bristol, where the Germans stayed, and eaten in the dining room among officers, and heard the piano play; and she had gone to Aleja Szucha 25A with a letter from the office in Posen, and had sat in a corridor with the others, and had been given, for a quarter of an hour, in a small hot room, by a doctor with soft white hands and a theory of ears, the whole file of Maria Anna Wojtera, including, in a folder, the letter which she was permitted to read but not to copy, and which made her sit in a taxi afterwards on Aleja Szucha with her gloves in her hands and her heart beating

in her throat, because the letter was in the file and the letter was from the child's own father's family — her own family, the von Brandts, in the person of her father-in-law, the Generalmajor, and it was dated 1933, and it was not the sort of letter that was ever supposed to have become a file, and the hand that had signed the receipt for it, at Szucha in 1943, was the hand of the same doctor who had written a note about the child's ear; and the letter was in the folder because the Reich, in the fifth year of the war, was now collecting everything.

So when the family came to Falkenhorst for Christmas 1943, Ilse knew a great deal more than any of them; and she carried the photograph of Maria Anna Wojtera in the back of her writing case, in a paper envelope, between the blotter and the stamps.

. . .

Posen, the week before Christmas

The house on the Karlstrasse had been built in 1905 for a Polish merchant called Wojciechowski, who had made his money in timber on the Warta, and it had a good staircase and a conservatory and a garden with a lime walk, and Ilse von Brandt had lived in it since the autumn of 1941, when the office had allotted it to her as the widow of an officer of the Reich: four rooms and the garden, with the merchant's furniture still in it because the merchant had gone, with his wife and his two daughters, to the General Government in a sealed railway car in November 1939, and because furniture is heavy and the war was long and nobody had come for it.

The merchant's piano was still in the drawing room. It was a good one: a Bechstein, out of tune since 1939, with the candle brackets and the yellowed keys, and Ilse played it twice a week, badly, in the evenings, because playing an

instrument that belonged to somebody else's disappearing life was, she had found, the only thing in the house that made her feel anything; and once, in the second winter, she had opened the little lid under the keyboard and found, on the felt, a child's exercise book with the name *Jadwiga Wojciechowska, klasa III* in it, and the sums done in pencil in a careful hand; and she had sat on the piano stool with the book in her lap for a quarter of an hour, and then she had put it back on the felt under the keys, in the same place, and had gone on playing the same waltz.

There were three servants in the house, because a widow of a fallen officer with an application before the Rasse- und Siedlungsamt was entitled to three: an old German woman from Stettin who did the linen and the accounts, and two Polish girls from the resettled villages, Genia and Wanda, who did everything else, and whose family lived in the town and were permitted to be there because their father was a skilled man and the office had left the skilled trades of Posen alone in 1940 and had come back for them in 1943. Genia was nineteen. She had been at school with the merchant's younger daughter, and she did not know where her friend was, and she had never once in four years asked Ilse a question about any of it, and she made the beds and put the flowers in the drawing room and sang under her breath in the kitchen in Polish, and she ironed Ilse's black dresses with a precision that was, Ilse understood perfectly, a form of judgment.

On the Monday before Christmas, Ilse came home at four from the office, and Genia met her in the hall with her hands folded and said, in German, the way she always spoke in the hall, "Frau Brandt, the post has come. There is a parcel from Falkenhorst and there is a letter from the Amt, and I have put the letter on the desk in the study."

It was a thin official envelope from the Rasse- und Siedlungsamt in the Warthegau, reference 2188/43, and it said, in three sentences, that her application regarding a female child of the Warsaw district was under active processing; that in consequence of the entry of a caveat by an office in Warsaw of which the undersigned did not at present know the detail, the case would not be determined before February 1944; and that the applicant should hold herself in readiness to receive the child for a probationary period of six months at fourteen days' notice.

Ilse read it standing at the desk with her coat still on.

Fourteen days' notice. In the new year, perhaps in February, a car would come from the station, and a woman from the League of German Girls would bring a child up the path, and the child would be ten years old, and she would have dark hair and grey eyes and hands that played on the table; and the child would come into the drawing room and see the Bechstein, and be told that she was Frau Brandt's niece from a family of the Reich, and that her parents had died in a raid; and she would be given the bedroom at the end of the corridor, which had been papered in blue in 1905 for the merchant's younger daughter and repapered in the small once more in November, because Ilse had done it herself, with her own hands, in the week when the merchant's daughter's wallpaper had begun to look, suddenly and unpardonably, like the wallpaper of somebody else's life.

She sat down at the desk and put her hand over her mouth, and wept for a minute, quietly, the way she had learned to weep in the years since 1941, with the door shut and the curtains straight.

Then she took the letter upstairs and put it in the writing case with the photograph, and came down, and ate a supper of liver sausage and potato, and went into the

drawing room, and opened the piano, and played, in honour of a thing that had not yet happened, the same waltz, very badly, twice.

. . .

The house filled up on the twenty-third.

The Krämers came first, from Posen, in the big Mercedes with the SS pennant, which Hermann always took off at the gate of the estate, a courtesy to the Generalmajor's opinions about the party; and Margarete, who was Grete, who was Friedrich's sister and 34 and had the practical energy of a farmer's wife, came in with her arms full of parcels and the two children ahead of her stamping the snow off their boots in the hall; and Wolf, who was nine, immediately began to be a storm on the staircase, and Dorle, who was six, sat down in the middle of the hall floor to take her boots off and had to be carried; and the house, which had been quiet for months, filled up in ten minutes with the whole apparatus: the wet wool in the boot room, the smell of the fir tree being carried through the hall in the arms of the foreman, the argument about whose turn it was to wind the clock, the singing of the third verse of the carol by the cook in the kitchen.

Erika arrived at four in the afternoon with the mail car from Küstrin, a small brown suitcase and a bunch of hothouse carnations, and she was, as always, correct: in her black, with the brooch, with the suitcase packed in the way that only a woman who has been a soldier's wife for six years packs a suitcase; and she kissed Ilse on both cheeks and said the right things, and went upstairs, and did not come down for two hours, and when she came down the little redness round her eyes was gone, and she was ready for the evening; and Ilse, who had lived in the same house with Erika for the first two years, knew exactly where she

had been for those two hours: in the room at the end of the corridor, the nursery, which Erika kept in order, with the little bed made up and the toys on the shelf and the photograph of Konrad — the little one, Friedrich and Erika's boy, who had died at three in February 1941 of meningitis, in the week when his father was on the road between Lodz and Warsaw and came home too late — and the dust on the little horse because nobody but Erika was permitted to touch the horse.

That evening, when the house was asleep and the last of the kettles had been filled in the kitchen, Ilse went up the corridor to the end, because she did it every Christmas, and because it was the only thing she knew how to give the woman in the room beyond it.

Erika was sitting in the little chair by the little bed.

The room had a nightlight in a china shoe, because Erika kept it burning, and the bed was made up with the counterpane turned back, and the horse and the wooden animals and the ball were on the shelf in the order in which a three-year-old puts away his own toys, which is to say no order at all; and Erika had the photograph in her hands, and she was not looking at it, she was simply holding it, the way a person holds a stone in the sea.

"I cannot be at this dinner," Erika said, in the flat voice.

"You can. You have been at eleven dinner parties since 1941 and every one of them was worse than this one will be."

"That is not what I mean." Erika put the photograph down on the little bed, face down, which was the custom of the house, because in that room photographs were never allowed to look at anybody. "I mean I cannot be here at all, in this house, at this table, being a German wife whose husband is on duty. Every year they ask me why Friedrich does not take leave, and I have learned to say that the

Referat is short of officers, and every year your father-in-law looks at me as though he knows that I am lying and is grateful for it." She looked up. "Do you know why he does not come?"

"I think I do," Ilse said.

"Then you know more than I do, and I live with it." Erika's face did not change; she had the face of a woman of thirty-two who has been taught by three years of a German Christmas never to change her face in front of the family. "I am not a fool, Ilse. I am a wife with a room in her house that has a dead child in it, and I know perfectly well that my husband has been, since the spring, doing something that a man of his name should not be doing, and I have not asked him about it because I am afraid of the answer; and this week Grete has been looking at me across a piano the way a woman looks at a woman whose husband has a photograph in his writing case." She smoothed the counterpane, one small stroke. "So. When the war is over, one of three things will be true. Either Friedrich has done something honourable and it will cost us everything; or he has done something dishonourable and it will cost us everything; or he has done nothing at all and we shall have to go on living with the kind of man who could do neither. I do not know which of the three frightens me more, and I have not slept properly since the middle of June, and I would rather be at this table tomorrow with you than be anywhere else in the world, because you are the only person in this family who has ever looked at me as though I were a person and not a room."

Ilse sat on the floor with her back against the wall, with the nightlight between them, and said the truth, or half of the truth, which was all she had ever said to anyone: "I have applied for a child. There is a girl in Warsaw, and the papers are moving, and I think that in the spring there will

be a car from the station."

Erika looked at her for a long moment. The little horse on the shelf cast a horse's shadow on the wall, and the snow ticked at the window.

"A girl from Warsaw," Erika said. "Then you had better tell me her name, because I am the only one in this family who will still be able to say it out loud in twenty years, and somebody in this house ought to know the name."

Ilse told her. And Erika, who had not wept in front of another human being since October 1941, sat by the nightlight in her dead son's room and took hold of Ilse von Brandt's hand and held it while the name was said, and said afterwards, quite steadily, in the voice of a woman giving a diagnosis: "Then God help all of us, and God help the child, and God help my husband; because in this family we are all of us doing the same thing now, and it is called wanting something, and it never ends well in the letters of a Prussian."

. . .

The Generalmajor was seventy-three, and he was in his study with the door open, listening to the house fill with his family, and he came out to dinner in his old black tunic without the badges, because he had worn the badges off, and made the sign of the cross at his place for form's sake in a house where no one had gone to church since 1918, and sat at the head of his table with his four grandchildren's grandchildren's worth of food in front of him — the goose, the red cabbage, the potatoes — and said grace, which he did twice a year, and then said, in his dry voice, lifting his glass:

"To those who are not at this table."

And they drank; and there were five of them who were not at the table, and they all knew their names, and nobody

said them.

Friedrich was not at the table, and that was talked about, in the way that the family talked about Friedrich, which was with a mixture of formality and grievance: he had sent a telegram — *Duty forbids; the Referat must be manned through the holiday; God bless the house; Friedrich* — by the field post, fifteen words; and Grete said, "He is always on duty. He has been on duty since 1933," and the Generalmajor said nothing, and Erika looked at her plate, and Hermann Krämer said, "We are all on duty, Grete," and turned the subject, because Hermann was in the habit of turning subjects.

At the table, after the goose, the family talked as German families talked at Christmas 1943: the talk that the war in the East was a war of the world against Bolshevism, and that the Bolshevists were not men in the way that we are men, and that the Führer had had no choice after 1933, and that the bombed-out families in Hamburg were being well cared for, and that the English were flying at Christmas to kill our wives and children deliberately, and that the Americans were rich but would lose interest, and that the war would end in the spring, or in the autumn, or not in our lifetime; and mixed with all of it was the ordinary, tender machinery of a prosperous family at a festival: the request to pass the salt, the smallest child's cough, the card game after supper, the servants in the corridor with the plates, and the silver, and the candles burning down.

Hermann Krämer was forty-five years old, from a family of Hesse schoolmasters, with a doctorate in law and a face like a good-natured hawk and careful hands, and he was, in the Rasse- und Siedlungswesen in Posen, a man of real importance: it was Hermann who organized the ethnic screening of the annexed territories in the Warthegau, who

determined which Polish families were to be registered in lists one to four, which were allowed to remain, and which were to be resettled; it was Hermann who had signed, on the third of May 1942, the order that had moved the Kaczmareks' neighbors and their four children and their father's grave to the Lublin district; and it was Hermann who, in the sitting room at Falkenhorst on the twenty-third of December 1943, with the schnapps and the cigars, explained the whole business to his father-in-law, the Generalmajor, in the voice of a farmer explaining a harrow.

"It is a public health measure," he said. "That is what the Führer's judgment amounts to. We have a hundred thousand children in the annexed territories of mixed blood. They cannot stay Polish, because a child who is Polish in Germany is a sickness in the state; they cannot go to Poland, because most of Poland as an entity will not exist. So the office separates the good blood from the bad, and the good blood goes into German families, where it will grow up German and useful; and the rest goes where the rest goes. The proof that the system works is the work itself. A child of eleven from Łódź, screened and placed in 1941, wins the prize at the school in Posen this year for German composition." He turned his brandy glass. "I do not expect you to like the details, Father. You were in the old army; the old army preferred to look away. That was a luxury of an age when the state did not have to make judgments. Now it does, and somebody has to be the man with the signature."

"Somebody does indeed," said the Generalmajor, dryly, and looked into the fire.

And Ilse sat in the corner with her embroidery, because she always sat in the corner with her embroidery, and listened to all of it, and felt the envelope in her writing case, in the room above, as though it were a lamp burning

somewhere in the house.

It was Grete who did it. Not Hermann, and not the Generalmajor, and not Erika, but Grete, at the piano on the afternoon of the twenty-fourth, when the house was full of the smell of the fir tree and the shortbread and the two boys had been sent up to wash and Dorle was on the floor with the wooden horses and the room was, in that arbitrary way of houses at Christmas, happy.

Grete was playing; she was the one in the family who played, badly and cheerfully, and she had just finished singing the same carol three times, and into the warm room, over her shoulder, she said, in a voice pitched for nothing at all: “Ilse. Show Erika the girl.”

The room did not stop. That was the terrible thing: a Christmas room does not stop. The Generalmajor went on looking into the fire, and Hermann went on pouring, and Erika, in the corner, looked up from the piece of work in her hands with a polite expression.

“I don’t know what Grete means,” Ilse said.

“The photograph,” Grete said, and turned on the piano stool, and smiled, and it was a sister’s smile, and there was nothing in it but interest and a certain impatience with other people’s secretiveness. “The photograph in your writing case, which I have seen twice in your hand since October, and which you do not know you have looked at under a lamp the way a woman looks at a piece of jewelry. If the family is going to talk about the girl from Warsaw for four days, let us all look at her.”

Ilse sat quite still for three seconds with her embroidery in her lap, and then she got up and went out of the room and up the stairs, and came down with the envelope, and took out the photograph, and put it on the small table between the lamp and the bowl of nuts, and the family looked at it.

A girl of nine in a striped shirt with the sleeves rolled, standing against a grey wall, with her hair grown out into dark fuzz and her hands at her sides and her eyes straight at the camera, and a chin held up.

There was silence for a moment. And then Erika, who had not spoken for the whole day except to say the right things, leaned forward a little and looked at the photograph for the length of four or five heartbeats, and said, in a voice quite without colour, the sentence that turned the house of wolves over on its back:

“She has Friedrich’s eyes.”

The Generalmajor’s fire-irons stopped. Out of the corner of her eye Ilse saw Hermann Krämer look up from the decanter with the whole of his mild face turned to stone, and she saw the Generalmajor a.D. Ewald von Brandt, seventy-three years old, the man who had commanded a division in 1917 and a garrison in 1939 and who had buried a son and a grandson, go on looking at the fire, and his hands stay perfectly still on the arms of his chair, and his eyes never leave the flame, and know everything.

“Well,” Grete said, after a moment, in the cheerful voice of a woman who wants to put a room back on its feet. “Half the family has the same eyes. The Woyrsch eyes; my father-in-law always said it.” And she began to play again, and the carol went on, and Hermann poured the schnapps, and Dorle drove her wooden horses across the rug, and the room resumed, in the way that rooms resume, the appearance of a Christmas at home in Prussia in the fifth year of the war.

Nobody spoke about it again, in the house, for two days; but Ilse, lying in her bed above the hall with the snow ticking against the window, knew that a family, having seen a thing, never unsees it; and on the morning of the twenty-sixth, at the breakfast table, Hermann Krämer said,

in his gentle, reasonable, careful-man's voice, the following:

"Friedrich is in Warsaw. The file with the girl's photographs is in the district office in Posen and the Institute in Warsaw, and the girl is a case of doubtful racial ancestry, and the case is open. I have looked at the case myself. There is a signature of a Wehrmacht office on the child's reserve papers, and the signature is going to have to be explained by somebody, and if it is not explained by somebody in Berlin it will be explained by somebody at Szucha, and one way or another somebody in this family is going to be standing in a room explaining it." He buttered his bread. "I shall write to Posen and ask for a full report on the file. That is what an office does. And you, Ilse, will write to the Amt yourself, since it is your application, and say that your interest in the case of the child Maria Anna Wojtera of Warsaw is unchanged and immediate, and that you wish the case to be completed in the ordinary course before the end of the winter." He looked at her with his mild eyes. "Because an application that lies still is an application that someone else fills. You understand?"

"Yes," Ilse said. "I understand."

And on the twenty-seventh of December, in the small writing room off the hall at Falkenhorst, with the snow coming down over the Oder and the smell of the goose fat and the fir tree, Ilse von Brandt sat down at the desk and took out two sheets of good paper with the monogram at the top, and began her letter to the Rasse- und Siedlungsamt in Posen, and the letter was short, and the letter was correct, and the letter contained one sentence more than was required by the form.

She wrote, under her signature, in her neat, upright, widow's hand:

I have seen the child's photograph and I am satisfied as to her suitability so far as the racial finding is concerned. I

am told that the case is connected with an officer of the Wehrmacht stationed in Warsaw who is a member of my family by marriage. For the sake of the family's name and its standing in the Warthegau, and to prevent a scandal which would be of no use to anyone in Potsdam or in Berlin, I ask that the office determine the case speedily, and that the father's name, if it is to be entered at all, be entered without the mother's knowledge and with the child placed in the Reich before the mother can contest the finding.

She read it over twice. Then she sealed it, and rang for the maid to take it to the post, and went back into the hall, where a nine-year-old boy was being a horse and a six-year-old girl was the rider, and stood in the doorway with her hands folded, watching the children scream with laughter under the tree, and she thought — and the thought was quite calm, and quite clear, and it never left her afterwards, for the rest of her life — *Whatever is done now, I did it myself, in my own hand, and I was of sound mind, and I wanted it, and that is the only truth about me, and I shall have to carry it the way one carries a stone in the stomach, all the days of my life.*

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The Tram at Szucha

Warsaw — Thursday, 6 January 1944

They came at five in the morning, which was the hour of the occupation, and they came quietly, which was worse, because a loud entry is a raid and a quiet entry is a name.

Helena woke because the gate in the courtyard had not squeaked, and the gate always squeaked, and she lay in the dark for one second with her heart going like a bird in a box, and then she was up and at the window and looking down through the corner of the blackout paper, and there were two cars in the yard, and men in the yard, and one of them was holding a torch on Zofia Mrożek in her nightdress with the caretaker's keys still on their string round her neck.

She had four minutes, and she used them the way Kuba had taught her: the folded pages of the Biuletyn went from the violin case into the stove and were lit with one match and burned down to a black flake while she held the lid up with her foot; the pencil-written name of the man at the Flak school — one word, no surname — went the same way; the tin came out from under the floorboard and went under the mattress; the photograph stayed where it had been for eleven years, in the lining, over her heart.

Then she sat on the edge of the bed in her nightdress with her hands in her lap and waited.

The first man through the door was not German. He was Polish, in a good coat and a soft hat, thirty-five, with a face like a shopwalker, and behind him came two of the

Sicherheitspolizei in plain clothes and behind them, at the door, a gendarme with a rifle; and the Polish one went through the room the way a man goes through a shop he has been in before: the cupboard, the shelf, the violin case, the case emptied on the bed with the instrument left on the blanket where it fell, the mattress, the floorboards under the rug, and the fourth floorboard lifted up, and the joist, and the hole, and the empty hole.

"Where is it?"

"Where is what? The board is loose, the house is sixty years old, everything in this street is loose."

The Polish one put his hand into the hole and felt it, all round, carefully, with two fingers, like a man feeling a hole in a tooth; and then he stood up and wiped his fingers on his handkerchief and looked at her, and he had, she saw, a small gold filling in his canine tooth, and she thought: *if I live, I will remember that tooth.*

"You know what I am, Pani Wojtera," he said, in Polish, quietly. "I am not one of them. I am a Pole from this city and I have a wife and a mother and a boy of eleven. I do what I do because the alternative is a camp in Germany and my boy with nobody to feed him. I am going to tell you one thing for nothing, because I do not want your death on me: the order for you came from Szucha, and the paper behind the order has your name on it in the hand of a man who sells, and the man who sells is a small man with his chin in his collar and he lives on the third floor at the Rialto, and he has been paid seven hundred zlotys for you. That is all I know. Dress warm. Take the coat with the good lining."

She dressed warm. She took the coat with the good lining.

They did not put the handcuffs on until the courtyard, in front of the windows, because that was the correct way to do it: the neighbours at their windows with the blackout

paper pulled aside, and Pani Halina Rowińska of the third floor with her hand over her mouth, and Zofia standing at the gate in her nightdress with her keys in her hand, and the shopkeeper's wife from the second floor crossing herself in the doorway, and the boys from the fourth floor watching the car with their faces full of the terrible appetite of boys of fourteen, and Helena went past all of them with her head up and her eyes straight ahead, and got into the back of the car between two men in plain clothes, and said, in German, to the driver, as a thing that cost her nothing: "The violin on the bed is my father's, and it is worth a great deal of money. If it is still there when I come back, I will play at your wedding."

The car went down Hoża Street and turned left, and in the grey the front of the building on Aleja Szucha came up like the front of a bank, and it was, in the winter dark with the lamps still on in the arches and the sentry boxes, exactly what it had been before the war: the Ministry of Religious Affairs and Public Education, with the stone urns on the parapet, and a hundred and eleven steps along the entrance, and, in the basements, the cells.

They did not take her picture, and they did not take her name, at first. They took her along a corridor and down a flight and along another corridor into a cell four metres by two with a bench, a stove, a bucket, a window at the height of a man's shoulder with the glass painted grey, and the stink of the cell, which was the smell of a hundred years of Polish ministries, and they left her there for nine hours.

The cell was called a tram. She learned the name the next day, from the woman who was put in beside her: a woman of sixty with a face like a farm, who sat down on the bench with a great sigh and said, "Good afternoon. *Tramwaj*. Because we come in, and we wait, and we go out, and there is no timetable. And you can hear everything

through that pipe." She pointed with her chin at the fat iron pipe that ran up through the corner of the cell, from the cellar to the roof. "Everything. If you are clever, you learn more from the pipe than from the Germans. What are you in for?"

"I don't know."

"They never tell you. That's the first thing they do not tell you; the first thing they do tell you is the name of your home town, to make you think they know everything." The woman settled herself, and pressed her hands together, and shut her eyes. "I am Krysia Zaremba. My husband has a workshop on Chmielna, radiators; my son went to the market on the twenty-second of December with a sack of flour and did not come back; I went to the police to ask about him and they kept me, because I asked twice. Now we are seven. There is a girl in the next cell who is a scout, and a doctor from Ochota who has not spoken for two days, and a woman who is nothing at all, from the country, who does not even know how she got here. Sleep when you can. They wake people at night; that is the trick of this building, the night, and the lamps."

At eleven o'clock at night she was taken up one floor and along the corridor to a room with a table, three chairs, a cupboard, and a picture of the Führer over the table, on the second floor, where the interrogations were done; and the man behind the table was reading a file and eating a piece of chocolate.

"Pani Wojtera. Sit down." Obersturmführer Werner Dörffel looked at her across the table with his long pale face and his unshadowed reasonable eyes. He was in his tunic this time, with the collar tabs and the iron cross with the ribbon, and his hair was combed wet, and he looked, in a way that no one who saw him in the street could have imagined, like a man who had come to work early and was

pleased with the morning. “You have been here nine hours and nobody has touched you, and I want to say at the beginning: nobody is going to touch you, unless you make a wall for them to break, and you are too intelligent to make a wall. We are going to be reasonable, and I am going to tell you the truth, which is more than the File is going to do, and then we are going to drink some coffee, because my tea was confiscated by the Army Ordnance Office in November and I am reduced to coffee like a Frenchman. Do you take sugar?”

“No.”

“Neither do I.” He pushed the chocolate aside and opened the file, and went through it with one finger as if he were checking the entries in a ledger: “Helena Wojtera, born Warsaw 1910; conservatory in Munich, 1931 to 1933, quite a good student, and I say that as a man who was dragged to the piano as a boy for nine years and remembers nothing but the smell of the keys; out in 1933, no reason given; Warsaw since 1933, gave music lessons, employed since May 1943 at the Wehrmacht hospital laundry on Wiejska Street; unmarried; one child, Maria Anna, born 3 December 1933, in the labour reserve of the Wehrmacht commandant’s office, presently quartered in the sorting room at the Ostbahn depot, and, I am obliged to tell you, that is a favour — a child of nine on the reserve of a Wehrmacht office, well fed, living in a heated barrack; there are four hundred thousand Polish children in the General Government who would call it paradise.”

“You have my file,” Helena said. “You do not need me.”

“That is what everyone says, and it is never true, and I will show you why.” Dörffel turned a page. “In June, a doctor of the Institute for Racial Hygiene examined you and made a note: *correspondence checked — none*. He meant, of course, that there is no correspondence between your

ear and your daughter's, which is a fact about ears and nothing else; but a fact is a nail, and a good interrogator is a man with a hammer. Then in October the file of that same doctor received a letter from a Generalmajor a.D. in Brandenburg, dated, mine to delight in, 1933, signed by your late father, Stanisław Wojtera, engineer, of Warsaw, and directed to the father of the officer who is presently the Referent for Labour Deployment at the Wehrmacht commandant's office in this city: a letter in which your father wrote that his daughter had refused to marry a German, that his daughter's refusal was final, and that the Major's family would oblige him by not writing and by not sending money. It is in the folder at the Institute. It has been in the folder since 1933, because the Security Service in Munich kept a copy, and their copy went into the file, and the file came to Warsaw after the General Government was created. Do you know what that means, Pani Wojtera?"

"That my father was a fool," Helena said, "and that the Reich keeps paper like a nation of shopkeepers."

Dörffel laughed out loud, and it was a real laugh, short and dry, and it made the room worse.

"It means," he said, "that in this file the question of your daughter's father has an answer that I have not yet proved and do not need to prove to anybody but myself. But we are not here about the father. We are here about the Major." He closed the file and looked at her with his unshadowed eyes. "On the nineteenth of April 1943, the SS began to destroy the Jewish quarter of this city. On the twentieth of April, Major Friedrich von Brandt requisitioned two hundred metres of rope and sixty tarpaulins from the Wehrmacht stores in Warsaw for a work detachment at the Gęsiówka, which was routine and correct. On the twenty-third of April he transferred eleven Polish workers out of the labour office's transport for the Reich, by

telephone, at four in the morning, which was not routine and was not correct, and the eleven men are alive and one of them is a cousin of a man in the Home Army, and I know this because I had a man in the labour office from the beginning of the year. On the twentieth of May he signed a disposition that took a nine-year-old girl off a transport list. On the fifth of June he began buying coffee in the name of a police fund at a transit camp, which means he is paying. In August he moved a child from Szucha's custody back into Wehrmacht reserve on a medical technicality, and there is not a person in this building, or in the Arbeitsamt, or in the Ostbahn who has ever seen a German officer do such a thing, and there are people in this building who are paid to notice such things." He folded his hands. "The Major is not a criminal in the ordinary sense. He is a man of the old Prussian kind who has walked into this war slowly, one paper at a time, and every paper has been smaller than the last excuse; and at the end of that path there is a wall, and the name on the wall will not be yours, Pani Wojtera; it will be his; and there is nothing on earth that will save either of you except the truth, told early, to me."

"So it is true," Helena said. "You do not want me."

"I do not want you at all. Look at you." He said it without contempt, as a fact of inventory. "You are a music teacher from Hoża Street with a violin and a forged aunt in the country. You are worth four weeks of my department's time and then a transport to Ravensbrück, and the cost of transporting you is more than you are worth, and I am a man with a budget. The Major is worth a great deal." Dörffel leaned back. "Here is the arrangement, and you will not like it and you will consider it and you will take it, and I will tell you exactly why you will take it. You will sign a statement, in your own hand, of the following: that Friedrich von Brandt, Major, of the Wehrmacht

commandant's office in Warsaw, is the father of your daughter; that you have concealed this since 1933; and that you have been rewarded for the concealment by the removal of your daughter from transport lists and by sums of money. You will name two occasions on which he gave you money. You will name the officer in whose presence he removed your daughter from the list — there is a young lieutenant in his office, a good Catholic boy from Pforzheim, and I want his name in the statement, because a second witness in a case of this kind is the end of a career and a life. And in return: your daughter is entered in the file of the Zentrale für Kinderfürsorge, that is, she leaves the labour reserve and goes to the home on Krakowskie Przedmieście, and she is fed, and she is not transported; and you are held here under investigation, which is a great deal better than being transported; and in the spring, when the case has been disposed of, you may be exchanged for a German civilian from the internment camp at Lublin — I have four such exchanges pending, they are done all the time."

Helena sat with her hands in her lap and looked at him.

"You are asking me," she said slowly, "to write a page that will hang a man."

"I am asking you to write a page that will hang a traitor," Dörffel said. "There is no difference in the paper and a great difference in the accounting."

"And if I refuse?"

"Then you go to Pawiak, and your case is closed, and the child goes back to Skaryszewska; and the SS does not care about ears and blood as much as the Institute does, and in the spring they will use her on the ramps at the Ostbahn, because there is a labour shortage, and a child of nine on the ramps is a child of nine who will not see ten." He looked at her without malice. "Do not decide tonight. I am not a

man who wants the answer from the mouth of a person who has been awake for twenty-one hours; it is a bad foot to start on. Go back to the tram and sleep, and I shall send you coffee with sugar, and in three days we shall talk about the statement in my office with a stenographer and a Pole from the prosecutor's office; and the coffee is not a bribe. The coffee is what we give to persons of quality, because there are so few of them here."

She was in the tram for three days.

The pipe in the corner of the cell taught her the building in the way Krysia Zaremba had promised. She learned the times of the interrogations by the sound of the boots in the corridor above; she learned to know the difference between the sound of a man being beaten and the sound of a man being talked to; she learned the two sentences that came through the pipe more often than any other in Aleja Szucha, and they were *I don't know* and *I have told you everything*, and she learned that the second was almost always a lie and the first was almost always the truth.

On the second day they brought the girl from the scouts into her cell for half a day, because the cell next door was needed, and the girl was twenty years old and had been beaten across the soles of the feet, and she lay on the bench and told Helena, in a whisper, without any self-pity at all, all the details of the boy she had been in love with, whose name was Tadeusz, and who had been shot in the forest in the autumn; and in the evening, when they took her away, she said, "If you get out, tell my mother I said nothing — tell her I said nothing, on my honour," and Helena said, "I will tell her," and the girl said, "She lives at Grójecka 107, third courtyard, the door with the bicycle," and Helena said, "I know," and the girl went away and did not come back, and Helena, alone with the pipe, learned the next morning that the girl's name was on the list of the

people who had been shot at the wall in the ruins of the ghetto the night before, and that the list was read out in the camp office, and that the reading of the list was how the building told itself what it had done.

On the third day the unmarked van took her across the city to Pawiak.

It went slowly, because of the snow, and she sat on the bench inside with the small high window and saw the city through it in strips: the snow on the tram wires, the closed shops, the people with their collars up, the boy with the sledge, the long queue at the Kurier Warszawski stand, the queue for the release of the *Volksdeutsche* at the corner of Królewska, the two men in the doorway of the Rialto with their hands in their pockets and their hats down — and at the corner of the Rialto she saw, through the small window of the van, the man with his chin in his collar, standing in a doorway with a newspaper, in the snow, in his good coat, looking at the van going by; and he saw her, and he knew her, and he did not move; and Helena Wojtera looked at him through the window of the van and did the only thing that a woman in her position could do, and it was not to scream and not to weep: she smiled at him, and lifted two fingers off the bench in a little salute, and held his eyes with hers until the van turned the corner into Dzielna Street.

Pawiak was on Dzielna Street and had been the biggest prison in Poland since 1835 and it was, when the van went in through the gate between the two kennels of the Gestapo dogs, the biggest prison in Europe by number of prisoners per man; and it was in the hands of the Security Police since 1939, and the cells were as they had been built, and the rules were not as they had been built, and the women's wing was called Serbia, because a Pole will give a name to everything, and the name had been invented in 1939 by a

woman who had been in the Serbian campaign, and it had stuck.

They registered her at the desk: name, age, address, sentence — *in Untersuchung*, under investigation, which is the category that has no term and no end — and they took her watch and her money and her wedding ring, which she did not have, and her mother's ring, which they did not find because it was in the hem of the coat, and they put her in a cell in Serbia with six other women, and there was a plank bed, a blanket, a window with bars and no glass and boards over it, and a wheel with the number of the cell, and one of the women had a baby of four months.

. . .

Serbia — the first week

The women's wing at Pawiak was on the left of the yard, above the workshops, and it had been built for four hundred and in January 1944 it held eleven hundred, and the arithmetic of eleven hundred women in four hundred places had been solved by the Germans in the standard way, which was to make each cell hold what it would hold and to forbid the guards to look in.

Cell 165 in Serbia had six bunks and eleven women.

They were, in the order in which Helena learned them: Krysia Zaremba, who had come across from Szucha in the same van and who had become, in three days, the person who knew everything; a teacher of French from the school on Młynarska, who was fifty and had been in Pawiak since October and who had made a calendar out of a strip of wallpaper and a piece of charcoal; a woman of about thirty who did not give her name and who had a baby of four months and had been arrested at the gate of the ghetto in 1942 while carrying a package, and who was called, by everyone, *the mother of the small one*, because it was not

safe to use names and because the small one was the most important person in the cell; two sisters from the country who had been caught hiding a man from the forest; a girl of twenty who had been a sales assistant on Nowy Świat and who cried every night for eleven nights and after that stopped crying and was, from the twelfth night, the hardest person in the room; and four women whose business nobody had established, because in Pawiak the rule was that a woman told you her village and her crime and never her name, and the crime was usually the same crime, which was food, or paper, or the fact of having a son.

At seven in the morning the cell door opened and the bucket was emptied and the bread came; at noon there was a soup of swede and water, sometimes with a piece of horse; at four there was the second roll call; at six, in winter, the lights went out and the cell went on existing in the dark, and the dark was when the women talked, because the dark was the only time in the whole of the prison when they were not being counted.

Helena learned the rules in three days.

Rule one: a name is a coin that you spend once. Rule two: the wall of the washroom in the basement is the newspaper of Serbia, and the newspaper is written in scratched letters and there are, on any given morning, between forty and ninety names on it, and every woman who goes down with her can reads the wall, and the ones whose men are on the wall learn it there, and afterwards they stand for a moment with their hand flat against the plaster, which is the only funeral in Warsaw. Rule three: the Patronat.

She learned about the Patronat on the second day, when the door of the cell opened, and a woman of about fifty in a grey skirt and a knitted jacket came in with a canvas bag and looked round the cell the way a woman looks round a

kitchen she has come to work in.

"New one," the woman said. "Warsaw? Music teacher?"

"Yes."

"Zaremba's told me. I am Danuta Wierzbicka; I am the Patronat, which means I am nothing and I am the only thing in this prison that is not German. This"—she took out of the bag, one by one, and put into Helena's hands—"is a spoon, because you do not own a spoon, and it is a crime to have no spoon; this is soap, half a piece, which you keep in your shoe, and if you wash with it in front of the others you will not have it in the morning; this is a pencil two centimetres long, which is worth more in this building than the soap; and this is a piece of paper, which is the real gift, because in Pawiak paper is the currency. Write to your people. Address it to the Patronat office, Marszałkowska; the Patronat is permitted, under the German rules, to receive and forward letters for prisoners, and it is permitted because it is useful to the Germans, and it is useful to us." She sat down on the end of the bunk. "Now. Two things. The first: what is your case?"

"Under investigation. Szucha. The Obersturmführer, Department Four."

"Then you will be taken to Szucha by the van twice a week, or you will not be taken at all, which is worse; and you will be fed here at the rate of the prison and after three months you will not be able to stand up in the morning. So: the second thing. Have you people outside?"

"I have a child."

Danuta Wierzbicka looked at her for a long moment, and Helena saw, very clearly, the thing that made this woman dangerous and useful in equal measure: she had heard the sentence a thousand times, in a thousand forms, and she had learned to work with what a sentence contained rather than with what it felt like.

“Where?”

“Ostbahn depot. Praga. The labour reserve of the Wehrmacht commandant’s office.” Helena said it flatly, because in cell 165 in January 1944 there was no advantage in a lie, only in a price. “There is a parcel that comes to the depot gate on Sundays — thread, pencils, soap. It comes from a German office clerk. If the Patronat can get a letter to the depot office, into the box for the labour reserve, addressed to the child Wojtera, and if it can come back, then name your price to me and I will pay it in labour, not in money: I can read and write German and I have been a courier on the Aryan side, and I am not going to be here forever.”

“You are a remarkable person to meet on your second day,” said the woman from the Patronat. “Very well. The price is this: you will help with the small one at night, and you will teach the girl from Nowy Świat to read, because she cannot, and if I am ever taken away you will go on doing it, and in return you will have your letter, one page, once a month, in German, and the reply will come through the same hand. And I will tell you the truth about your case for nothing, because you have the face of a woman who is going to find it out anyway, and because nobody told me mine.” She stood up. “An investigation under Szucha that does not end in six weeks does not end at all. It does not go to trial. It goes on, and you are moved to a camp when the transport list wants a hundred bodies, and the only thing you have in your hand is the fact that somebody in the Security Police wants something from you and cannot have it yet. Make that last. Every day you are alive is a day that the man who wants the thing from you wants it a little more. And child: the ones who last are not the strong ones. They are the ones who have decided the date to live till. Fix a date. Mine was my daughter’s wedding, and my daughter

was married in 1941, and I have never once been able to think of a new date, and I have been in this prison for four years, so do not ask me how it works."

. . .

She lay on the plank in the dark on the night of the tenth of January 1944, and listened to the cage in the corridor and the changing of the guard, and looked at the ceiling, and thought about the two doors of the building on Aleja Szucha and the man who had offered her coffee and the girl from the scouts and the man with his chin in his collar in the doorway of the Rialto; and she came, at some time in the small hours, to the thing that she had been feeling her way towards for three days in the tram like a woman feeling along a wall in a dark room, and the thing was this:

He had not once asked her about the underground. He had not asked her about the leaflets or the parcels or the boys or the routes or the desk on Wilcza Street, and he had a file on her that any policeman in the General Government would have paid a month's salary for. He had not asked, because he did not want it, and he did not want it because the underground was not his business; and the only thing in the whole file that was his business was a man in a grey tunic in a room on Nowy Świat with a signature and a coffee fund and a nine-year-old girl in a labour reserve; and the reason that Dörffel had not hurt her in three days, the reason that the SS in the corridor had brought her coffee with sugar and a cushion for the bench, the reason that a woman with a Polish name and a forged aunt in the country was still alive in Warsaw in January 1944 was that she was not a prisoner and not a suspect and not a Pole.

She was a door.

And a door is not tortured and a door is not killed and a door is not sent to Ravensbrück: a door is oiled, and tried,

and left standing in a house that a man is going to walk into on a night when he has no lamp; and so long as she stayed a door, and did not become a wall, she would live; and the man on the other side of her — the one with the grey eyes and the terrible careful hands and the coffee bought in the name of a police fund, the one who had stood in a courtyard in the rain in September 1933, and had not come up the stairs, and had gone home, and had married Erika von Wense — had, without ever being told, without ever asking, and by the simple process of remaining, for eleven minutes at a time, a person who could not walk away, signed the warrant for the two of them: him, and her, and, if the men in that building had their way, the child.

She turned her face to the wall of the cell in Serbia and shut her eyes and said, out loud, in Polish, to the plaster, in a voice that was almost nothing:

“Bar eleven. From the top. Slowly.”

And then she slept, because sleep was the only weapon a prisoner had, and because she had a great deal to do in the morning, which included staying alive for a child in a heated barrack at the Ostbahn depot, and finding, somewhere inside the hands of the men who owned her, one single thread that led out.

CHAPTER TWELVE

The Girl in the Laundry

Praga — January 1944

The barrack was brick, not wood, because before the war it had been the Ostbahn's stores office, and it had a stove in the middle and twenty-two bunks and a window at each end, and if you kept your place in the bunk next to the stove you were warm all night, and if you did not you were cold all night, and Marysia Wojtera had the bunk next to the stove because she had been given it in September for a reason that she had not understood at the time and understood perfectly by January.

The reason was that she could count.

The work was the trays of small brass fittings: the pieces came into the shed in wooden boxes, stamped, still sharp at the edges, and each box had a ticket with a number on it, and in the trays each fitting had its own little compartment, and the German foreman, Herr Bader, a man of fifty in a brown coat who had lost the top joint of his ring finger in a press in Essen in 1936, would come down the row twice a day with a wooden tally and ask how many trays, and the girls who could not answer in German correctly would be moved to the boxes with the heavy pieces, and the girls who could answer would stay at the fine work, and the fine work was in a warm corner of the shed.

Marysia could say, in German, without hesitating and without looking at her hands: *Einundzwanzig volle Trays, Herr Bader.* One-and-twenty full trays. And *vier Stück fehlen* — four pieces missing — when four pieces were

missing, which made Herr Bader look at her twice the first time, and after that he only grunted, which was, in the mathematics of the Ostbahn depot in Praga, a promotion.

There were twenty-two children in the barrack in January 1944. The youngest was five and could not lift the trays; the oldest was fourteen and was called Irena and had a cough that would not go, and she slept in the bunk on the far side of the stove and did the best work in the shed because her hands were quick and her eyes were good. There were seven girls from the camp at Skaryszewska and eleven from the ruins of the little town at Zamość and four who had been in the cellar of the labour office at Wilcza Street for a month and had been brought to the depot in December with no explanation; and there were two boys of eleven who worked the hand-cart and one of them, whose name was Józek, had arrived in December with a bandage round his head and had not spoken for eleven days, and Marysia had given him half her bread on the third night and had not given him any since, because a person who is given something every day stops being able to get it for himself, and because Pani Zofia in the courtyard at Hoża 14 had said that once, to a beggar, out loud, and it had stayed with her.

At six in the morning the bell; at half past six the soup, which was turnip and millet and sometimes a piece of horse; at seven the roll in the yard by the watch shed, standing in two rows with your hands at your sides, counted by the Ukrainian guard, whose name was Didko and who was from a village near Ternopil and who called the children *the little ones* and who had once given Marysia a sugar lump for finding his glove under a tray in the shed; from half past seven until twelve and from one until six, the shed; and at six, the soup again, and the bread of two hundred and fifty grammes, which was more than the

ration in the city, because the Ostbahn was an armaments enterprise and its labour reserve was fed at a rate that had been decided by a German official in Berlin on a printed sheet, and which had, in the whole of Poland in the winter of 1944, this one consequence: that a child could look at a German soldier in the street and know, with absolute precision, that she ate better than he did.

But what the child could not know on the printed sheet, and what she learned in the barrack, was the rest of the arithmetic.

The rest of the arithmetic was that on the seventh of December a girl called Bronka, from the second bunk on the right, who was nine and had a grandmother in Wola, had put her hand into the press to push back a tray that had gone crooked, and the press had gone down and taken off the ends of three fingers; and the German foreman had sent for the doctor's assistant, who had put a dressing and a paper figure round her hand and had said she would heal; and in January Bronka was still there, at the end of the shed, sorting the big washers with one hand, because a girl who is injured in an armaments enterprise does not go home, because there is no home, and because the paper figure round her hand is a form that keeps the enterprise's record clean.

The rest of the arithmetic was that two of the children had disappeared in November, in the middle of the night, without any noise, and Herr Bader had not looked up from his trays in the morning; and that when Marysia had once asked Didko where they had gone, Didko had said, in his Ukrainian, without any malice, "To the Reich, to work on a farm, it's better there, they're fed there"; and that Irena, who was fourteen, who knew everything, had said afterwards, "They're not on farms. They were on the list for the homes. The SS came for them."

The rest of the arithmetic was the letters.

On Sunday afternoons, in the hour after the soup, you could write a letter, one page, and it went into the box outside the depot office and it went, if the guard took it, to wherever you addressed it, and there was a rule in fine print that letters from the labour reserve must be in German; and there was no rule at all about what a child could do with the two stub pencils that came in once a month in the box from the Arbeitsamt with the same quantity of paper. So Marysia wrote, every Sunday, in the small, careful, upright letters she had learned from her mother, and the letter was in German, and it said:

Für die Mutter. Ich bin gesund. Ich arbeite bei der Ostbahn. Es ist warm im Saal. Bitte schicken Sie mir den Bleistift und den Faden. Deine Tochter, Maria.

For my mother. I am well. I work at the Ostbahn. It is warm in the hall. Please send me a pencil and thread. Your daughter, Maria.

It was a good letter, and it was the third version of the letter. The first version had been in Polish, and it had been taken by the guard and not sent, and Marysia had learned from that. The second version had said, at the end, *Ich vermisse dich sehr* — I miss you very much — and it had been returned to her two weeks later, unsent, with a mark in pencil by a German clerk, and the mark was a small line labelled *unnecessary*, so she had learned that too.

The third version, the one that went every Sunday, was the letter of a girl who was well and warm and had no feelings at all: and it was sent, and it reached her mother wherever her mother was, whether it be the laundry on Wiejska Street or the cell in Serbia at the prison on Dzielna Street, because the German post, in the middle of the greatest catastrophe in the history of the world, was, god help them all, efficient; and every third or fourth Sunday an

envelope came back to the depot office for her, and the envelopes were also in German, and the safe ones said the same six things:

Meine Tochter. Ich bin gesund. Arbeite gut und sei ruhig. Iss alles. Ich bin immer bei dir. Deine Mutter.

My daughter. I am well. Work well and be quiet. Eat everything. I am always with you. Your mother.

They were all the same, those letters; and they were all in her mother's hand, and the handwriting was not well, and once the paper smelled of lye and once, in December, it had a brown marker on the corner and the word *Krankenhaus* at the top, which Marysia did not understand until Irena explained that it meant that the letter had been written in a hospital; and Marysia did not cry, because a person who cries in the barrack is a person who gets looked at, and instead she folded the three safe letters and the two with the hospital marks on them into the lining of her jacket, on the left side, over her heart, which was where her mother had told her, in May, in the yard at Skaryszewska, that a thing of your own should always be carried.

And there was Sunday, and there was the shed, and there was the cold, and there was the counting, and there was, in the middle of January 1944, the day of the two visitors, which is the day that must be described properly, because it is the axle on which the whole of this part of the book turns.

. . .

The yard, and the man who knew her father

The depot yard was sixty metres wide and three hundred long, and it was, in the winter of 1944, the busiest place in Warsaw that no Pole talked about: the Ostbahn's works at Praga repaired the rolling stock of the German armies in

the east, and the yard had eight kilometres of sidings and four long sheds and a coaling stage and a turntable, and at any hour of the day or night there were, in that yard, between two and six hundred Polish workmen and forty Germans and two hundred wagons, and the wagons went east empty and came back full and went east full and came back empty, and everybody in the yard knew, by the beginning of 1944, exactly what a railway was.

It was in the yard, on a Sunday in January, that Marysia met Wiktor Sadowski, in a manner that was not an accident.

Because on Sundays, between the soup and the letters, the children of the reserve were allowed — in the way that children in a labour reserve were allowed anything, which is to say not permitted, but not prevented — to walk along the fence at the eastern end of the yard, where the coal was, and to watch the trains.

She had gone there with Irena and Józek on the second Sunday of January, and the three of them had stood at the fence with their collars up, looking at a train come in: thirty wagons of coal from the mines at Zagłębie, with a Polish brakeman in a padded jacket standing on the last wagon's step with the cold making his nose run, and a German railway guard in the brake van with the stove going and the window slid open; and Irena had said, into the cold, without any expression at all: "That's how they'll take me."

"Take you where?"

"Łódź. Or further. On a train like that; except not with coal. My cousin was taken in November from the camp at Skaryszewska, twenty-nine of them, with two guards and a paper for each child, and they went in a wagon with the doors wired and the addresses chalked above the doors, and the chalk said *Konstantynów* and the paper, everybody knows, said *Arbeitserziehungslager*, and you know what

happened to my cousin?" Irena's eyes were on the train. "Nothing has happened to my cousin. There is no letter and there is no grave and there is no list, and that is what happens: nothing. That is the thing they do, they make it be nothing."

"Then how do you know she went to Łódź?"

"Because Didko told me, because Didko is a Ukrainian from a village with a mother in it, and he has a nose for the ones who are going to be sent, and when the wagon came in, he told me to go and stand at the fence, and he came and stood next to me, and he watched it go, and he said, in his Polish, 'Look at it, girl, because it is better to look at a thing you cannot stop than not to look at it, and because your cousin asked me — she asked me at the ramp, in November, with her hands tied, she asked me to make you look at the train.'" Irena blew on her fingers. "That's Didko. He is twelve years older than me and he is a guard, and he gives sugar lumps to children, and he stood next to me by this fence and we watched her wagon go out of the yard, and then he went back to the shed and I stood here for another hour."

Marysia stood at the fence and looked at the coal train, and thought about a thing that had happened, once, in the shed, when the water pipe had frozen and a small boy had come in with a bucket and had put the bucket down and said, in the Polish of the country, to nobody, "*They went east, the ones in the third wagon*," and then had picked up his bucket and gone out.

The whistle went. The train pulled away east along the river flats, and the three children stood and watched the wagons go until the brake van's stove was a red dot in the grey, and then a voice behind them said, in Polish:

"That is the Warsaw–Mińsk line, and it does not go to Łódź."

He was a man of about fifty-five in a padded workman's jacket with a leather cap, and he was standing at the fence six metres away with a cigarette in his hand, not looking at them at all, looking at the departing train, and he had come up without any of them hearing him, which was a thing that men did in the Warsaw of 1944, and which children learned to notice.

"The train to Łódź goes north out of the yard on the roundabout line," he said, "and it goes out in the middle of the night and it comes back empty, and it is one of the things in this yard that nobody talks about, and children who go and look at it and write down the numbers of the wagons are children who lose a finger and get moved to the packing shed. My name is Wiktor. I am a fitter on number three shed, and I had the honour of knowing your father."

Marysia looked at him, and her heart did a thing that she had taught it, over the last year, not to do.

"My father is dead," she said. "Adam Wójcik. He was a railwayman, and he died before I was born."

"Yes," the man said. "So I am told." He dropped the cigarette and stood on it, and looked at her, for the first time, and his face was a workman's face, grey and seamed and careful, the face of a man who has spent forty years looking at metal and knows exactly what will break and where. "The one I knew was Stanisław Wojtera, an engineer on the Wilno line, who had a wife from Piaseczno and one daughter who played the violin, and who died in September 1939 helping to dig the anti-tank ditch at Okęcie, and who was the best hand with a worn axle that ever came out of the workshops at Wilno; and before the war, in the yard at Wilno, in 1931, he showed me the photograph of his daughter in a green dress with a violin, in a garden, with a laurel tree." He straightened up. "I have been at this depot four years and I have heard the name

Wojtera in the reserve detail every month on the paper, and I am not a brave man and I am not a fool, and I am not going to speak to you again; I am going to speak to the coal yard. But I want you to know that you are not nobody. The man whose name you carry was a good engineer, and the woman who taught you to count was a girl in a green dress in a garden, and if the day comes when the shed's counting papers can do a thing for you, then papers are counted by men, and men can be counted too. Good afternoon, girls. Mind the coal."

He walked away along the fence and did not look back, and Irena said, under her breath, in the voice of a person who has just seen a small and genuine miracle:

"What was that?"

"That," Marysia said, "was a man who knew my grandfather," and stood looking after him for a long time, with her hands in her sleeves, at a fence at the end of a railway yard in Prague in the winter of 1944, with the whole of her life in front of her and six people in the world who cared whether she lived, one of them a German lady with pale eyelashes, one of them a guard from Ternopil who gave children sugar, one of them a fitter with a leather cap, one of them in a cell in Serbia, one of them a boy who had not spoken for eleven days, and one of them a Major in grey who had taken a pencil from behind her ear and put it back.

. . .

The first visitor was the German lady from the office on Nowy Świat.

She came every second Tuesday, in the afternoon, by tram from the city, with a leather case and a list, and she was young, perhaps twenty-eight, with pale eyelashes and a long neck and a grey coat with the collar up; and she came to the depot office to compare the labour returns of the

armaments enterprise with the schedules of the commandant's office, and she did it in the depot office with Herr Bader standing at her shoulder being agreeable and the depot's clerk hovering; and every visit, at the end of it, she needed a girl to carry the certified copies of the returns from the office to the depot's gate, because she was not permitted, as a woman, to walk through the depot's yard alone, and so the yard guard's instructions said, and so she did.

She chose, every visit, the same girl.

And in the fifty metres between the office door and the depot gate, walking at a measured pace in the slush with a bundle of certified copies in her arms and the German lady beside her, the girl was given, in the voice of an official discussing a discrepancy in a return, the news of the world.

Your mother is alive. She is in the prison on Dzielna Street. Do not ask anybody about her. Do not send letters to the prison; the letters are read, and a letter from you to her is a mark on the file.

The rest of the children from the camp at Skaryszewska went to a factory at Łódź in November. Twenty-nine of them. Do not ask about them either.

Eat the bread. The bread in the depot is counted; the bread in the parcel is not. There is a parcel at the gate on Sundays, for the girl Wojtera, with thread and pencils and a piece of soap; that is not from your mother and you are not to say who it is from, and if you say it, it stops.

You can read German, cannot you. Yes. Then read the tickets in the shed and never say you can. A person who can read the tickets is a person who is useful; a person who is useful goes to the Reich. A person who cannot read, and cannot be trusted with any paper, stays where she is and cleans the trays. Which would you rather be?

Good. Then that is the whole of your education, and it is not much, but it is more than Goebbels gives to the children of this city.

On the last visit, at the gate, in the middle of January, with the sleet coming down and the yard guard watching from his box, the pale girl in the grey coat had said, in the same flat voice, with her eyes on the gate:

"On Friday the Referat makes its inspection of the depot. There will be an officer. He will be the Major. You will be presented to him as the best of the reserve detail, because Herr Bader has to show that his detail can count and read, and he will choose you because you can say 'einundzwanzig Trays' and the other girls cannot." She had taken the copies back into her arms and turned away, and then, over her shoulder, in the last two seconds before the gate, she had said the only sentence in eleven months that had anything in it at all: "Girl. Whatever you do on Friday, do not be afraid of him. He is the only man in this whole apparatus who will not eat you. Do not tell anybody I said that either."

That was Tuesday. On Friday the yard was swept, which in the Ostbahn depot in January meant that the snow was pushed into two long ridges along the fence, and the shed floor was swept and the trays were levelled and the children were washed in the washroom with cold water and the ends of their fingers were blue, and at eleven o'clock in the morning the cars came in through the depot gate.

There were three men with the Major. There was Herr Bader, and there was a fat oberzahlmeister in a leather coat with a laugh like a door, and there was a young lieutenant with a face like a choirboy who looked at the shed the way a person looks at a place where he has been told he will find a thing that will disappoint him; and there was the Major, who was tall, and grey, and whose cap left a red line across his forehead because he had been riding in

the car with the heater on, and who walked into the long shed with the brass trays in the racks and stopped at the end of the aisle and looked down the whole length of the room, the way a man looks at a thing he has built and is going to have to break.

Herr Bader presented the detail: twenty-two children standing at their trays with their hands at their sides.

The Major went down the row. He stopped at Irena, whose cough was in her chest, and asked her how long she had been there, and looked at the white of her eye, and said nothing; he stopped at Józek, whose head was bandaged no longer, and asked him his name and where he came from, and Józek said nothing at all, and the young lieutenant laughed, and the Major did not; and then he came to the fourth tray on the left, and stopped, and looked down at a girl of ten with a rag tied over her hair and a stub pencil behind her ear.

“Your name.”

“Maria Anna Wojtera.”

“Your work.”

“Feinsortierung, Herr Major. Ich zähle die Trays. Einundzwanzig volle Trays heute.”

The Major looked at the tray; and then he did something that made the fat Oberzahlmeister raise an eyebrow, which was that he took off his glove, and picked one of the brass fittings out of the tray with two fingers, and turned it over, and looked at it, and put it back in its compartment exactly as it had been, and said, in Polish, quietly, so that only the girl, and perhaps the young lieutenant, could hear: “Has anybody taught you to sort like that?”

“My mother taught me to count,” the girl said, in Polish, and then, remembering, added, in German: “Herr Major.”

And the Major said, in German, in the voice of a man dictating a report: “It is good work. It is work which the

enterprise requires to be maintained, and the persons of this detail are to be maintained in it, and the returns are to continue to my office." And then, still in German, still in the voice of the report, with no change in his face at all, he said: "Also there is a thing which has interested me. The child of the reserve has a musical name. Is there music in this shed?"

The room went quiet. Behind them, Herr Bader's mouth opened and shut.

"There is counting, Herr Major," Marysia said. "There is no music."

"Then there is a loss," said the Major, "since every German enterprise requires counting and no enterprise is improved by it. Stand straight." And he reached out and did the most ordinary thing in the world: he took the stub pencil from behind her ear and looked at it, and turned it over — it had been sharpened at both ends with a knife, and it was no longer than a joint of a finger — and he put it back behind her ear, and his knuckles brushed her hair, which was the first time a grown man had touched her head since the guard cut her plait off in the bath house in May.

And then, because she was ten years old and because she was tired and because she had been holding the whole of herself together for eight months, and because the hand smelled of soap and cold wool and boot leather from the car, and because a long time ago, in a room on the second floor at Hoża 14 with the piano tuned flat, a man used to lift her onto the stool by both hands under her arms, she said the word.

She said, "Papa."

In the long shed at the Ostbahn depot in Praga, in the middle of the inspection of the labour reserve of the Wehrmacht commandant's office in Warsaw, in January 1944, a child of ten looked up at a Major in a grey tunic and

said, quietly, in Polish, in the ordinary voice of a person making a report:

"*Papa*, the tray is empty, I have counted them all."

Nobody heard it. That was the mercy, and it lasted for about two seconds: Bader was three metres away and had the hearing of a man who had been a foreman in Essen, and did not know a word of Polish; the young lieutenant heard the sound of it and understood nothing and would remember it in March and say so, in a room with a desk lamp and a stenographer, in a different building; and the fat Oberzahlmeister heard nothing at all, because he was thinking about the customs clearance on a case of Polish vodka that was, at that moment, in the boot of the car.

But the Major heard it. The Major heard it the way a man hears a door close somewhere in a house he believed was empty; and his face did not move at all, and his hands did not move at all, and he stood in front of the tray of brass fittings and looked down at the girl for the length of three breaths, with the whole of his life going past him like the Ostbahn's wagons in the yard outside; and then he said, in German, in a clear, level, carrying voice, so that everybody in the shed could hear him:

"The detail is satisfactory. The persons are to be kept at work and kept in health. The Major will note it in the file."

And he turned and walked down the length of the shed and out into the snow of the yard, where the three cars stood steaming, and the whole shed let out its breath; and Herr Bader said, "Weiter, weiter," and the trays began to move again; and the girl did not cry, because a person who cries in the shed is a person who gets looked at.

She stood at the tray with the pencil behind her ear and the brass fittings going into their compartments in their long, even rows, and she thought about the word.

She was ten years old. She had been told, all her life, in a voice that was calm and level and final, that her father was Adam Wójcik, a railwayman, dead before she was born, and she had said it to the doctor from Posen and to the clerks and to the guards because her mother had told her to; and she was not so simple as to believe a thing only because she had been told it, because in this war she had watched the whole city be told things; and she had, in the last year, learned three facts that had no other explanation, and they were these.

One: that when she was taken to the room with the shutters, nobody hurt her, and a German doctor with soft hands gave her chocolate and told her she sang on pitch.

Two: that when the children of detail three were taken from Skaryszewska in November, she was not taken; and the list had had nineteen names on it and she was not on the list, and she had seen the list, because it was on the wall of the shed for two days with the German heading and she could read it.

Three: that a German Major had walked out of his way, in the snow, in the middle of an inspection, to take the pencil from behind her ear and put it back.

She fitted a brass fitting into a compartment, and then another, and then another, and she made, in the middle of the ninety-fifth tray of her life, the decision that a child makes in a war, which is to hold the two things at once, because holding both is the only way to stay alive: she would go on saying the name of the dead railwayman of Grodno, every time, exactly as her mother had taught her, because to say anything else was to break the one thing her mother had ever asked of her; and she would also, from that day, be watching the Major; and she would not tell her mother, because her mother was in the prison on Dzielna Street and there was nothing to tell, except that a man in a

grey tunic had touched her head in the snow, and that she had said a word to him that she had never said out loud to any living person on earth, and that nobody, in the whole German depot at Praga, had punished her for it; and that she had liked it, and was ashamed, and was glad.

She worked until six. She ate the soup and the bread, and put the two hundred grammes of bread away in her bunk against the morning, and lay down in the dark next to the stove with her mother's letters inside her jacket over her heart; and in the morning she was at the tray again before the bell, because that is what children in the labour reserve of the Wehrmacht at Warsaw did in January 1944, and while she worked she did a thing that she had told no one about, not her mother and not Irena, and it was this: in the corner of her bunk, where the boards met the wall and the mortar had fallen out and nobody could see, she had begun to keep a list, written on the good paper from the office that she was given to wrap the trays in, folded to the size of a stamp and hidden in the mortar.

On the list were the names of the children who had gone.

Bronka — 3 fingers — January Fela — Skaryszewska — took away with the camp list — August — I gave her the chocolate Irena's sister — Łódź — November Józek's brother — ? The two boys from Zamość — night — no names

and then, at the bottom of the sheet, in the afternoons when she was alone, in letters as small as she could make them, she wrote the names of the people who were still there, so that when they disappeared there would be somebody to know it:

Irena. Józek. Herr Bader's tally. Didko's sugar. The girl Kallman's cough. Me. Maria Anna Wojtera, daughter of Adam Wójcik, of Grodno, deceased 1933, and of Helena Wojtera of Hoża 14 in Warsaw, who is alive.